THURSDAY
September 24, 2026

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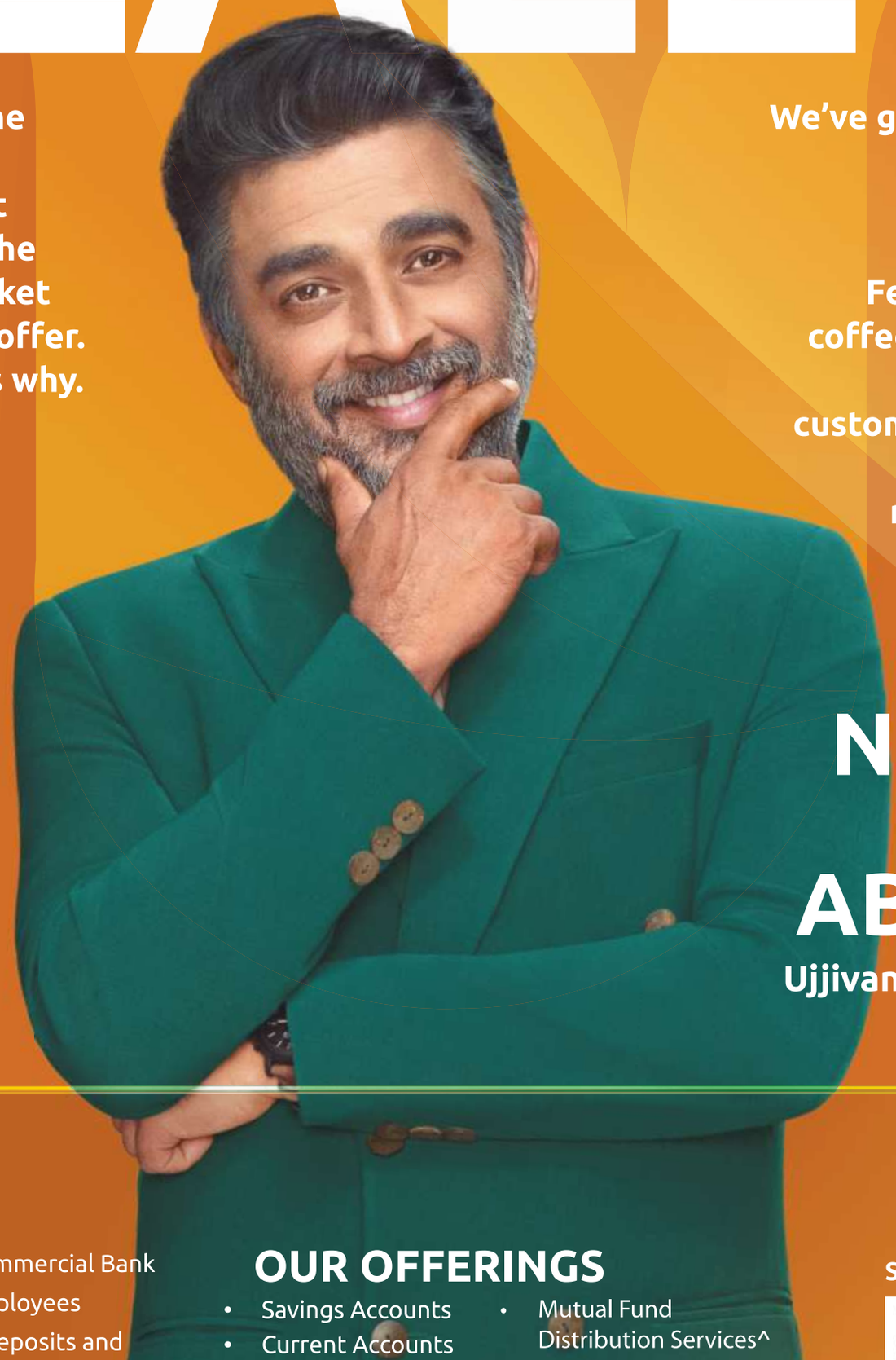
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OUR OFFERINGS

- Savings Accounts
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- Term Deposits
- Loans
- Co-branded Credit Cards
- Debit Cards
- Mutual Fund Distribution Services^
- Demat & Trading Solutions through our partner*
- NRI Services & Forex
- Ivory Programme
- Ujjivan Rewardz

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^*Mutual Fund investments and investment in securities market are subject to market risks, read all scheme/related documents carefully.
^Distributed by Ujjivan Small Finance Bank Ltd. – AMFI Registered Mutual Fund Distributor (ARN: 175676).
*Demat and Trading Account offered through SMC Global Securities Ltd. T&C Apply.
**Loan amounts starting at ₹6,000 to over ₹250 crore are available across distinct product categories. Eligibility criteria, loan amount, applicable interest rates and other terms vary by product. T&C Apply.
#Interest rates are subject to change. T&C Apply.

Data as of June 30, 2026.

900 208 2121 1800 208 2121

www.ujjivansfb.bank.in

Timings
DELHI

THURSDAY, SEP. 24		
RISE	06:10	SET 18:15
RISE	16:53	SET 03:40
FRIDAY, SEP. 25		
RISE	06:11	SET 18:14
RISE	17:24	SET 04:37
SATURDAY, SEP. 26		
RISE	06:11	SET 18:13
RISE	17:54	SET 05:36

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	36	25
Safdarjang	36	25
Palam	35	24

Delhi Palam Today
35ºC Morning will be pleasant with mist and haze.The weather will be dry. Day will be warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be comfortable.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
36ºC The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night will remain comfortable.

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THE HINDU
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ANDHRA PRADESH POWER COORDINATION COMMITTEE
VIDYUT SOUDHA : VIJAYAWADA

TENDER NOTICE

APPCC on behalf of the APDISCOMs inviting bids in single stage, two enveloped followed by e-RA through Bharat Electronic e-Tendering Portal vide **Tender No: APPCC/PSP-01/2026-27** for **Procurement of 500 MW Energy Storage Capacity (8 hours per day, with a maximum of 6 hours continuous discharge) from Pumped Storage Projects fully commissioned or part-commissioned with untied capacity in anywhere in India** through Competitive Bidding for a period of 5 years extendable for another period of 2 years with input power from APDISCOMs. The Interested and eligible applicants may participate in the bidding process through the ISN-ETS portal Date & availability of RFS document in Bharat Electronic e-Tendering Portal is after **24.09.2026** at **17:00 hrs.** The due date for submission of bids is **12.10.2026.** For complete details and tender access visit: **https://www.bharat-electronictender.com;** Ph: **9493120085**

R.O. No. GMCC/APTRANSCO/156/26-27

Sd/- Chief General Manager/APPCC
Power Purchase & Legal

BENGALURU METROPOLITAN TRANSPORT CORPORATION
Traffic Commercial Department, 2nd Floor, Shanthinagar TTMC, K.H. Road,Shanthinagar, Bengaluru-560 027.

No: BMTC/CO/TR/COM/1959/2087/2026-27 Date: 23.09.2026

TENDER NOTIFICATION NO: 24/2026-27
(Through e-Procurement Platform)

Bengaluru Metropolitan Transport Corporation invites bids from eligible persons/ agencies for the establishment, operation, and maintenance of Smart Parking Facilities on Revenue Sharing Model at Shanthinagar T.T.M.C MLCP and Kalasipalya Bus Station parking locations through the e-procurement platform.

Pre-Bid meeting date & time	**30.09.2026 at 11:30 am**	**Place: CTM(C)'s Chamber, 2nd Floor, Central Office, BMTC, Shanthinagar, Bengaluru-27.**
Last date & time for submission of bids is on	**27.10.2026 up to 17:00 hrs.**	
Opening of Technical bids is on	**28.10.2026 at 17:05 hrs.**	
Opening of Financial bids is on	**To be Intimated later**	

Further, EMD amount, measurement and all other necessary details in this regard can be obtained in the e-procurement portal **www.kppp.karnataka.gov.in** or by Contacting: **09240214000, 09240214001, 080-22483777 & 7760991222** or E-mail: **ctmc@mybmtc.com.**

Sd/- Chief Traffic Manager (Com) (Tender Inviting Authority)

TELANGANA STATE CIVIL SUPPLIES CORPORATION LIMITED
Regd. Office: 6-3-655/1/A, C S Bhavan, Somajiguda, Hyderabad -500 082.

NOTICE INVITING PROPOSALS

RFP Notice No.: TGSCSCL/PROC/VLTS/2026/01 **dated 23.09.2026**

Online bids are invited from eligible and experienced Service Providers for **selection of an Agency for integration of GPS devices installed on paddy-transporting vehicles with a Vehicle Location Tracking System (VLTS), enabling real-time tracking and integration with the State Procurement Portal (OPMS), on an SLA-linked per-trip basis, for a period of three (3) years from 01.10.2026 to 30.09.2029. Selection of the Service Provider shall be based on the lowest (L1) quoted Base Per-Trip Rate among the technically qualified bidders,** subject to the terms and conditions stipulated in the RFP.

The detailed **Request for Proposal (RFP)** containing the Scope of Work, eligibility and pre-qualification criteria, SLA requirements, terms and conditions, and prescribed proformas may be downloaded from the Telangana State e-Procurement Portal: **http://tender.telangana.gov.in**.

Contact: 7995050700 / 9704534627 / 9281423637 E-mail: **hoprocurement.tgscscl@gmail.com**

DIPR R.O.No.567-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:23.09.2026

Sd/-VC & Managing Director

Land Ports Authority of India, MHA
(Appointment of Member (Planning & Development) on deputation basis)

MHA has issued a vacancy circular dated 24th April, 2026 for filling up the post of Member (Planning & Development) with the last date of submission of applications being 23-05-2026. Now the last date is being extended up to 30-09-2026. For more details **please visit the website of Ministry of Home Affairs at http://mha.gov.in and LPAI at http://lpai.gov.in.**

cbc 19142/11/0014/2627

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD (B/R) DIVISION NO.1 SAGAR
PHONE No. 07582-222296 **E-mail:-eepwdsagar@mp.nic.in**
NIT No. 18/TC/2026-27 **SAGAR DATE 22/09/2026**

Online bids for the following works are invited from registered contractors and firms of repute fulfilling registration criteria :

S. No.	Tender Portal No.	Name of work	District	Probable Amount Contract (Rs. in)	Eranest Money Deposit (EMD) (in Rs.)	Cost of Bid Document (in Rs.)	Period of completion (in months i/c Rainy Season)	Remark
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1	**2026_ PWDRB_537626_1**	CONSTRUCTION OF AGRA TO NITARRI ROAD LENGTH-4.40 KM WITH ELECTRIFICATION WORK PAC 447.19 LAKH	Sagar	44719000	447190	15000	08 Months i/c Rainy Season	1st Call
2	**2026_ PWDRB_537627_1**	CONSTRUCTION OF SAGONI KHURD TO UMARIYA SEMRA ROAD [INCLUDING ELECTRIFICATION WORK (TOTAL LENGTH - 4.40 KM)] PAC 496.39 LACS	Sagar	49639000	496390	15000	08 Months i/c Rainy Season	1st Call
				94358000				

1 All details relating to the Bid Document (s) can be viewed and downloaded free of cost from the website. **http:// mptenders.gov.in**
2 Bid Document (s) can be purchased after making online payment of portal fees through Credit/Debit/Cash Card/ internet Banking.
3 The Bid Document (s) can be purchased only online from 23/09/2026 (time) 10.00 to 07/10/2026 time 17.30 Other key dates may be seen in Bid Data Sheet.
4 Amendment (s) to NIT, if any, shall be published on website only, and not in newspaper.

EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
G18965/26 **PWD (B/R) DIVISION NO.1 SAGAR**

HIMACHAL PRADESH PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT
INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)

The Executive Engineer, Bhoranj Division HPPWD, Bhoranj on behalf of Governor of H.P invites the Item rate/ Percentage rate bids, in electronic tendering system from the eligible class for the works as detailed below on the table:-

Sr. No.	Name of work	Estimated Cost (In Rs.)	Earnest Money (in Rs.)	Starting date for down-loading Bid	Deadline for submission of Bid
1.	Restoration of link road Bassi Bhareri Tatahar road Km 0/00 to 11/00 District Hamirpur (HP) (SH:-C/O R/wall , PCC U&V shape drain, cross drainage work (Under PDNA 2023)	1,53,23,201/-	3,06,500/-	26-09-2026	03-10-2026

The bidders are advised to note all details of tenders, from the department website

Executive Engineer,
Bhoranj Division, HPPWD Bhoranj, Pin Code 176045
Tel. No. 01972-266099. e-mail : eepwd-bhoranj-hp@gov.in
on behalf of Governor of HP.

HP / 3609/26-27 **HIM SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAMPARK**

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE FOR ELECTRICAL GENERAL CONSTRUCTION WORK

Tender No. : 36-CEE-C-SECR-2026, Date: 12/09/2026

Name of Work: "Electrical general construction work for following works:- (i) Centralized Sick Line and associate development work at Bhilai, (ii) Provision of 02 nos. Auto goomties in connection with construction of 4th line between Bilaspur-Dadhapara and (iii) RPF Barrack-01 nos. Office of SSEs- 04 nos. ORH- 01 nos, Railway Quarters (Type-II- 12 nos. Type-III-05 nos., Type-IV-01 no. & Type-V-01 no.) in connection with Gauge conversion work between Abhanpur-Dhamtari section; in Raipur and Bilaspur Division over S.E.C. Railway".

Tender Value : ₹ **3,11,49,547.88/-** (Rupees Three Crore Eleven Lakh Forty Nine Thousand Five Hundred Forty Seven and Paise Eighty Eight Only). **EMD :** ₹ **6,23,000/-** (Rupees Six Lakh Twenty Three Thousand Only).

Date & Time of Tender Closing : At **15:30** Hrs. on **06/10/2026**. **Date & Time of Tender Opening :** At **15:45** Hrs. on **06/10/2026**. **Completion Period :** 12 (Twelve) Months from the date of issue of LOA.

Website Particulars & Notice Board Location : For further details/related to e-tender document, eligibility criteria & the complete details for the above work, please refer/download tender document which is available on our website- **http://www.ireps.gov.in**.

Asstt. Elect. Exe. Engg./Con.
CPR/10/407 **S.E.C. Railway, Raipur**

South East Central Railway @secrail

KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
No.2, 2/1 and 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar, Bengaluru-560009. Phone No. 080-22265383, Website: www.kiadb.in

No. IADB/ENGG/ETND-DPR-04/1630/2026-27 **Date: 22.09.2026**

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

KIADB invites tenders from reputed consultants/firms under two cover bid system having an office at Bengaluru with vast experience and proven record of similar nature of work for project mentioned below:-

Name of the Works: Providing Consultancy Services for Preparation of Detailed Project Report (DPR) for the Formation of New Industrial Area Including Economic Analysis, Surveying, Layout Plan Design, Preparation of Cost Estimates, Cost Structure etc., for the Proposed Balakunji Industrial Area, Udupi Taluk & District in an extent of Extent 316.79 acres

The last date and time of receipt of tender is : **07.10.2026 upto 4.00 pm.**

Applicants May Download Bidding Documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal **https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in.**

Sd/-
Engineer in Chief, KIADB, Bengaluru

DIPR/CP/2857/SMCL/2026-27

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, CONSTRUCTION DIVISION (E/M), U.P. JAL NIGAM (URBAN), GHAZIABAD
Letter No.: 1647/Vividh-7/69
Dated : 21.09.2026

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Sealed tenders are invited for the **"Restoration of 350 kVA 415V APFC Panel No. 2 installed in Pump House Panel Room at 100 Cusec Ganga Jal WTP Siddharth Vihar, Ghaziabad."** Tender documents shall be available for sale from **26.09.2026 to 05.10.2026.** The last date for submission of tenders is **05.10.2026 up to 15:00 hrs.** and the tenders will be opened on the same day at **15:30 hrs.** in the office of the Superintending Engineer, Construction Circle (E/M), U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Ghaziabad. The cost of the tender document is **₹1,000/- plus 18% GST (i.e. Rs 1180.00).** All other terms and conditions shall be as specified in the Notice Inviting Tender (NIT) and the tender document.

Office Address
May to October: Forest Complex, Shiekh Bagh, Lal Chowk, Sgr- 190001 Phone: 0194-2483937 Fax: 0194-2455027
Nov. to April: Forest Resource Management Centre, Narwal Jammu- 180006 Phone: 01913511803
URL Address: www.forest.jk.gov.in www.campa.jk.gov.in
E-mail: pccf.for-jk@nic.in ceo.campa@jk.gov.in

Government of Jammu & Kashmir
Office of the Pr. Chief Conservator of Forests & HoFF
Jammu & Kashmir Forest Department

Sub: Request for Proposal (RFP) for hiring of services of Third-party Organisation.

Notification for tender No.01/CAMPA/2026-27
Dated: 19.09.2026

The Jammu & Kashmir Forest Department invites proposals from the reputed and experienced agencies (Central/Government Department/Society/Institute/Firm/ Company/Trust/NGOs) to undertake Third Party Evaluation of works executed by J&K Forest and allied Departments during FY 2023-24, 2024-25, and 2025-26, covering all forest divisions of the Union Territory of Jammu & Kashmir under various components of the Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority (CAMPA).

For details of RFP, please visit the official website of Government-e-Marketing (GeM) National Public Procurement Portal at www.gem.gov.in.

The last date for receipt of tender is 10th October 2026 (online mode).

(Tender Inviting Authority)
O/o Pr. Chief Conservator of Forests (HoFF)
FRMC Building, Narwal, Jammu-180006/
Sheikh Bagh, Forest Complex, Srinagar-190001
Email: ceo.campa@jk.gov.in/

DIP/J-11005/26

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक, यूनिट–9 कन्सट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज
उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय)
(उ0 प्र0 सरकार का उपक्रम)
2–शंकरनगर (नियर संदीप गैस एजेन्सी), दिल्ली रोड, सहारनपुर
प्रधान कार्यालयः टी–सी–38वी, विभूतिखण्ड, गोमतीनगर लखनऊ–226010
Ph. No. 0132-3580995
e-mail id:- pmu9cds@gmail.com

NIT NO-1830/E-Tender/192
Date:- 22.09.2026

अल्पकालीन ई–निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय), की ओर से अधोहस्ताक्षरी द्वारा जनपद न्यायालय सहारनपुर परिसर में स्थित न्याय भवन ब्लॉक–बी के वृहद् मरम्मत कार्य अनुमानित लागत ₹ 51.81 लाख (लेबर सेस सहित एवं जी.एस.टी. रहित) हेतु दिनांक 01.10.2026 अपरान्ह 17:00 बजे तक ई–निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई–निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 23.09.2026 से दिनांक 01.10.2026 को 17:00 बजे के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की **e-procurement** वेबसाइट **https://etender.up.nic.in** से डाउनलोड किये जा सकते है तथा ई–निविदा दिनांक 03.10.2026 को 13:30 बजे कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक यूनिट–09, सी. एण्ड डी.एस., उ.प्र. जल निगम (नगरीय), सहारनपुर में खोली जायेगी। ई–निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य ₹ 5900.00 (₹5000.00+GST (18%) अतिरिक्त देय होगा। निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट **www.cdsupjn.org** एवं प्रोक्योरमेन्ट पोर्टल **https://etender.up.nic.in** पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र **(Corrigendum) https://etender.up.nic.in** पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, **इनका पृथक से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा**। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाईट का समय–समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

TO ADVERTISE PLEASE CONTACT
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selvakumar.n@thehindu.co.in
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Letter No: 854 **Date Extension Notice-05** Date: 23/09/2026

Due to unavoidable circumstances, due dates in respect of online Bid Identification No.T-01/EE(Solar)/2026-27 are revised as follows:
Last Date /Time of Receipt of bid on the portal: 30-09-2026 upto 16:00 Hrs.
Last Date /Time of submission of bid in Office : 03-10-2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.
Date of opening of the bid on website:03-10-2026 from 13:00 Hrs.
All other details and terms & conditions shall remain same. Detail of subsequent addendum/corrigendum/cancelation etc. may be obtained from the website.
Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal **http://uktenders.gov.in**

Executive Engineer (Solar)

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED
Office of the Deputy General Manager-1,BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru – 560 052

No: DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/24/2026-27 **Date: 23.09.2026**

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER (IFT)-Call-04
(Only through GOK KPP Portal Only)

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work	Amt. put to tender/Annum Rs.in lakhs	EMD (in Rs.)	Stipulated Period of Service Contract
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Yeshwanthpura-2 division (Package-29) Call-04	**1,569.52**	Rs.1,00,000/- through e-payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS / NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.14,70,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized / scheduled Bank	**84 Months**

Calendar of events: 1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal **23.09.2026 onwards. 2)** Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: **27.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs. 3)** Pre bid meeting: **28.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs.** at above mentioned office **4)** Last date for submission of the bids: **05.10.2026 before 17.00 hrs. 5)** Date of opening of Technical bid on: **06.10.2026 after 17.30 hrs.** More details can be downloaded from website: **https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in**

DIPR/CP/JA/2915/2026-27 **Sd/- Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML**

CENTRAL RAILWAY
PUNE DIVISION
E-TENDER NO.: DRM/S&T/PA/ WKS/2026/17, Dated 22.09.2026

Divisional Railway Manager (Signaling & Telecommunication), Central Railway, Pune for and on behalf of President of India, invites Open E-tender through website **www.ireps.gov.in** for following works: **Name of work**: Signalling work in connection with Alteration in existing KYOSAN make EI in connection with provision of modification of point circuits NDKR1/RDKR1 and KAVACH Ready interface of Pune, Nagpur, Bhusawal, Solapur and Mumbai division, **E-tender No: CR-PA-SNT-WKS-S-2026-11, Cost of the work**: ₹19,31,07,100.46. **Bid Security (EMD)**: ₹ 38,62,200/-. **Cost of tender form**: Nil, **Completion period**: 11 months, **Date & Time of submission of bid from 12.10.2026 and up to 15:00 hrs. on 26.10.2026, Date & Time of closing of E-tender: 26.10.2026 at 15:00 Hrs. and Date & Time of opening of E-tender: 26.10.2026 after 15:30 Hrs.** Tenderer should participate electronically only in above E-tender through website **www.ireps.gov.in** and kindly visit the website for all the details of E-tender from time to time before the date of closing of submission of tender to note any changes/updates/corrigenda if any. For any enquiry, may contact at our office address Senior Divisional Signaling & Telecommunication Engineer, 3rd Floor, DRM Office, R.B.M. Road, Near Hotel Sheraton Grand, Central Railway, Pune-411001.

AK-66 **Sr. DSTE, Pune**

Unauthorized crossing of railway line is a punishable offense

BANGALORE WATER SUPPLY AND SEWERAGE BOARD
INVITATION FOR TENDER (Only through KPP portal)

BWSSB invites TENDERS in Two Stage Tender System from registered agencies for the following works.

Office of the Chief Engineer (Design, QA & IT), 9th Floor, Cauvery Bhavan, K.G. Road, Bangalore-09.

Sl. No.	Name of the Works	Amount put to Tender / EMD Amount
IFT No.: BWSSB/CE(DQA&IT)/ACE(D)/TA/1787/2026-27		**Date: 21.09.2026**
1	Work of Construction of Sub-division office at Bellandur for AEE (E-1-3), Bengaluru.	**Rs. 1,90,14,285/-** / **Rs. 2,85,300/-**
2	Work of Construction of division office at R.T. Nagar, Bengaluru.	**Rs. 1,62,79,622/-** / **Rs. 2,44,194/-**
3	Work of Construction of Service station building at Nellurahalli lake & Hoodi GLR coming under EE(E-1) Division, Bengaluru.	**Rs. 1,82,11,995.31** / **Rs. 2,73,200/-**

For all the above works the Last date for receipt of tender documents is on **08.10.2026 upto 16:00 hrs.** The technical bids will be opened on **09.10.2026 at 16:00 hrs.**

Sd/- Chief Engineer (Design, QA & IT)

The details regarding the tender and participation in the e-Procurement portal process can be obtained by logging on to **https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in** For further details contact the above signed office during working hours.

DIPR/CP/YC/2901/2026-27

ENTERPRISE CONNECT
A Business Initiative

Shri Manoj Kumar Sharma assumes charge as Director (Projects) of GAIL (India) Limited



Shri Manoj Kumar Sharma today assumed the charge as Director (Projects) of GAIL (India) Limited, India's integrated energy major, Prior to assuming charge as Director (Projects), GAIL (India) Limited, Shri Sharma served as Executive Director and Regional Head, Eastern Region Pipelines, at Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL). He was responsible for operations and maintenance, construction and City Gas Distribution (CGD) businesses across five states, overseeing a pipeline network spanning more than 5,700 km. With a Master's Degree in Mechanical Engineering (Production & Industrial Engineering) from Delhi College of Engineering (DCE) and a Post Graduate Diploma in Business Management from Xavier Institute of Management, Bhubaneswar (XIMB). Earlier, Shri Sharma has also served as Executive Director (Projects), Pipelines Division, IOCL, where he was responsible for engineering, procurement and construction management of major oil, LPG and natural gas pipeline projects in India and overseas. He has served on the Boards of GSPL India Transco Limited (GITL), GSPL India Gasnet Limited (GIGL), and Kochi Salem Pipeline Private Limited (KSPPL) as Nominee Director representing IOCL, contributing to strategic governance and the development of energy infrastructure.

ALLEN Expands Presence in Tamil Nadu with Grand Opening of Salem Centre



ALLEN Career Institute further strengthened its presence in Tamil Nadu with the grand opening of its new centre in Salem. The ceremony marked an important milestone in ALLEN's efforts to bring quality academic guidance and competitive examination preparation closer to students in Salem and neighbouring areas. The address of Salem Campus is fair fields, 49, Advaitha ashram road, Alagapuram, Salem. The event was presided over by Mahesh Yadav, Academic Head – South Zone, ALLEN Career Institute, and Santosh Singh, Head – Tamil Nadu, Allen. The ceremony brought together students, parents, ALLEN alumni, school toppers and education stakeholders. S Ashwin IRAS, Senior Divisional Finance Manager, Salem Division was the Chief Guest on the occasion. Speaking on the occasion, Mahesh Yadav, Academic Head – South Zone, ALLEN Career Institute, said, "The opening of the Salem centre is an important step in our endeavour to make quality academic guidance accessible to more students across Tamil Nadu. Salem has a strong pool of talented and ambitious students, and we look forward to supporting them with a structured learning environment, experienced faculty and a focused approach to competitive examination preparation. We are confident that this centre will become an important academic destination for students in Salem and surrounding areas."

Leadership and Community Development Training Programme Inaugurated at Sardar Patel University, Mandi



A four-day training programme on "Leadership and Community Development" was inaugurated today at Sardar Patel University, Mandi. The programme is being organised in collaboration with the Rajiv Gandhi National Institute of Youth Development (RGNIYD), Regional Centre, Chandigarh, Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, Government of India. The training programme will be held from September 21 to 24, 2026. The main objective of the programme is to develop leadership skills, social responsibility, community participation, team spirit, and a sense of nation-building among NSS volunteers. Addressing the gathering, Controller of Examinations and Programme Coordinator Dr. Sunil Kumar Thakur highlighted the importance of leadership and community development. He encouraged the NSS volunteers to understand their responsibilities towards society and play an active role in bringing about positive social change. Hon'ble Vice-Chancellor Shri Lalit Kumar Awasthi, in his address, highlighted the important role of youth in the development of society and the nation. He encouraged the NSS volunteers to imbibe the spirit of the NSS motto, "Not Me But You," and contribute actively towards the service of society and the nation. He further emphasised that such training programmes help NSS volunteers develop leadership capabilities, understand the real needs of communities, and contribute effectively towards addressing social challenges.

10 Years of excellence of AOMSI Delhi NCR State Chapter



The Association of Oral & Maxillofacial Surgeons Of India (AOMSI) Delhi NCR chapter held its 10th Annual Conference in Delhi at Hotel Crowne Plaza, Mayur Vihar, with the theme "transforming faces, transforming lives". The conference was attended by more than 200 participants, including delegates and post-graduate students from all over India. The chief guest Dr. Ashish Gupta, President of AOMSI, emphasized the role of maxillofacial surgeons, and the crucial role they play during maxillofacial trauma, infections, cancers and facial asymmetry cases. Dr. Apoorva Mowar the President of the AOMSI Delhi NCR chapter in his welcome address updated about the number of social outreach programs conducted by the Delhi NCR chapter to create public awareness about the much neglected oral health, anti-tobacco drive, Road safety awareness programs, prevention of maxillofacial trauma and First aid/ Basic life safety programs for the public. The guest of honour Dr. Kannan Balaramn Secretary AOMSI, congratulated the chapter for its many successfully conducted programmes.

UP Sharpens PM Gati Shakti Focus on Faster Project Planning and Implementation



Uttar Pradesh is strengthening the implementation of the PM Gati Shakti National Master Plan (NMP) to enhance core and social infrastructure planning, improve inter-departmental coordination, and accelerate project execution across the state. The initiative focuses on leveraging integrated geospatial data and digital planning tools to identify infrastructure gaps, optimize resource allocation, enable evidence-based decision-making, and ensure faster, more efficient delivery of infrastructure projects. A meeting on the effective implementation of PM Gati Shakti was held at the Invest UP office in Lucknow in collaboration with BISAG-N (MeitY). More than 100 officials from departments and districts participated, including representatives from PWD, Energy, UPEIDA, Health, Education and Skill Development. Uttar Pradesh has integrated 29 mandatory data layers and initiated or integrated 56 additional departmental layers on the PM Gati Shakti platform. The framework is being used to support evidence-based decisions across infrastructure and economic development projects. A key outcome has been the implementation of more than 32 infrastructure projects worth over ₹2,150 crore under the Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment scheme. The state has emphasised on regular review meetings. CEO Invest UP Shri Vijay Kiran Anand said stronger coordination and technology-enabled planning were helping departments move projects from conception to execution. "PM Gati Shakti is helping departments work with a common planning framework, identify gaps early and coordinate project requirements more effectively. This is supporting faster and more efficient implementation on the ground,"

THURSDAY
September 24, 2026

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IN BRIEF



SIR is illegal, says former CEC Quraishi

NEW DELHI
The SIR is illegal and needs to be reversed, former CEC S.Y. Quraishi said on Wednesday at an event to launch the book, 'The Delimitation Debate: The Union and its Units', published by The Hindu Group.
» Page 11

SIT to probe graft allegations against Pinarayi

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM
The Keralam government has constituted an SIT to probe corruption allegations against former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, son-in-law , and others in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.
» Page 5

Opposition calls for CEC's exit over 'illegal conduct'

Gyanesh Kumar under fire after expose on several objections by fellow Election Commissioners; Congress calls for SC-monitored probe; INDIA bloc to meet soon to discuss the issue, says Mamata

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Opposition parties on Wednesday sought the removal of Gyanesh Kumar as the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) after an *Indian Express* expose claimed that two of the three members of the Election Commission (EC), Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, had formally recorded objections at least 14 times over the last 10 months. The two commissioners said major decisions were being made in the name of the full EC without their knowledge, several of which they called "unauthorised and illegal".

Declaring that "vote *chori*" is a crime against the Indian people and a direct attack on the Constitution, the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, said "the BJP, RSS, and EC who organised it have committed an act of treason. Justice will be served."

Under the 2023 law governing the EC, all decisions should be made unanimously where possible. Where the CEC and the commissioners disagree, the majority should prevail, the law says.

According to the *Indian Express* report, the two commissioners red-flagged several issues, led by the centralisation of the database of electoral rolls. In May, Mr. Joshi had reportedly proposed an audit to certify that "no one except the concerned statutory authorities has any credentials to make any change in the data base".

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MORE REPORTS ON
» PAGE 10

Under scanner

The allegations against the CEC come amid widespread complaints about the SIR exercises and apprehensions about the poll body's conduct

KEY ISSUES RAISED
- Centralisation of electoral database
- Alteration of Form 6
- Authorisation of appeals against voter inclusion
- 97 eligible voters from Goa being left out of the roll


Sukhbir Singh Sandhu
Election Commissioner


Gyanesh Kumar
Chief Election Commissioner


Vivek Joshi
Election Commissioner

"All official orders, decisions, and administrative directions issued by the commission carry full legal sanctions - **EC STATEMENT**

"Vote *chori* is a crime... The BJP, RSS, and EC who organised it have committed an act of treason. Justice will be served"
RAHUL GANDHI, LoP in Lok Sabha



'Minister in a panel to select CEC sends wrong signal'

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court Justice Dipankar Datta on Wednesday said the replacement of the Chief Justice of India with a Union Cabinet Minister in the Prime Minister-led selection panel for Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and Election Commissioners *prima facie* amounts to an effective veto in favour of the Union government and fails the "perception test", sending wrong signals to the public.

The observations came in a separate opinion following a split judgment over the question whether a challenge to provisions of the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service, and Term of Office) Act of 2023 ought to be referred to a Constitution Bench or not.

CONTINUED ON
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India, EU to sign trade deal on December 16

Final touches

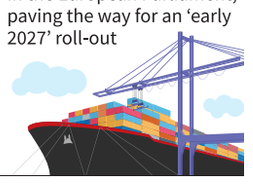
Negotiations on the India-EU Free Trade Agreement, dubbed the 'mother of all deals', were concluded in January 2026

The FTA will see the EU dropping tariffs on **99.5%** of Indian exports to the region, with most tariffs going down to **0%**



India will give tariff concessions on **97.5%** of the traded value between the two economies

After the signing, the deal will take 1-2 months to pass in the European Parliament, paving the way for an 'early 2027' roll-out



T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

The Free Trade Agreement (FTA) between India and the European Union (EU) will be signed on December 16, two diplomatic sources have separately confirmed to *The Hindu*.

This will be part of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's back-to-back trips in December to Canada, the U.S., and Belgium, where three separate FTAs are currently either being negotiated or in the process of approval.

Further, as the EU FTA has received "majority approval" in Europe, it will not require separate ratification by each EU country once the European Council gives its go-ahead.

The next step, after the signing, will be passage in the European Parliament, which will take another one to two months, paving the way for a roll-out in "early 2027".

"The most recent development was the European Commission finalising the text of the deal and sending it to the European Council," a diplomatic source told *The Hindu*.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

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Hon'ble Minister for Medical Education and Skill Development Dr. Sharanaprakash R. Patil, Hon'ble Minister for Health and Family Welfare Shri U. T. Khader and Hon'ble Vice Chancellor Dr. Bhagavan B. C. participated in a programme at RGUHS.

New Projects Underway
RGUHS CAMPUS AT RAMANAGARA
A state-of-the-art University Campus is being established in Ramanagara with the vision of creating a world-class center for medical education, academic excellence and institutional administration. It will include constituent colleges, a modern hospital and an administrative block.

Skill/Simulation Labs Across Karnataka
Skill/Simulation Labs are being developed at Gadag, Bheemanakuppe, Kalaburagi, Davanagere, Mysuru and Mangaluru to provide students with hands-on clinical training and practical skill development.



New Projects Underway
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As enshrined in our Constitution - to safeguard public property and to abjure violence is the fundamental duty of every citizen of India.



LSR students during the solidarity march demanding enhanced safety measures, in New Delhi on Wednesday. LAVPREET KAUR

LSR students take out 'women-only' march over safety concerns

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Hundreds of students of Lady Shri Ram College for Women (LSR) took out a women-only solidarity march on Wednesday evening, passing through areas linked to the gang rape of a 17-year-old girl in Astha Kunj Park and the police encounter.

The march started from the National Park near the college's back gate and ended at SD Office Road near Moolchand, with a brief sit-in near the spot where Asif, one of the three accused men, was shot in the leg during an exchange of fire with the police. Students said the march was intended to reclaim spaces they use every day and send a message that the incident would not dictate where or when women could move.

"We want freedom from rape culture, moral policing and patriarchy," a student said.

The demonstration was held amid heavy police presence, with personnel managing traffic and accompanying the students as the march moved through busy stretches of Nehru Place and Kailash Colony during the evening rush hour. "There were blood splashes on the road. It was very scary. Nothing felt safe despite the police being there," said Aakriti Yati, a second-year journalism student.

Raising concerns

Questioning why they had not been informed about the incident before coming to college on Tuesday, the students sought a formal mechanism for communicating verified safety advisories during emergencies.

Meanwhile, senior Delhi Police officers held a meeting with the principal, assuring the administration that police presence would be increased and immediate assistance provided in case of any emergency.

L-G directs MCD, DDA to undertake safety audits of public parks

Move comes after gang rape of 17-year-old girl at Astha Kunj Park; orders issued to step up vigilance, identify dark spots, install CCTV cameras: DDA

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu chairing a high-level review meeting at the Secretariat on Wednesday. ANI

Lieutenant-Governor (L-G) Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday directed civic authorities to conduct safety audits of public parks across the Capital. The L-G gave the order after reviewing safety arrangements at a meeting attended by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) Commissioner, the Commissioner of Police, and the Vice-Chairman of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), Lok Niwas stated in a release.

The move comes after a 17-year-old girl was gang-raped allegedly by three men who posed as police personnel at Astha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Mandir in south-east Delhi on Monday. All three accused were arrested on Tuesday. A city court remanded the accused in two-day judicial custody on Wednesday.

The Delhi police have not sought their custody so far. Further investigation is under way in the case.

According to the Lok Niwas statement, the safety audit will examine lighting, deployment of guards at all entry and exit points, patrolling inside parks - particularly after sunset - and cleanliness and sanitation facilities. Authorities have also been asked to look into whether some parks can be handed over to residents' welfare associations or private entities for maintenance and upkeep.

'Seek public feedback'

The L-G directed officials to engage with nearby schools, colleges, and other institutions to seek feedback on facilities at parks. Regular visits by beat constables and police personnel responsible for the respective areas have been ordered to strengthen security, the release stated.

In a separate statement, the DDA stated that its field staff and security personnel have been directed to maintain heightened vigilance, particularly during evening and night hours. Parks with multiple gates may restrict late-evening access to selected entrances. The authority has also initiated measures to identify dark spots and install additional lighting and CCTV cameras at vulnerable locations, it stated.

The DDA will also coordinate with the Delhi police to monitor suspicious or illegal activity around parks, it added.

Metro integration

Meanwhile, the L-G approved six multi-modal integration plans for metro stations and two road projects at the 70th governing body meeting of the Unified Traffic and Transportation Infrastructure (Planning & Engineering) Centre. The projects aim to improve last-mile connectivity and ease congestion.

Show-cause notices issued to 37 bus drivers at Wazirabad DTC depot over ongoing stir

Shrimansi Kaushik
Soibam Rocky Singh
NEW DELHI



The DTC bus drivers' strike began on September 15 over demands for better pay and social security benefits. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

At least 37 drivers at Delhi Transport Corporation's (DTC) Wazirabad depot were issued show-cause notices on Wednesday for allegedly obstructing bus operations between September 16 and 22, according to a statement issued by the depot manager.

The disciplinary action, which includes blacklisting of eight drivers, comes amid an ongoing strike by DTC bus drivers that began on September 15 seeking better pay, paid leave, and social security benefits.

The drivers who received the notices have been directed to present their case in writing within 24 hours, failing which the depot could conduct an internal inquiry and arrive at an *ex parte* decision.

Several drivers have returned to work fearing termination while others have reportedly fled to their home towns fearing a government crackdown.

"At least eight drivers were blacklisted, which could result in termination and a permanent blot on their service records. Others were told that if they did not return to work, they would be dismissed," said a protesting driver requesting anonymity.

Despite the show-cause notices being issued, the DTC Karamchari Ekta Union has called for a full strike by all contractual employees on September 28.

Compulsory attendance

Meanwhile, the DTC has issued a notice mandating compulsory attendance. At the Rohini depot, employees have been asked to report for duty between September 25 and 28, while at the Kalkaji depot, staff have been asked to report for work between September 24 and 30.

Responding to the notice, Lalit Chaudhary, president of the union, said, "We won't back down. We will continue our strike."

Employed by seven private companies that operate Delhi's cluster buses, the drivers currently earn ₹862 per day with no paid leave or social security net.

The Delhi police have detained hundreds of drivers after registering FIRs over multiple incidents of alleged vandalism and mischief under sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. However, the accused drivers claimed that they have been falsely charged.

HC steps in

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday sought a reply from the Delhi government on why provisions of the Essential Services Maintenance Act have not been invoked against the protesting drivers.

A Bench of Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia also asked the government to review the situation and take appropriate steps to ensure that DTC buses continue to ply across the Capital.

The crisis has heavily impacted commuters, especially daily wagers, domestic workers, and students. To ease the crisis, the Delhi Metro pressed into service eight to 10 additional trains and operated 20 to 50 extra daily trips from September 16 to 22.

HC seeks response on DUSU victory processions

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday sought responses from Delhi University and candidates who contested the recent Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections on a plea alleging that victory processions were taken out in breach of the court's express directions.

The ABVP won three central panel posts while independent candidate Deepanshu Shokeen won the vice-presidential post in the elections. The results were declared on September 19.

A Bench of Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia was hearing the application filed by advocate Prashant Manchanda.

It alleged that the winning candidates took out victory processions despite the court prohibiting such celebrations, amounting to contempt of court.

"This is not done. This is just not done," the Bench remarked, indicating that the court would take a serious view of the alleged violation of its directions.

The court directed Mr. Manchanda to compile relevant material in the matter and submit a dossier.

Only 1 lakh inclusion claims against 47 lakh deletions; Sept. 30 deadline set for extension

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI



The claims and objections period, which began on August 31, is scheduled to conclude on September 30. FILE PHOTO

Around one lakh applications have been received for inclusion in Delhi's electoral roll during the ongoing claims and objections period of the special intensive revision (SIR). This represents only about 2.2% of the 47.56 lakh names left out of the draft roll published on August 31.

The latest figures released by the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer show that 1,06,937 inclusion applications were received between August 31 and September 22. Along with the 2,12,400 applications received before August 30, this takes the total number of inclusion requests received so far to 3,19,337.

During the same period, 1,774 objections seeking deletion of names have been received, while 39,184 applications have been filed seeking corrections.

The claims and objections period is scheduled to conclude on September 30. Officials, however, said the September 30 deadline could be extended after reviewing the progress over the next week.

New or omitted voters must file Form 6 to be included in the electoral roll. Applications remain low, even though a senior official estimated that 50% of "shifted" electors could return by filing the form -- 66% of the 47.5 lakh electors left out were categorised as "permanently shifted".

Form 6 declaration

Those seeking re-inclusion have also raised questions about the declaration applicants are required to sign while filing Form 6. A new declaration asks applicants to provide details of themselves, a parent or a relative from the previous SIR. However, both the online and offline versions of Form 6 continue to carry a declaration stating: "I am applying for inclusion in electoral roll for the first time and my name is not included in any Assembly Constituency/Parliamentary Constituency."

Election Commission of India guidelines state that all entries must be completed and warn that a false statement is punishable under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, with imprisonment of up to one year.

Vulnerable groups

Officials said special camps will be held for homeless persons, transgender persons and sex workers on September 24 at the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board night shelters and other locations. Camps will also be organised at all polling stations on September 27.

Under EC rules, homeless individuals can register to vote without address proof if a Booth Level Officer verifies their location. However, officials said that the SIR process still requires a prescribed document or a linked previous electoral roll declaration for these applicants.

Two men get HC notices for releasing dogs on law officer in Mehrauli

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court has issued contempt notices to two men for allegedly releasing dogs on a court-appointed Local Commissioner during a property inspection in Mehrauli, stating that they *prima facie* obstructed the execution of its orders.

In his September 18 order, Justice Amit Bansal directed the two men to file affidavits within four weeks explaining why action should not be initiated against them for "violating and wilfully disobeying" judicial orders. The judge also directed them to remain physically present in court on November 19, the next date of hearing.

In July, the court had directed Local Commissioner Akanksha Bisht to verify whether any construction was being undertaken at the property in Mehrauli.

'Distasteful remarks'

In her report, Ms. Bisht stated that when she reached the property to conduct the inspection, distasteful remarks were hurled at her in an aggressive tone. The report also stated that two dogs were released on her from a kennel on the property. They were put back into the enclosure after the head constable accompanying her intervened, it added.

"This is a serious matter where dogs have been released on a Local Commissioner appointed by this court as well as on the photographer accompanying her. Along with the aforesaid report, the Local Commissioner has placed on record photographs and videos evidencing the obstruction... in the execution of the commission," the court observed.

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For **ARTERY CONSULTING & TECHNOLOGIES PRIVATE LIMITED**
Sd/-
Premal Sharadkumar Vasavada (Director)
Date: 24/09/2026 **DIN: 08134093**
Place: New Delhi

PERSONAL
CHANGE OF NAME

I, **DILEEP** Kumar Ojha, hereby declare that my mother's names Ahalya Ojha and Ahilya Devi refer to same person. My father's names Khageshwar Ojha, Khageshwar Kumar Ojha and Khageswar Ojha refer to same person.Add: HNo 40 Karkar Model Sahibabad GZB UP

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1.	Second Call	2026_UAD_528881_2	Empanelment of firms for supply of poly aluminium chloride (PAC) is -15573/ 2005 at water treatment plant khatpura i/c transportation, filling tank etc. Complete.	16,385,000.00	12,500/-	06.10.2026 05:30 PM

Executive Engineer
Water Works Department
Municipal Corporation, Bhopal
T.N. 773/026/027

Ready for yet another fight, says Hooda, seeks support from voters

Ashok Kumar
GURUGRAM


Former Haryana CM Bhupinder Singh Hooda with a supporter in Garhi Sampla-Kiloi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A week after turning 79, former Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda on Wednesday made it clear that he was not ready to hang up his political boots.

Addressing villagers during a tour of his Assembly constituency Garhi Sampla-Kiloi, the Leader of the Opposition said he was ready for another "fight" and asked his supporters to also prepare for it. Mr. Hooda cast his political future as a choice between "sitting silent" and "continuing the fight".

"My people are my real strength. I have come to ask you whether I should sit quietly or continue to fight. There are only two paths - to sit silent or to fight.I am not going to step back," the Congress leader said in Haryanvi, drawing applause.

Invoking the language of the wrestling arena, Mr. Hooda said a political leader, unlike a wrestler, had no strength of his own and drew it from the people.

Mr. Hooda ended his address by turning the question of his political future into a show of public support. "Raise your hands and tell me, should I fight?" he said.

Arunachal Cabinet clears panel for Siang dam survey

Villagers have been opposing the preparation of the pre-feasibility report for the proposed Siang Upper Multipurpose Project; the Central govt. had declared SUMP a national project in 2008

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI


Villagers along the river belt protesting against the project in Siang district of Arunachal Pradesh. FILE PHOTO

Amid protests, the Arunachal Pradesh Cabinet on Wednesday adopted a resolution approving the constitution of an empowered high-level committee "to guide and coordinate" the pre-feasibility report survey and associated activities for the proposed Siang Upper Multipurpose Project or SUMP.

Villagers along the Siang river belt are resisting the pre-feasibility report for the project, which will generate an estimated 11,000 megawatts (MW) or more of hydroelectricity. Two of the project's three designated sites are in Siang district, and one is in Upper Siang district.

The Cabinet noted that the Union government had declared SUMP to be a national project in 2008, underlining its strategic significance. It also noted that the project could strengthen water and energy security, help mitigate floods in the Siang-Brahmaputra basin, generate employment, and support long-term socio-economic development of the region.

The Cabinet underlined concerns raised by some sections of people in Siang and Upper Siang districts "regarding misinformation and disinformation" being spread by certain vested interests. It resolved that conducting the pre-feasibility report peacefully depended on sustained, meaningful engagement with the residents of these two districts. "The voices, welfare, and aspirations of the likely project affected families and local communities have always been, and will always remain, central to the process," the Cabinet said.

Meanwhile, local authorities organised a series of school exhibitions on SUMP, involving 640 students from four schools in Siang district. "The exhibitions formed part of a targeted educational outreach initiative to foster awareness about river management and the SUMP among students," an official statement said.

2 more key accused in Sagar hooch tragedy held after encounter

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL


Manish Lodhi alias Yashwant Thakur. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Two prime accused in the hooch tragedy that has claimed 20 lives so far in Madhya Pradesh's Sagar district were held after a brief encounter on Wednesday, officers said.

According to the police, Manish Lodhi alias Yashwant Thakur and his accomplice Ashish Sahu were held after an encounter at 3 a.m. near Malthone area, about 50 kilometres from the district headquarters. Mr. Lodhi suffered a bullet injury in his leg in the encounter.

With Mr. Lodhi and Mr. Sahu, the total number of arrests in the case has reached 39. The police have named 52 persons in two separate cases filed in the wake of the tragedy.

Sagar Superintendent of Police (SP) Anurag Sujania said the police had received inputs on Tuesday night that Mr. Lodhi had entered the district through Malthone area to seek help.

"The police surrounded him and asked him to surrender but he started firing at the team. The police fired in self-defence and he was injured in his leg after which both were taken into custody," he said. Mr. Lodhi had been absconding since September 6 when the tragedy came to light.

SC stays order to recover ₹5 lakh from Noida DM

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday stayed an Allahabad High Court direction to recover ₹5 lakh from the salary of Gautam Buddha Nagar District Magistrate Medha Roopam and other officials to compensate Delhi University student Akriti Chaudhary for detaining her under the National Security Act (NSA) over a workers' protest in Noida in April this year.

A Bench headed by Justice Satish Chandra Sharma froze the operation of the Division Bench judgment, which quashed the student's nearly five-month detention as illegal.

Appearing for Ms. Roopam, senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi submitted that such decisions went through a multi-tiered process, including at the Central and State levels, and his client cannot be singled out for penalty. Senior Advocate Tushar Mehta, who is the Solicitor General of India, also appeared on the side of Ms. Roopam. Senior Advocate Colin Gonsalves appeared for Ms. Chaudhary, the respondent in the case.

"After hearing senior counsels for the parties, this court is of the opinion that till the matter is heard on merits, the operation of the judgment, particularly paragraphs nos. 27 to 33, shall remain stayed," the court ordered, listing the case for October 7.

The seven paragraphs highlighted by the Supreme Court from the decision against Ms. Roopam had cautioned that the continued "despotic" conduct of an errant bureaucracy could reduce Uttar Pradesh to an "Orwellian Dystopia".

The HC had criticised Ms. Roopam's lack of application of mind to a police report against the student activist. It had allowed Ms. Chaudhary's *habeas corpus* petition and ordered her immediate release, unless she was required in another case. The HC had flagged discrepancies in the arrest notice and termed the State's version a "concocted story".

Ms. Chaudhary was among several activists arrested in connection with the protest held between April 10 and 18, during which industrial and contractual workers demanded a hike and parity with wages paid in Haryana. The protest had turned violent on April 13. The Uttar Pradesh police had invoked the NSA against Ms. Chaudhary a month later, alleging that she had instigated protesters to engage in stone-pelting and arson.

Cabinet approves 'DURGA' scheme for e-autos in Delhi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Cabinet on Wednesday approved the 'DURGA' scheme to allocate electric autos exclusively to women and transgender persons, according to a statement from the Chief Minister's Office.

In the first phase, 1,300 pink electric autos are proposed to be registered. Of these, 1,170 will be allocated to women and 130 to transgender beneficiaries. A maximum of 90 electric autos for women and 10 for transgender beneficiaries will be allocated in each revenue district.

The CMO stated the scheme aims to provide "dignified self-employment and livelihood opportunities" while promoting women's safety, greater participation of transgender persons in the transport sector, last-mile connectivity and clean and sustainable urban transport.

Applicants must apply through an online portal. They must be Delhi residents aged 20-40 with voter ID, LMW driving licence and PSV badge; women with over three children are ineligible.

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INBRIEF



U.P. CM launches Bharat Taxi, loan scheme for farmers

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Wednesday launched the Bharat Taxi service and the Mukhyamantri Krishak Samriddhi Yojana, calling it two major steps for welfare of taxi drivers and farmers of the State. Through Bharat Taxi, two-wheeler, taxi and three-wheeler drivers will be able to join on zero commission upon registration. They will also receive social security of ₹5 lakh. Under the Mukhyamantri Krishak Samriddhi Yojana, the interest rate on loans provided to farmers through the Uttar Pradesh Cooperative Gramya Vikas Bank has been reduced from 11% to 6%.

Mayawati's younger nephew new BSP national convener

The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) on Wednesday appointed Ishan Anand, younger nephew of party president Mayawati, as its new national convener, days after his elder brother was removed from all party responsibilities. The decision was announced at a meeting of the BSP's national executive held in Lucknow and chaired by Ms. Mayawati. Mr. Anand, who has completed his Master of Laws (LLM), was present at the meeting along with his father and BSP national vice-president Anand Kumar. In his address Mr. Anand thanked the party chief for entrusting him with the responsibility.

Cases withdrawn against 20 booked for Leh violence

L-G announces decision ahead of first anniversary of protests that left four dead; foot marches in Leh and Kargil led by Wangchuk and KDA

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR



Cases withdrawn in the larger interest of peace, public tranquillity and social harmony, said L-G Vinai Kumar Saxena. FILE PHOTO

Lieutenant Governor (L-G) Vinai Kumar Saxena on Wednesday announced withdrawal of criminal cases against 20 individuals allegedly involved in last year's September 24 protests over Statehood and Sixth Schedule demands in Ladakh ahead of the first anniversary of the violent stir that left four civilians dead.

"In the larger interest of peace, public tranquillity, and social harmony in Ladakh, I have approved the withdrawal of criminal cases against 20 individuals, related to the unfortunate violence that erupted in Leh on September 24 last year," said Mr. Saxena. He said a comprehensive review was held of the cases, upon which the Ladakh police recommended a closure report for these individuals.

"By prioritising justice and healing over protracted litigation, the decision aims at fostering a more peaceful, united, and harmonious society in Ladakh," said the L-G while thanking Union Home Minister Amit Shah for his "sympathetic approach in matters pertaining to the victims and their families".

Meanwhile, peaceful *padayatras* (foot marches) were held in Leh and Kargil on Wednesday. Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk led a march in Leh to commemorate those who died in Leh last year. "Civilian volunteers fought for the nation and won huge areas in the 1971 war with Pakistan. People of Ladakh have always stood for the nation and now it's time the nation stood with Ladakh," said Mr. Wangchuk, who has expressed unhappiness over the Centre not sharing details of the road map for Ladakh's special status under Article 371.

All-faith prayer

The Ladakh Buddhist Association (LBA) will hold an all-faith prayer in memory of those people who died in the firing last year on Thursday. In Kargil, hundreds of supporters of the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), a civil society body, took out a 'Ladakh Justice March'.

T.N. Cong. leader says he told Chennai police about 'Gem' Veeramani scandal 2 years ago

THE HINDU EXCLUSIVE

Udhav Naig
CHENNAI



R. Veeramani

In a twist to the sensational child sexual abuse case allegedly involving Gem Granites owner R. Veeramani, a Congress leader on Wednesday said he had informed the Chennai police about the crime as early as November 2024.

The following month, he had also shared with the police a video clip in which a man resembling the octogenarian business magnate was seen abusing a minor girl.

"I met a senior police officer at the Chennai Police Commissionerate in Egmore on November 22, 2024, and submitted a written complaint (dated November 21), seeking action against Veeramani and his associate Shanthi (both now in custody). I also attached screenshots from the video clip," M.P. Ranjan Kumar, president, Tamil Nadu Congress Committee's Scheduled Caste Department, told *The Hindu*.

He shared with this correspondent a copy of the complaint, which he claimed he had handed over to the senior police officer, as well as screenshots of his conversation with the officer on WhatsApp, seeking his appointment to discuss the issue.

Mr. Kumar's claim contradicts the Chennai police's statement that they had received a complaint and a pen drive of the video of the sexual abuse through an NGO only in October last year.

"The senior officer assured me that action would be taken after conferring with the then Police Commissioner. On November 25, 2024, an Inspector from the Anti-Vice Squad sought information related to the case. On December 17, 2024, I sent him (Inspector) the video clip. Thereafter, I was repeatedly asked if I knew the victims seen in the video. I did not know them, but I insisted that if the police could summon Veeramani and Shanthi or conduct a surprise raid at their homes, they would be able to retrieve more evidence," he said. Mr. Kumar alleged that the police, however, gradually stopped correspondence with him on the case.

The Congress leader said he was disclosing this as some vested interests were seeking to link him with the scandal, and the police, too, had not acknowledged his role and were now seeking to push back the case by a year, claiming they had received a complaint only last year.

In his complaint, Mr. Kumar had alleged: "Gem Granites proprietor, Veeramani, had been frequenting the residence of Shanthi and had been preying on girl children aged between 14 and 16, particularly belonging to oppressed and minority communities. I had been given the possession of videos that show sexual acts performed by him on girl children..."

He had lodged the complaint "in the hope that the children would be protected".

JD(U) to contest upcoming U.P. poll, eyes 60 Purvanchal seats

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA



JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar with son Nishant Kumar.

The Janata Dal (United), a coalition partner of the Bharatiya Janata Party in Bihar, on Wednesday said it would contest the Assembly election in neighbouring Uttar Pradesh next year and preparing to field candidates in 60 seats, particularly in Purvanchal areas, close to the inter-State border where Kurmi and Kushwaha votes are in sizeable number. Towards, this, it will also hold a party workers' meeting in Varanasi on October 25 in which top leaders from Bihar are likely to be present.

'Nishant to attend meet'

"Party's national working president Sanjay Kumar Jha, U.P. in-charge Shrawan Kumar, Nishant Kumar [son of former CM and party president Nitish Kumar] and Deputy CM Vijay Kumar Choudhary are likely to attend," said Sanjay Gandhi alias Sanjay Kumar Singh, a senior JD(U) leader and MLC in Bihar who is considered to be a trusted confidant of Mr. Nitish Kumar.

When asked if the party has zeroed in on the seats it plans to contest, Mr. Gandhi indicated that they would be constituencies near the Bihar border but added "it's up to NDA's top leadership to decide in coalition politics".

Other Bihar JD(U) leaders, preferring anonymity, said the party is eyeing seats where Other Backward Class (OBC) Kurmi and Kushwaha caste voters are in sizeable numbers. Mr. Nitish Kumar is a Kurmi; current Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary comes from the Kushwaha caste.

'No alliance yet'

"Party leaders would discuss how to strengthen the organisational strategy in view of the upcoming Assembly election. We are right now in the process of deliberating on alliance partners but nothing has been finalised yet," said JD (U) U.P. spokesperson Kunwar Ajay Singh. Other JD (U) leaders indicated that BJP is their preferred ally for U.P. as well.

In the previous Assembly election in U.P. in 2022, the JD(U) contested 26 out of the State's 403 seats on its own but won none. The party secured about 0.11% of the total vote share.

'Bhajan jamming' at cultural festival near Badrinath temple triggers row

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI



Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami attending the festival held at the Tourist Arrival Plaza in Chamoli district. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A two-day cultural festival held in the fragile, high-altitude town of Badrinath in Uttarakhand has sparked controversy after videos of a loud, concert-style "*bhajan* jamming" session went viral on social media.

The Chamoli district administration and the Uttarakhand Tourism Department claimed that the Army had organised the festival, which was held on September 19 and 20 at the Tourist Arrival Plaza adjoining the Badrinath temple on the theme "Our Heritage, Our Future".

'Organised by Army'

"It was held as part of Operation Sadbhavana, the Indian Army's community outreach initiative, with participation from the Chamoli district administration and the Uttarakhand Tourism Department. Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami also attended the event," an official said.

The district administration said permission was given only to put up stalls and it was not informed about the DJ performance. "We have written to the Army seeking a response on whether it had obtained any permission to organise such a concert near the shrine," the official said.

Videos of the session, centred on a performance by singer Priyanka Meher, went viral on social media, with some users likening it to a "nightclub rather than a cultural programme".

'Ban such events'

Demanding a ban on "vulgar performances" near the Badrinath temple, part of the Char Dham Yatra, Swami Avimukteshwaranand Saraswati, Shankaracharya of Jyotirmath, said: "Even blowing a conch is prohibited in the area so that the meditation of Lord Vishnu is not disturbed. The administration is disturbing the religious atmosphere by allowing DJ and vulgar performances."

Brijesh Sati, general secretary of the Uttarakhand Teerth Purohits Samiti, said the Army had organised a similar event at Badrinath in April before the temple's portals opened, which the priest community also opposed. "We cannot put the entire onus on the Army as the permission is granted by the State government," he said.

Activist Anoop Nautiyal said such events go against local traditions. Congress spokesperson Garima Dasauni said the BJP government must "clarify where it draws the line between tourism promotion and commercialisation".

State Tourism Secretary Dhiraj Singh Garbyal said a response should be sought from the Army as it had organised the event. Attempts by *The Hindu* to reach the Army for comment went unanswered.

M.P. traders and retailers observe 'No UPI Day'

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

Traders and shopkeepers in cities across Madhya Pradesh on Wednesday protested against the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) charges on UPI transactions by observing a 'No UPI Day' and covering the QR codes on their outlets.

In cities like Bhopal and Indore, QR code stickers and payment confirmation soundboxes on several shops were seen covered with a black cloth with the traders requesting customers to pay in cash. Demonstrations were also witnessed at various places with traders demanding a rollback of the move while threatening a complete boycott of digital payments.

New transaction charge

On September 15, the National Payments Corporation of India introduced a charge of 0.4% on person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI payments of above ₹2,000. The new rates, that will come into effect from October 15, will be applicable on merchants, who will have to pay their banks and payment processors. Person-to-person transactions and payments to small vendors have been exempted from the new rates.

The protests in Madhya Pradesh have been called by Ahilya Chamber of Commerce and Industry with various trader bodies in cities like Indore, Bhopal, Gwalior and Jabalpur taking part in it.

At a demonstration in Indore, traders raised slogans like 'Aaj ka vyapaar, nakad vyapaar (Today's business, a cash business)' and claimed that they refused customers who were making a digital payment.

Posters reading 'No UPI Day' were also pasted outside shops in busy markets across cities. The posters also read that the traders were already paying taxes like GST and income tax.

After Jat belt, Nuh next in INLD's bid to reclaim lost ground

Ashok Kumar
GURUGRAM



INLD patron Sampat Singh (right) and its Nuh chief Tahir Hussain at Mewali village to garner support for the party's 'Samman Diwas' rally slated for September 27. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

After taking its battle for political relevance into former Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda's home turf - the Jat stronghold of Sonipat-Rohtak-Jhajjar - last year with a 'Samman Diwas' rally, a resurgent Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) is now shifting its focus to another Congress fortress, the Muslim-dominated Nuh.

Led by national president Abhay Singh Chautala, the party has announced that the next edition of the annual event - to mark the birth anniversary of former Deputy Prime Minister Chaudhary Devi Lal - will be held in Nuh on September 27, two days later than the traditional September 25 date to avoid conflicting with Friday prayers.

The choice of Nuh is politically significant as Devi Lal enjoyed considerable support among the Meo Muslims. The region was once an INLD stronghold. However, the party's organisational strength in the area declined sharply after the split in 2018, and the Congress won all three Assembly constituencies in the district - Nuh, Ferozepur Jhirka and Punhana - in the past two Assembly elections (2019 and 2024). Two of these three Assembly segments were, however, won by the INLD each in 2009 and 2014.

The party's pitch, however, is not confined to Nuh. The sizeable Muslim electorate in the neighbouring Sohna and Hathin Assembly constituencies in Gurugram and Palwal districts also makes the belt politically important for the INLD.

In a recent blow to the Congress in this region, two of its legislators - Punhana MLA Mohammad Ilyas and Hathin MLA Mohammad Israil - voted against the party nominee in the Rajya Sabha polls in April this year and were suspended by the party.

The INLD, now, appears keen to reclaim that lost political ground and tap into what it sees as growing disenchantment with the Congress.

"Muslim voters in the region had been voting for the Congress in the past two Assembly elections in the hope that it would dislodge the BJP government. But they now feel betrayed by the Congress, which failed to capitalise on the favourable political atmosphere in 2024 because of infighting and the personal ambitions of its leaders. They are now looking at the INLD as the only credible Opposition to the BJP," INLD convener and former Minister Sampat Singh told *The Hindu*.

Workers' meetings

Mr. Chautala and State president Rampal Majra have already held workers' meetings across all 90 Assembly constituencies, while special attention is being given to more than a dozen constituencies in and around Nuh, including Palwal, Hodal, Jhajjar, Beri and Pataudi.

Senior leaders, including Mr. Singh, his son Gaurav Sampat, Mr. Chautala's son Arjun and Mr. Majra, have been assigned these constituencies where they are holding village-level meetings to mobilise support for the rally.

R.C. Chavan's exit has diminished UCC draft panel credibility: MLA

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Samajwadi Party (SP) MLA Rais Shaikh has alleged that the credibility of Maharashtra's Uniform Civil Code (UCC) drafting committee was undermined after former Bombay High Court Judge R.C. Chavan resigned and demanded the appointment of a representative from the minority community.

The former judge has cited serious reservations over the panel's decision to restrict public feedback on crucial social issues to a binary 'Yes/No' format.

In a letter addressed to Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, the SP MLA alleged that preparation of the UCC draft is a political strategy by the BJP with an eye on elections.

He has demanded that a representative from the minority community be appointed on the panel to "enhance" its credibility.

"The committee was constituted in July. It has been given a six-month term. There is currently no representative from the minority community on the committee. As a result, the panel is being viewed with suspicion, and following Justice Chavan's resignation, its credibility has been further undermined," he said. Mr. Shaikh alleged the BJP is attempting to impose the "norms of the majority" through the proposed UCC.

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Probe on: Officials inspect the railway track after four students were hit by a train in Tekkali, Srikakulam district on Wednesday. PTI

Four students killed in train accident in A.P.; one hospitalised

The Hindu Bureau
VISAKHAPATNAM

Four Intermediate students died, and another sustained grievous injuries on Wednesday, after being run over by a train between Naupada and Tekkali railway stations in Srikakulam district, Andhra Pradesh.

According to railway officials, the incident occurred at around 12:45 p.m. when Train No. 18117 (Rourkela-Gunupur Express) hit the five persons walking on the railway tracks.

The deceased have been identified as Anguwada Visakha Rao (17), Janni Dileep Kumar (17), Janni Sharat Kumar (17), all hailing from Damara village in Tekkali mandal, and Savara Shiva (17) from Savara Street in Meliaputti village. All the victims were first-year Intermediate students of a government junior college in Tekkali. They died on the spot.

Another student, Ganguwada Salman Raju (18) from Damara village, sustained critical injuries. He was rushed to the government hospital in Tekkali.

Senior railway officials, along with Railway Protection Force and Government Railway Police personnel, rushed to the spot. The Self-Propelled Accident Relief Medical Equipment (SPARME) from Palasa railway station was mobilised to provide comprehensive relief support.

CM offers condolences

Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu expressed shock over the tragedy and offered condolences to the bereaved families.

Officials briefed the Chief Minister that the students failed to notice the train. Mr. Naidu directed the authorities to ensure advanced medical care for the injured student and extend the necessary support to the bereaved families.

Srikakulam Collector Swapnil Dinkar Pundkar instructed the police to submit a detailed report. The police have registered a case and launched an investigation.

SIT to probe graft allegations against Pinarayi in CMRL case

Inquiry initiated based on Enforcement Directorate's report; the agency has sought charges under PCA against former Keralam CM and his daughter; Home Department yet to issue official orders

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Keralam government has constituted a special investigation team (SIT) to probe the corruption allegations against Leader of the Opposition and former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, and son-in-law, former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas and others in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

The probe will be supervised by Additional Director-General of Police, Crime Branch, H. Venkatesh, with Superintendent of Police P. Vikraman leading probe, sources said.

The Home Department is yet to issue official orders constituting the SIT.



Hit the streets: A CPI(M) protest march in Kozhikode condemning the police inquiry ordered against Pinarayi Vijayan. K. RAGESH

The probe has been instituted on the basis of a report by the Enforcement Directorate to State Police Chief Ravada A. Chandrasekhar. The agency had sought registration of a case under the Prevention of Corruption Act (PCA) against Mr. Vijayan, Ms. Veena, and Mr. Riyas.

Mr. Chandrasekhar told mediapersons on Wednesday that the police would conduct a preliminary inquiry based on the communication by the ED.

He clarified that a Vigilance inquiry would not be initiated at the present stage.

He pointed out that the preliminary examination was necessary to determine whether a criminal case could be registered.

Earlier in the day, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said the government's intent was "not to target or take revenge on anyone."

'Vested interests'

Meanwhile, CPI(M) leader and former Minister P. Rajeeve accused Mr. Satheesan of aiding the political interests of the BJP by ordering a police inquiry into the controversy.

The Chief Minister's claim that the government has no option, but to initiate an inquiry as per Supreme Court judgments, is part of the efforts to act as per the vested interests of the BJP, he alleged.

Toll rises to five in Telangana hospital fire

Siddharth Kumar Singh
HYDERABAD

Infants died after a fire ripped through a neonatal care unit of RIMS Adilabad

The death toll from the fire at the Special Neonatal Care Unit (SNCU) of Rajiv Gandhi Institute of Medical Sciences (RIMS) in Telangana's Adilabad district has risen to five, with two more infants dying on Tuesday night.

The two infants were premature babies, born between 26 and 28 weeks of pregnancy, and weighed around one kg each, said Adilabad District Medical and Health Officer Sadhana.

The fire broke out around 11.40 p.m. on September 21 after an air conditioner in the reception area of the SNCU burst into flames. A five-day-old infant died in the incident, while another four-day-old infant died a fews hours later. A third female infant was declared dead while being shifted to a nearby hospital.

As many as 25 infants were rescued from the SNCU following the fire and shifted to various government and private hospitals in the vicinity. They are undergoing treatment and are being monitored by medical teams.

Inquiry ordered

Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy has ordered an inquiry into the incident to determine the circumstances that led to the fire. Health Minister C. Damodar Raja Narasimha visited RIMS Adilabad on Tuesday and met the families of the affected infants.

He assured them of the government's support and reviewed the condition of the infants who were shifted to other hospitals.

The Telangana government, on Wednesday, announced an *ex-gratia* of ₹5 lakh to the families of the children who died in the fire.



Eight UDP MLAs from Meghalaya after they joined the BJP in New Delhi on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Eight Meghalaya UDP legislators join BJP in presence of Rijiju

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Following the switchover, the BJP is now the second-largest party with 10 MLAs

Eight legislators of Meghalaya's United Democratic Party (UDP) on Wednesday joined the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), in the presence of Union Minister Kiren Rijiju and other senior leaders, at the party headquarters in New Delhi.

Following the switchover, the BJP is now the second-largest party with 10 MLAs after the National People's Party's (NPP) 33 in the Meghalaya government. The UDP's strength, on the other hand, has reduced from 12 to four. Both the UDP and the BJP are currently allies of the NPP-led government.

'Key development'

The eight legislators who joined the BJP are Lahkmen Rymbui, Pius Marwein, Kyrmen Shylla, Mayralborn Syiem, Matthew Kurbah, Ollan Singh Suin, Balajied Kupar Synrem, and Synshar Kupar Roy.

"It is an extremely important political development, not only for the Northeast but the entire country. It is a defining moment for Meghalaya... All of these eight MLAs were extremely impressed and influenced by Prime Minister Modi and our BJP-led NDA government's performance. They decided to join the BJP," said Mr. Rijiju at a joint press conference.

BJP MP Sambit Patra, who is the party's coordinator for northeastern States, was also present.

CM's reaction

Responding to the development, Meghalaya Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma said: "This is between two political parties and has nothing to do with the National People's Party. Our coalition strength remains the same... Therefore, it does not disturb the overall functioning of our government in any way."

INBRIEF



Keralam Cabinet decides to dissolve Loka Kerala Sabha

The Keralam Cabinet meeting on Wednesday formally decided to dissolve the Loka Kerala Sabha and replace it with an alternative mechanism that "benefits expatriate Keralites", Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan has said. For establishing the alternative mechanism, a Cabinet sub-committee chaired by the Chief Minister with Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala, Industries Minister P.K. Kunhalikutty, Health Minister K. Muraleedharan and Water Resources Minister Mons Joseph has been constituted.

Scan, pay, collect: temple in A.P. installs first 'laddu ATM'

Devotees at Indrakeeladri in Vijayawada can now get the Kanaka Durga temple's laddu prasadam the way they would buy a snack at an airport: pay by UPI and collect it from a machine. The self-service vending machine, introduced on a pilot basis at the Sri Durga Malleswara Swamy Varla Devasthanam on Wednesday, is the first of its kind at a temple in Andhra Pradesh, temple authorities said. The temple's Trust Board approved the machines, which it called 'laddu ATMs,' at its meeting on September 15.

₹1 lakh cr. horticulture hub to come up in Rayalaseema

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman are scheduled to lay the stone for the proposed Rayalaseema Horticulture Hub at Madanapalle on October 2. The Centre will provide ₹40,000 crore under the Purvodaya scheme for the project, and another ₹60,000 crore is expected from private investment, a press release said on Wednesday. It is aimed at promoting horticulture-related activities in drought-prone areas and increasing farm incomes by creating opportunities in the sector.

Bay watch



High waves roll in at RK Beach in Visakhapatnam. Several places in Andhra Pradesh recorded heavy rainfall under the influence of a deep depression over the Bay of Bengal. The weather system is likely to cross the coast, close to Kalingapatnam, by Wednesday night. K.R. DEEPAK

Cong. flags anomaly in BJP Nandigram candidate's affidavit

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

The academic qualifications of BJP candidate Hasirani Rath for the Nandigram bypoll in West Bengal predate her birth year, according to the affidavit she had filed for her nomination. The Opposition has lodged a complaint with the Election Commission against the discrepancy.

The affidavit mentions her highest qualification as Class 10 in 1965, and her age as over 60 years, indicating her birth year had to be 1965 or 1966.

On Wednesday, the State Congress unit also filed a writ petition in the Calcutta High Court in this regard. It also filed a plea seeking bail for its candidate Milan Pradhan, who has been arrested in four cases dating to 2007.

A court on September 19 sent him to judicial custody till October 3, leaving him with no time to campaign for the October 6 bypoll.

Bail hearing today

The High Court will hear the bail plea on Thursday.

The BJP dismissed the discrepancy in Ms. Rath's affidavit as a typographical error. She was a Class 10 student at the school mentioned in 1980, and not as seen in the affidavit, it said.

A.P. Police track missing 12-year-old using drone

The Hindu Bureau
KUPPAM

A 12-year-old boy who reportedly left home after a quarrel with his parents over a mobile phone was traced within two hours by Gudupalle police in Chittoor district, Andhra Pradesh, with the assistance of a surveillance drone.

After the boy's father lodged a missing person complaint, a team led by Sub-Inspector Srinivasulu deployed a drone and scanned the fields, hillocks and isolated stretches around the Nalagampalli village. The boy was eventually located at a bus stop near Tamil Nadu border.

Prakash Raj launches campaign to oppose SIR voter deletions

The Hindu Bureau
KALABURAGI

Actor and activist Prakash Raj launched an "SIR Resistance Tour" on Wednesday from Ramanagar, a predominantly nomadic settlement in Kalaburagi raising concerns over the deletion or proposed deletion of eligible voters from electoral rolls during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Karnataka.

He interacted with residents, including voters whose names had been placed in the Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate and Others (ASDDO) category.

Addressing press persons after the interaction, Mr. Raj claimed that 5,21,950 voters in Kalaburagi district had been placed under the ASDDO category. He questioned whether the existing mechanism would enable all such voters to establish their eligibility before the stipulated deadline.

Mr. Raj said only around 25,000 people had so far responded by submitting Form 6, according to information available to him. "Why should an existing voter be asked to register afresh through Form 6 just to retain their place on the electoral roll?" he asked.

He said he would visit different parts of the State and conclude the tour with a conference in Bengaluru on September 30.

Congress MLA in Karnataka 'quits' citing drought issue

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Congress MLA Yashwanthrayagouda V. Patil sent his resignation to Karnataka Speaker G.S. Patil on Tuesday, citing the government's failure to declare his Indi taluk in Vijayapura district as drought-hit.

Mr. Patil submitted that he was unable to meet the expectations of people in his constituency. He said farmers had suffered crop losses, and people and livestock were facing water shortages. Describing Mr. Patil's resignation as an emotional response, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said, "The MLA was emotional. I have pacified him."

Karnataka CM assures release of water to Telangana: Ministers

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Karnataka has responded positively to Telangana's request for the release of Krishna water to the Jurala Project, Ministers Jupally Krishna Rao and Vakiti Srihari said on Wednesday.

The Ministers said they met Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Tuesday and Wednesday, and explained the prevailing irrigation situation in Telangana. They stated that although Karnataka is also facing water constraints, Mr. Shivakumar took a sympathetic view of the difficulties faced by Telangana farmers and agreed to extend support.

They briefed him on the drought-like conditions caused by El Niño, the declining water levels at the Jurala Project, and the hardships being faced by farmers in the ayacut areas of the erstwhile Mahabubnagar district.

According to the Ministers, Mr. Shivakumar assured them that Karnataka would release water to the Jurala Project intermittently over the next 10 days.

Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy thanked Mr. Shivakumar for acceding to his government's request. "This is a great example of bonhomie between two different States and showcases the love and brotherhood of people of India," Mr. Revanth said in post on X.



D.K. Shivakumar with Telangana Ministers Jupally Krishna Rao, Vakiti Srihari, and MLAs from Mahabubnagar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Deep rot

With the SIR thoroughly vitiated, CEC Gyanesh Kumar must resign

The investigation by *The Indian Express* into the Election Commission of India's (ECI) functioning during its Special Intensive Revision (SIR) shows that the disquiet over what transpired under Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's watch is not limited to civil society, the media and the Opposition. It ran through the ECI itself, as Election Commissioners (EC) Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi objected on record at least 14 times between October 2025 and August 2026 to decisions, many of which, they said, were taken without their knowledge. Their dissent mirrors what many have long said about the SIR. In May, Mr. Joshi had warned that Form 6, the application for new electors, could not be altered without the government amending the rules. Yet, in July, the form contained questions on whether the applicants or their parents or grandparents figured in the "electoral roll of the last SIR", which Mr. Sandhu called "unauthorised and illegal". The ECs also flagged the centralisation of the electoral roll database, sought an audit, and recorded that field officials lacked complete access to the ERONet portal. This mirrors what local election officials had complained of: that many of the changes in the rolls were done at the central database level overriding Electoral Registration Officers, the statutory authority on voters' eligibility.

The consequences of the anomalies in the ECI's decision-making and its functioning were the deepest in West Bengal. About 60 lakh electors were flagged for software-generated "logical discrepancies" – many were dubious – and 27 lakh names were deleted. Of the 38 lakh appeals pending before tribunals, 16.1 lakh were by those seeking to remove voters whom judicial officers had included; Mr. Sandhu's question of who authorised filing them on the ECI's behalf remains unanswered. Meanwhile, over nine in 10 appeals against deletion decided so far have restored the electors, which suggests that the exercise struck off lakhs of genuine voters before the West Bengal elections. *The Hindu*'s analysis also revealed that 24 of the 70 seats in Delhi now have fewer electors in draft rolls than those who actually voted just a year and a half ago. On Wednesday, Justice Dipankar Datta, as part of a two-judge Bench, held in his opinion that the 2023 Act's replacement of the CJI, whom the Anoop Baranwal judgment had placed on the selection panel, with a Union Minister, fails the "perception test". It was this panel that chose Mr. Kumar as CEC. Regrettably, the Supreme Court had earlier upheld the SIR without adequately confronting its design, which deletes electors before verification and places the burden of proving eligibility on the citizen rather than the state, thereby defeating the constitutional guarantee of universal adult franchise. Mr. Kumar must resign and the Court must halt further deletions until the roll database is audited. Anything less will be a defeat for India's democracy.

Trading smart

India-NZ FTA shows how smaller deals can complement big-bang trade pacts

The India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA), set to come into force on October 20, is a good example of why India is right in simultaneously pushing for trade deals with smaller trade partners along with the major global economies. On the face of it, it would be easy to dismiss the $1.1 billion of bilateral goods trade between the two countries as being less than 1% of India's total goods trade. A doubling by 2030, as envisaged under the deal, is still a minuscule amount. Yet, trade is not simply a macroeconomic indicator. It is also a source of livelihood for lakhs of businesses, nearly half of which are micro, small, and medium enterprises. These exporters need all the help that they can get in the current trade environment. Adverse developments related to tariffs or the closure of trade routes can be mitigated to an extent by a nimble rerouting of trade to other countries where Indian exporters receive an advantage. With 100% U.S. tariffs looming and a trade deal with Washington remaining elusive, India needs to open up as many alternative channels for its exporters as possible. The New Zealand FTA delivers – India has managed to receive duty-free access on 100% of its exports, a historic concession. India has a good mix of capital- and labour-intensive exports to New Zealand that stand to benefit. Textiles make up about 14% of India's exports, while pearls and semi-precious stones constitute another 5% or so. On the capital-intensive side, one-third of India's exports are pharmaceuticals, parts of nuclear reactors, vehicular parts, mineral fuels, electrical machinery, and iron and steel.

India has also done well in its handling of sensitive sectors. While the opening up of India's dairy sector was a major demand by the New Zealand negotiators, India held firm and excluded it from the deal. In total, nearly 30% of India's import lines have been kept outside the tariff concessions. On labour mobility, India has won some valuable concessions on visas for workers and students. At a time when several western countries are clamping down on foreign worker inflows, such alternative routes provide relief. India has also extracted a commitment from New Zealand to facilitate investments of $20 billion in India over 15 years, smaller but along the same lines as in the agreement with the EFTA bloc. India needs foreign investment not just for its economic growth but also to manage its balance of payments. This FTA is a good blueprint on how India can use its growing international heft to negotiate overwhelmingly in its favour.

India and the plausible multilateralism of BRICS



Varghese K. George



Stanly Johny

BRICS gatherings always trigger heated debates in India. The primary reason is the importance that the strategic and policymaking community, comprising both optimists and sceptics, attaches to this platform, of which India is an integral pillar. While optimists argue that BRICS could function as an institution capable of multipolarising the global order, or expediting that transition, sceptics highlight the grouping's internal divisions and worry about its possible domination by Russia and China. A third group writes off BRICS altogether, dismissing it as little more than an annual gathering that generates strategic noise. They argue that India should be wary of close association with the grouping and instead focus on preserving and expanding its partnership with the United States, which, in their view, is the only viable path to India's rise.

The 18th BRICS summit, held in New Delhi on September 12-13, 2026, attracted greater national and global attention because of its timing and location. It was the first BRICS annual summit since the U.S. and Israel launched their unprovoked war against Iran, in India's extended neighbourhood, on February 28, 2026. The summit, which brought together the Presidents of Iran, Russia and China, among other leaders, was hosted by India, a close strategic partner of the U.S. and Israel.

Consensus in Delhi

Despite its internal contradictions and the broader chaos enveloping international politics, the summit can be seen as a success on multiple levels. That New Delhi could forge a consensus among the 11 member-countries, including the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Iran, which are involved in an undeclared conflict, was itself an achievement. The Delhi Declaration shows that, despite their differences and even disputes, member-countries continue to find value in supporting a BRICS worldview rooted in the pursuit of a more representative global order.

The consensus was reached through compromises by all parties. Consider India's position. Prime Minister Narendra Modi was in Israel just two days before Israel and the U.S. started bombing Iran. India initially refrained from condemning the attacks or the assassination of Iran's Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. This created an impression that New Delhi was siding with the U.S. and Israel. India also watched from the sidelines as Pakistan seized on the diplomatic opening created by the war and stepped in as a mediator between the U.S. and Iran. But India quickly repositioned itself as a traditional balancer in West Asia.

Multilateral platforms such as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) and BRICS provided New Delhi with space to restore that balancing posture without causing strategic damage to its bilateral relationships. India strongly endorsed the Bishkek resolution of the SCO in September, condemning the strikes on Iran and expressing condolences to the country over the killing of Khamenei. It also hosted Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian for the Delhi BRICS summit, even as the war in West Asia grinds on. The image of Mr. Modi walking hand in hand with Mr. Pezeshkian is unlikely to fade any time soon in Washington or Tel Aviv.

> The very structure of BRICS offers India space to pursue strategic autonomy amid intensifying great-power rivalries

Second, while there is no immediate resolution to the border problems with China, which continue to simmer, there is momentum in efforts to reset ties. Multilateral forums such as BRICS provide a platform for India and China to remain engaged even when high-level bilateral visits are not taking place. Their differences are not going to disappear; they have to learn to manage their troubled relationship. History suggests that a lack of engagement between competing major powers can only deepen mistrust, while deepening mistrust, combined with the security dilemma stemming from their competition, could have dangerous consequences. So, it is important for India and China to stay engaged, bilaterally and multilaterally, creating guardrails for competitive coexistence.

Third, on all the major global issues of the present – artificial intelligence regulation, the rules governing global trade and finance, climate change, border conflicts, and the role and status of multilateral bodies – BRICS members may have different approaches and priorities, but they converge on the point that unilateralism by any bloc or power is detrimental to their interests and to the planet.

The Washington predictability

The context in which the Delhi summit was held is also crucial. The total predictability of the U.S. approach – rather than the unpredictability that some commentators labour to establish – towards the rest of the world is that it does not care much about anything other than its own dominance. Several BRICS members have had their own difficult experiences with the U.S., and they are trying to chart their own paths forward. India, a few months ago, was slapped with varying tariffs by Washington. India was also one of the countries most affected economically by the U.S.-Israel war on Iran. On September 16, the U.S. House passed the Russia sanctions Bill, seeking to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries including India.

India's foreign policy under Mr. Modi has been interpreted by a section of the strategic commentariat as an evident tilt towards the U.S. camp. Statements by Mr. Modi himself in the early years of his premiership that India had overcome its "hesitation of history" in ties with Washington gave further impetus to this view, though there has also been the parallel official formulation of *'sabke sath'* foreign policy, or multi-alignment. India has always had a more complex view of history. And even if it has overcome its "hesitation of history", it has not abandoned the hesitations of its strategic realism.

When India looks back at history and looks around the world today, it sees that countries that become frontiers in great-power rivalries often pay a huge price. If Pakistan's story is not instructive enough, there are two live battlefronts that illustrate this every day – the UAE and Ukraine.

The UAE and Iran would have been better off dealing with each other than facing the situation in which they currently find themselves. The UAE-Iran bilateral meeting on the sidelines of BRICS in Delhi marks an acknowledgment of this lesson and a quest to use multilateral platforms to address bilateral challenges. Ukraine, which, backed by the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), has been fighting Russia for more than four years, does not have any such platform to maintain direct contact with Moscow – which leaves Kyiv's diplomatic options totally dependent on the whims and wishes of Brussels and Washington.

India's learning

This is not to argue that India should downgrade its relations with the U.S. The strategic partnership with Washington is extremely important for India's progress and development, but what India must not allow itself to become, at any cost, is a frontline in the U.S.-China competition. BRICS enables India to pursue that path without having to champion an anti-U.S. agenda or undermine its cooperation with Washington. The U.S., which had come to terms with India's firm adherence to strategic autonomy, has recently been pushing the envelope to draw New Delhi into a more subordinate relationship. For Washington, this is an ongoing theme. But India should pursue multiple pathways to its rise rather than succumb to the temptations of unequal great-power alliances.

While it is true that there are serious internal divisions among BRICS members, there is also a larger reality of external convergence of interests among them. BRICS is not an organisation like the G-7, where American primacy and the western order are accepted by all member-countries. Nor is it the case that every multilateral or plurilateral grouping is converging on all points.

The divisions within BRICS, to a certain extent, prevent any one country from dominating the grouping, while the external convergence of interests – their shared belief that the post-war international system is unfair and that a more representative order should be built – could hold the group together as it lays the foundations and builds the blocks of a new order. The dialectical relationship between internal contradictions and external convergence could ultimately produce a synthesis, which is increasingly evident in the case of BRICS. The contradictions within are therefore not a reason to question the grouping's existence; they are, in fact, part of the reason why it should exist and flourish.

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Quality control and India's manufacturing growth



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India needs firms that can grow, integrate into global value chains and compete internationally. To make this happen, the Quality Control Order (QCO) reassessment exercise needs to move forward.

Concerns over India's QCOs and other non-tariff barriers also surfaced during the WTO's eighth Trade Policy Review of India, held in July 2026, and were raised not only by major trading partners such as the European Union and the United States, but also by fellow BRICS members, including Brazil, China and Indonesia.

The number of products covered under QCOs expanded rapidly after 2019, from 88 products in 2019 to 765 by the end of December 2024. However, the pace of expansion slowed considerably towards the end of 2025. This was driven by an important shift in the government's approach, with several QCOs being revoked or suspended, particularly those covering intermediate goods, as mandatory certification had raised concerns about input availability, costs and potential supply-chain disruptions.

The government's new order

Recently, the government introduced the Transition Facilitation (Quality Control) Order, 2026, notified by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) on June 25, 2026. The order seeks to ease regulatory bottlenecks by allowing eligible firms facing difficulties in obtaining BIS Scheme-I certification to source products temporarily from BIS Scheme-II-licensed suppliers in specified sectors, including toys, footwear and air conditioners. Access to this transition mechanism is subject to prescribed eligibility criteria and approval by a committee constituted by the DPIIT.

These developments are welcome steps towards reducing the risk that quality regulations inadvertently disrupt supply chains or constrain domestic manufacturing. More than 600 QCO-covered products remain to be reassessed, including several critical intermediate inputs used across key manufacturing sectors such as chemicals, steel, textiles, machinery and electronics, and rubber and plastics.

> India's Quality Control Order (QCO) reset must go further in a changing global trade order

Existing regulations can place a disproportionate burden on smaller industrial players, both by constraining their access to critical inputs and by imposing relatively high compliance costs. Given the extensive downstream linkages of these inputs, the next phase of QCO rationalisation should focus particularly on regulations affecting intermediate goods and assess their implications not only for product quality but also for input availability, costs, competitiveness and domestic value addition.

Findings of a recent study

In this regard, a recent CSEP study examined this question in detail for firms that use chemicals. Chemicals are critical intermediate inputs for downstream sectors such as rubber and plastics, pharmaceuticals and electronics, among others. The first QCO for a chemical product was introduced in 2018, and the number of chemical products covered rose to 52 by 2024. Consequently, the share of chemical-using firms exposed to regulation on the input side rose from 11.8% in 2019 to 56.6% in 2024.

When examining the impact of QCOs on chemicals on downstream user industries, the study finds that the effects vary considerably by firm size. Among larger firms, input QCOs are associated with a 9.6% increase in production alongside a sharp 37% decline in gross value added (GVA). This suggests that while larger firms can sustain and even expand output, this comes at the cost of lower value addition, potentially reflecting higher input costs and their ability to pass on at least part of these costs through higher output prices.

For smaller firms, input QCOs have no statistically significant effect on production or GVA but are associated with a steep 47.6% decline in profitability. This points to their more limited ability to absorb rising input costs and bear the additional compliance costs associated with QCOs.

The empirical evidence makes it clear that the adverse effects of QCOs on key inputs are not confined to smaller downstream firms. Even larger firms, which are better placed to absorb regulatory and input-cost shocks and are often able to sustain production, can experience significant declines in value addition. Supply-chain implications should therefore become an integral part of both the design of new QCOs and the reassessment of existing ones. Finally, the disproportionate burden on Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME) requires specific policy attention. Smaller firms need dedicated assistance to meet certification and compliance requirements, alongside appropriately designed exemptions or transition periods where compliance costs are particularly burdensome.

Quality standards, greater scale

As India works towards the ambition of Viksit Bharat 2047, achieving greater scale in manufacturing will be critical. Quality standards have an important role to play in that journey, but their success should ultimately be judged not by the number of products brought under mandatory regulation, but by whether they improve quality without constraining the scale, efficiency and competitiveness of Indian manufacturing.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Court's message

The Supreme Court of India's observations on singing all six stanzas of the National Song, *Vande Mataram*, while bringing respite to lakhs of citizens, rightly bring back the issue to a fundamental constitutional principle: freedom of conscience (Front page, September 23). Respect for a national song may be encouraged, but it need not be rammed down a citizen's throat. The Court's reference to the Bijoe Emmanuel verdict — in the far less problematic National Anthem case, at that — is a timely reminder that a citizen may decline to sing when doing so conflicts with deeply held religious or conscientious beliefs. National symbols should unite citizens, not place their conscience on trial. A democracy is secure enough to distinguish between disrespect and conscientious dissent, and between voluntary, spontaneous patriotism and compelled conformity. One should not forget that there is more to patriotism than mere singing, sloganeering and chest-thumping.

M. Jameel Ahmed,
Mysuru

Unsafe Delhi

It is horrendous that the capital city has become unsafe and dangerous for women ("Delhi L-G directs formation of 'Pink Force' to curb crime", September 23). Unless stringent laws are put in place and speedy punishment is ensured for perpetrators, such incidents will continue to occur and young lives scarred. It is the confidence of perpetrators that they can evade justice that encourages them to continue such abhorrent and abominable acts.

Balagopal Gopinath,
Keerikkad, Alappuzha, Keralam

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name.

Limits of the casting vote at Tata Sons



Prasanth Raju

Advocate practising in the Bombay High Court. Views are personal

On September 17, the board of Tata Sons voted on a third five-year term for N. Chandrasekaran as Executive Chairman. Mr. Chandrasekaran abstained from voting voluntarily and the recorded result was four to one. Within hours the Tata Trusts, owners of about 66% of Tata Sons, called the decision legally void. The claim rests on how several provisions of the Articles of Association, the company's rulebook, fit together.

With a 66% share, the Trusts could have packed the board. Instead, under Article 104B, the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust act jointly and nominate one-third of the directors. So now, on a board of six, two seats are held by Noel Tata and Venu Srinivasan.

Article 121 gives these seats their weight; any matter the board decides by majority requires the affirmative vote of a majority of these nominated directors. If the votes are equal, the chairman has a casting vote.

The chairmanship is built in steps. A person must first be a director. A new Chairman of the Board is appointed under Article 118, subject to the voting requirement in Article 121 (whether it also governs a reappointment is disputed). Only a Chairman may be made Executive Chairman under Article 105(b).

On September 17, the nominees split – Mr. Srinivasan for and Mr. Tata against. Harish Manwani, an independent director chairing the item in Mr. Chandrasekaran's place, reportedly used a casting vote in favour.

In the Cyrus Mistry litigation in 2019, the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) called the nominees' affirmative vote indispensable, which the top court later upheld in 2021. Neither court had to decide whether a casting vote can cure a split between the two nominees.

Where the readings part

Tata Sons relies on two legal opinions. Senior advocate Sudipto Sarkar has advised that a casting vote can break a tie between the nominees as well as a board tie – that whoever presides may use it because Article 121 says Chairman, and not Chairman of the Board. Justice B.N. Srikrishna, a former Supreme Court judge, agrees and advised that since no majority could be found between the nominees, the casting vote ended the deadlock. However, the Trusts referred to a contrary opinion held by former Chief Justice D.Y. Chandrachud.

The company's reading has a textual footing: the words about equal votes do not say whose votes are meant. But Article 121 has two parts and they must be read together. The first sets a condition: a majority of the Trusts' nominees must support the decision. The second breaks a tie when the board is evenly split. The board as a whole was not evenly divided; the only split was between the two nominees. With two nominees, a majority means both. When Justice Srikrishna says no majority could be found, it means that the condition was not met. The company's reading uses the tie-break to make up for it. The Trusts' reading gives each part its own role. If both nominees support a decision and the other four directors divide evenly, the board is tied three all, and the casting vote settles it.

Other parts of the rulebook support this reading. Articles 104B, 86 and 118 resolve any difference between the two Trusts by a majority of their trustees, never by the chair of a board meeting.

Defending these rules against Mr. Mistry in 2019, Tata Sons itself argued that where the Articles require the support of particular directors, a decision passes only if those directors agree. Here, those are the two Trust nominees. Mr. Manwani is an independent director; on the Trusts' reading, his casting vote cannot stand in for their agreement. The minutes of the meeting Mr. Tata has produced record the February 2022 extension of Mr. Chandrasekaran's tenure as made under Article 118, and Article 118 is itself subject to Article 121.

The advisers argue, with some force, that no selection committee was needed for a reappointment, and that Mr. Chandrasekaran's August letter (wherein he detailed he did not wish to hold the post) did not bind him. Neither point changes Article 121's arithmetic: with both nominees present, the required majority was two.

Only a director can be chairman, so directorship matters. The August general meeting was adjourned for want of a quorum before shareholders could consider Mr. Chandrasekaran's reappointment.

The Trusts are weighing legal proceedings. A mutual settlement is preferred to a lengthy litigation, which could spiral into uncertainty about the group's leadership.

A mutual settlement is preferred to a lengthy litigation, which could spiral into uncertainty about the group's leadership

Delhi's infra-governance problem



Kartavi Satyarthi

Senior Resident Fellow, Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy

Every year, news of an infrastructural disaster in Delhi taking precious student lives sends shock-waves across the nation. Investigations into enforcement of building bye-laws, suspension of officials, and arrest of landlords gain momentum for some time and slowly settle down until yet another year invokes a fresh infrastructural horror. It is Satya Niketan now, it was a flooded basement in Rajinder Nagar two years ago. Delhi houses millions of students who move to the city either to join premier institutes or to prepare for competitive government exams. This influx of students has created a sprawling ecosystem of largely unregulated Paying Guest (PG) accommodations and coaching centres.

PGs have over time transformed from an extra room in a house rented out for extra cash to full-blown commercial establishments. Moreover, several coaching centres also operate in certain floors of buildings marked as residential establishments. This changes the nature and use-type of the building from residential to partly or wholly commercial and ideally makes them subject to a completely different set of safety norms. Municipal laws, regulations and bye-laws govern safety norms for residential and commercial buildings in the Union Territory but there is a significant enforcement gap which is unable to identify/accommodate these hybrid establishments. Regulations that would typically apply to similar establishments such as schools and college hostels are not directly applicable to these establishments. Therefore, PGs and coaching institutes need to be recognised as a separate category of mixed-use educational buildings under municipal and urban local body regulations.

PGs and coaching institutes need to be recognised as a separate category of mixed-use educational buildings under municipal and urban local body regulations

Delhi's regulatory framework is split across the Master Plan of Delhi (MPD), the Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL) and the Ministry of Education's 2024 coaching centre guidelines. Together, they create an odd mismatch between the law on paper and the way it actually functions. The MPD does not specifically mention PGs, and while the UBBL recognises coaching centres as an educational building, development controls prescribed under the bye-laws are not applicable to coaching centres. The Guidelines lack teeth and cover only broad infrastructural requirements. Thus, the regulatory landscape falls severely deficient in accounting for the on-ground realities of the city, especially student-focused areas such as Rajinder Nagar, Mukherjee Nagar and Satya Niketan.

The road ahead

The regulatory landscape needs to solve for two gaps – one, the absence of substantive safety standards for mixed-use educational buildings, and two, the lack of routine enforcement. Both the Delhi Development Authority and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi need to acknowledge coaching centres and PGs as a separate category of land-use. Specific standards applicable to such mixed-use educational buildings need to be developed prescribing requirements such as appropriate protection against fire hazards, safe exits, minimum floor area per person, maximum capacity of a mixed-use building etc. Individuals aiming to open a PG or coaching centre may register the building in this separate category.

To enable enforcement, it is essential to note that the prescription of blanket minimum standards with little recourse for correction may encourage rent-seeking and by-passing of regulatory requirements through illegal means. Accordingly, an enforcement mechanism needs to be established which provides support to building owners to enable them to ensure compliance with the prescribed minimum standards. The following process may be followed to ensure compliance: a building safety task force or district-level committee with State oversight must be created consisting of representatives from urban local bodies; periodic audit of mixed-use educational buildings must be conducted; a compliance resolution plan which highlights compliance gaps and whether such gaps are capable of being addressed should be drawn up (in cases where the flagged gaps are alarming the building may be shut down immediately); and periodic annual reports must be submitted by the safety task force to the State government showcasing the number of buildings shut down and the number of buildings rehabilitated.

It is time to re-evaluate urban governance models and regulatory infrastructure; preferably before the next headline of an infrastructural disaster devouring young lives.

The backdrop in which the U.S. Fed raised interest rate

Inflation in the U.S. hit a peak in May, at 4.2%, after which it climbed down to 3.4% — far above the Federal Reserve's target of 2%

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis

On September 16, the U.S. Federal Reserve raised the short-term interest rate – its main policy rate, broadly comparable to the Reserve Bank of India's repo rate – for the first time in three years, by 25 basis points from a range of 3.5% to 3.75% to a range of 3.75% to 4%.

Chart 1 shows the short-term interest rate, also called the federal funds rate, seeing its first increase this month after being brought down a few times since 2023.

Coming ahead of the mid-term polls in the U.S., the interest rate hike disappointed supporters of President Donald Trump as its current Chair Kevin Warsh was handpicked by Mr. Trump, who has been vociferous in his opposition to increases in the interest rate.

Soon after the announcement about the increase, Mr. Trump took to Truth Social to register his opposition and said the interest rate "should be 1 % or less" and argued that higher rates have allowed other countries to benefit.

However, multiple indicators that influence each other show that the increase was almost inevitable. The key indicator is the inflation rate that has not come down to acceptable limits since the beginning of the war the U.S. and Israel started with Iran earlier this year. Long-term bond yields, pushed up by inflation fears and by heavy government borrowing, added to the pressure on the Fed as holding the rates risked signalling that it was going soft on inflation.

Need to bring down inflation

Mr. Warsh, along with 11 members of the Federal Open Market Committee, made this decision to combat inflation. "The plain fact is that inflation is too high and has been for too long," he said at a press conference.

As per the Consumer Price Index data released for August, overall inflation in the States continued to be at 3.4% in August. **Chart 3** depicts the U.S.'s rate of inflation throughout 2026.

The sharpest jump in inflation took place in March, after the beginning of the U.S.-Israel war with Iran in February.

Inflation in the U.S. hit a peak in May, at 4.2%, after which it climbed down to 3.4%, still far above the Federal Reserve's 2% target, which it measures using the Personal Consumption Expenditures (PCE) price index.

Meanwhile, the benchmark 10-year U.S. Treasury bond yields also started increasing after the Iran conflict, resulting in higher borrowing costs for the government.

Chart 2 shows the increase, which was seen in other major economies as well. While the chart shows monthly data till August, the yield on the 10-year bonds crossed the key threshold of 5% on September 14.

Rising debt

One of the factors influencing the markets to drive the long-term bond yields up is the public debt of the U.S., which is increasing at a rate faster than the growth of its Gross Domestic Product (GDP).

The country's debt-to-GDP ratio saw sharp rises in 2008, during the housing finance crisis, and its highest jump of more than 25 percentage points was in 2020, during the COVID-19 pandemic **(Chart 4)**.

As of the first quarter of 2026, debt was 122.6% of the country's GDP. This ratio is nearly twice of what it was just 20 years ago, in 2006.

The cost of servicing the increased debt is so high that the net interest payments by the U.S. government **(Chart 5)** is higher than its spending on Medicare, health, and interestingly even defence – which according to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute accounts for one-third of global military spending.

Putting out fires

The data for the charts were sourced from Federal Reserve Economic Data (by the Research Department at the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis) and USAspending.gov



Tough times: U.S. President Donald Trump shakes hands with Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh in the White House in Washington, D.C. REUTERS

CHART 1: *The increase in the short-term interest rate by the U.S. Federal Reserve* **for the first time since July 2023**

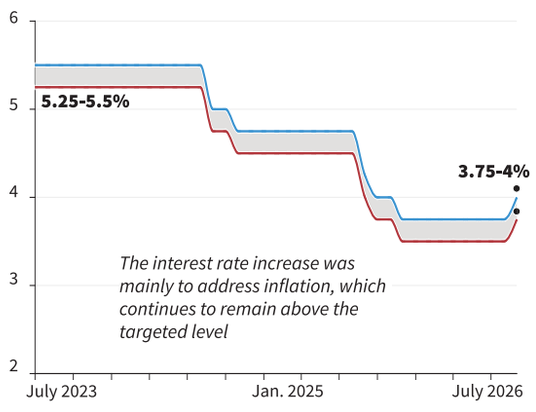


CHART 2: The long-term bond yields of some other key economies have also gone up along with that of the U.S. Japan's yield hit 2.94%, the highest since 1998

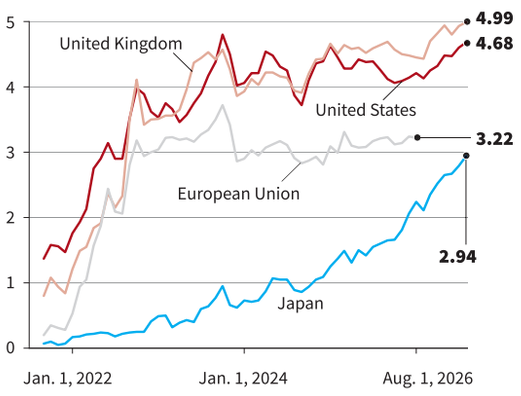


CHART 3: As fuel prices soared after the war began, inflation in the U.S. accelerated and hit retail and food prices, and is much higher than the Fed's target of 2%

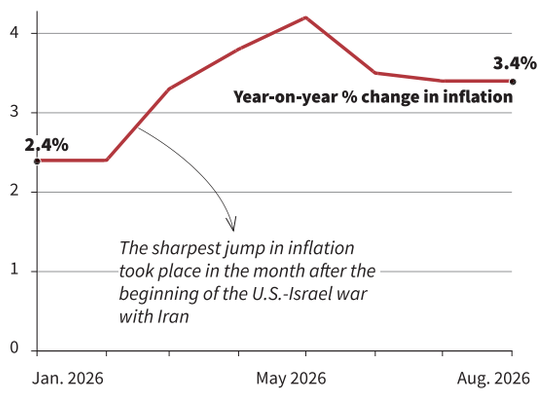


CHART 4: The U.S.'s public debt is increasing at a rate faster than the growth of its Gross Domestic Product

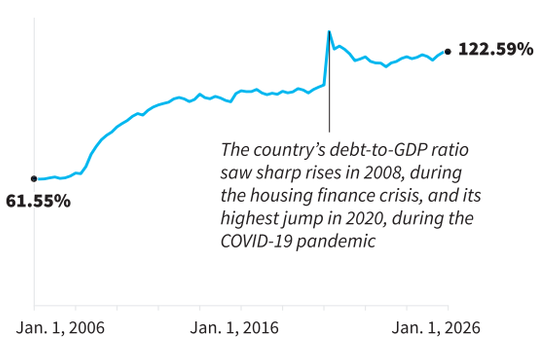
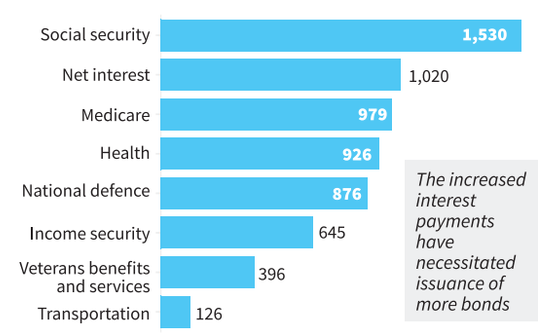


CHART 5: Net interest payments by the U.S. government is only smaller than its social security expenditure. Values in $ billion



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 24, 1976

Mars may have more water than Earth

Pasadena (California), September 23: Mars is like a giant ice-lollipop packed with vast quantities of frozen water – and it might even possess more water than earth, according to U.S. scientists.

Viking project scientists here said the martian north polar cap had been found to contain huge amounts of water ice and the rest of the red planet's rocky surface might be a thin blanket over an enormous ice sheet.

The announcement of the Viking space probe findings ended a long-standing dispute over whether martian polar caps might be composed of frozen carbon dioxide instead of water ice.

The experts made it clear at a press conference there was more water on mars than they ever expected.

"Mars can perhaps be described as an iceberg floating in a sea of rock and the north pole is the top," said Dr. Barney Famer, head of the Viking Water Vapour Mapping Team.

Dr. William McElroy, an atmospheric scientist, said it was possible there was more water in various forms on mars than on earth, '"Everywhere you look on mars you see water," he said.

"There was a time when we thought there was no water on mars," Viking project scientist Gerald Soffen told reporters. "Now we find there are massive amounts of water frozen in the north polar cap."

The discovery was made when the orbiting vehicle which carried the Viking landing craft to mars made low, temperature reading passes over the north pole.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 24, 1926

New cure for Malaria

Berlin, September 23: A new cure for Malaria, by means of a synthetic preparation "Plasmochin", was explained at the Scientists' and Doctors' Congress at Duesseldorf. It was claimed that it was more effective than quinine. Experiments were at first conducted by Professor Shell on lunatics who were specially infected with malaria germs, after which "Plasmochin" was successfully tested by Professor Muchlens of Hahmburg Tropical Institute on over a hundred victims of malaria from various parts of world. In many cases, permanent cure is believed to have been effected.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Cost of Chandni Chowk's Town Hall redevelopment

225 in ₹ cr. Redevelopment proposal for the Town Hall situated in Delhi's Chandni Chowk has been initiated with an estimate cost of ₹225 crore. An MoU was signed between the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi. PTI

Daily fuel losses faced by oil firms as crude prices surge

530 in ₹ crore. Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd are losing ₹8 a litre on petrol and ₹9 on diesel, while under-recoveries on LPG stand at about ₹300 a cylinder. The daily loss to OMCs is estimated at ₹530 crore. PTI

Percentage growth recorded by retail sector in August

10 in per cent. India's retail sector maintained a steady trajectory in August, recording a 10% year-on-year pan-India growth, according to a survey. Building on July's recovery, stable consumer demand across regions and categories indicates strong industry preparation for the festive peak. PTI

Decline in seafood export value from Odisha to West Asia

14.5 in per cent. The export value of fish, shrimp and other seafood items from Odisha to the West Asia region declined by 14.57% in 2025-26, resulting in a loss of approximately ₹23.40 crore, Minister Gokulananda Mallik said on Wednesday. PTI

Percentage hike in DA for employees notified by Punjab govt.

8 in per cent. The Punjab government notified an 8% increase in dearness allowance for government employees and pensioners. This reflects the government's commitment towards the financial well-being of its employees and pensioners, a statement said. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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How are road accident claims decided?

Who can file a motor accident claim? Who is liable to pay? When can an insurer be directed to pay and recover? Who can claim compensation for a deceased person? What are the four heads of compensation in a death case?

EXPLAINER

Kartikey Singh
Barkha Dwivedi

The story so far:
India has the world's largest road network, spanning about 6.7 million kilometres, larger than the U.S.'s 6.59 million km and China's 5.49 million km, but it also records the world's highest road fatalities. Over-speeding and reckless driving, poor road upkeep, inadequate driver training, and weak emergency and trauma care continue to make road crashes a severe public-safety crisis.

According to the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways' *Road Accidents in India 2024* report, 4,87,707 road accidents in 2024 claimed 1,77,175 lives (about 485 deaths a day or 20 an hour) and injured 4,71,441 people. With road crashes estimated to cost around 3.14% of India's GDP, their impact extends beyond lost economic productivity, falling most heavily on dependants of those killed or permanently disabled. Yet, for many claimants, courts' quantification and compensation awards remain difficult to navigate.

What is the legal framework?
The Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 (MV Act) is the principal law governing motor-accident compensation. The MV Act creates a statutory scheme covering the entire accident chain, from regulation and driver and owner duties to insurance, liability, investigation, and compensation. For adjudicating claims, Section 165 empowers State governments to constitute Motor Accidents Claims Tribunals (MACTs) for specified areas to determine claims arising from motor-vehicle accidents.

Under Section 166, a claim may be filed by the injured person, the owner of damaged property, or, in case of death, by all or any of the deceased's legal representatives (LRs). The insurer, owner, and driver are ordinarily parties to the proceedings, as the Tribunal must determine both the amount of compensation and the party liable to pay it. The claim is ordinarily first heard by the MACT, which is the primary fact-finding and compensation-awarding forum. An appeal under Section 173 may be filed before the High Court within 90 days, subject to the depositing of ₹25,000 or 50% of the awarded amount, whichever is less. In determining liability, the Tribunal typically examines the FIR and chargesheet, site plan, Mechanical Inspection Report, post-mortem report or medical/disability records, insurance policy, and the depositions of eyewitnesses and the investigating officer, etc.

Importantly, the same accident may generate two distinct proceedings: a criminal case for offences such as rash or negligent driving, and a separate MACT claim for compensation. As held by the apex court in *Reena v. Managing Director, KSRTC* (2026), an acquittal in the criminal case does not affect the MACT proceedings, since the two operate in distinct legal spheres and apply different "standards of proof".

Who is liable to pay the compensation?
Liability initially attaches to the negligent driver and, vicariously, to the owner of the offending vehicle. Where the vehicle is insured, the insurer generally satisfies the award. Section 146 mandates compulsory third-party insurance, while Section 150 requires insurers to satisfy awards arising from third-party risks,

The compensation formula

The Supreme Court's framework breaks down compensation into four heads before the final amount is calculated

Step	Head of compensation	Formula	Result
1	Loss of dependency (Loss of income)	[(Annual income + future prospects) − deduction)] × multiplier	(A)
2	Loss of estate	Flat conventional figure (base: ₹15,000; currently after 10% increase per 3 year: ₹18,150/-)	(B)
3	Funeral expenses	Flat conventional figure (base: ₹15,000; currently after 10% increase per 3 year: ₹18,150/-)	(C)
4	Loss of consortium (spousal/parental/filial)	Flat conventional figure (base: ₹40,000; currently after 10% increase per 3 year: ₹48,400/-) × Number of claimants entitled to consortium	(D)
	TOTAL COMPENSATION		(A) + (B) + (C) + (D)

Prepared as per the framework laid down by the Supreme Court in Sarla Verma (2009) and Pranay Sethi (2017)



Under Section 166, a claim may be filed by the injured person, the owner of damaged property, or, in case of death, by any of the deceased's legal representatives

subject to limited defences under Section 150(2), including specified policy breaches, unauthorised use, driving without a valid licence, and non-disclosure or misrepresentation in obtaining the policy. Even where a defence is established, courts may apply the "pay and recover" principle, directing the insurer to pay the victim/LRs first and recover the amount from the owner or driver thereafter.

A separate "no-fault liability" route dispenses with proof of negligence and provides compensation of ₹5 lakh for death and ₹2.5 lakh for grievous hurt (post the 2019 amendment), payable by the owner or authorised insurer, without proof of negligence.

How to calculate compensation in accidental deaths?
Money cannot substitute for a life lost, but motor-accident compensation seeks to ease the financial burden on the deceased's dependants. Section 168 of the MV Act requires an award of "just" compensation. Through landmark decisions such as *Sarla Verma* (2009) and *Pranay Sethi* (2017), the top court has evolved standardised formulas and foundational principles for giving effect to this requirement. Once "rash and negligent" driving is established, the quantum can broadly be understood as a three-stage exercise: first, establishing the foundational facts; second, applying them to the prescribed heads and formulae; and third, aggregating the amounts to arrive at the final award.

The first stage is to establish three facts: (1) the deceased's age at the time of the accident, (2) annual income and (3) number of dependants. "Age" can be established, among others, from the date of birth recorded in the school-leaving certificate and not from the Aadhaar card, as was ruled in *Saroj* (2024) by the Supreme Court. "Income" means actual income less income tax paid (as per *Pranay Sethi*). The Supreme Court in *Rashmirekha Tripathy* (2026) held that, for salaried persons, the ITR of the immediately preceding assessment year should ordinarily be considered, while for self-employed persons or business owners, the Tribunal should take the average income reflected in the preceding three years' ITRs, subject to the circumstances. Where income cannot be proved, the applicable State-notified minimum wage for the relevant time for unskilled, semi-skilled or skilled category is used. The LRs, including married and earning sons and daughters, are entitled to claim compensation, regardless of financial dependency on the deceased, as settled by the Supreme Court in *Jitender Kumar* (2025).

The second stage is to translate these three facts into the four heads under which compensation in a death case is computed: (A) loss of income/dependency, (B) loss of estate, (C) funeral expenses, and (D) loss of consortium. The major component is "loss of income", which represents the financial loss suffered by the dependants on account of the victim's death. For the first head, the calculation begins with the deceased's "annual income" to which the prescribed percentage towards "future prospects", having regard to the deceased's age and nature of employment, is added. From the resulting figure, the prescribed "deduction" towards the deceased's personal expenses is made, and the balance is multiplied by the appropriate "multiplier" to arrive at the "loss of income". The aforesaid three components perform different functions: "future prospects" account for the career growth the deceased would reasonably have received had they survived. As delineated in para 61 of *Pranay Sethi* (2017), for a person in a permanent government or salaried job with assured career progression, 50% is added where the deceased was below 40 years, 30% where aged 40-50 years, and 15% where aged 50-60 years; no addition is made above 60 years. For a self-employed person or one on a fixed salary, the corresponding additions are 40%, 25% and 10% for these three age groups, respectively, with no addition above 60 years.

Further, the "deduction" recognises that a portion of the deceased's earnings would have been spent on their own personal living expenses. As per *Sarla Verma* (2009), for a married deceased with two to three dependent family members, the standard deduction is one-third (33%); where there are four to six, it is one-fourth (25%); and where there are seven or more, it is one-fifth (20%). In the case of a bachelor or unmarried deceased, the usual deduction is one-half (50%) where the parents or other dependants are the claimants, although courts may reduce the deduction where the number of dependants is particularly large. Lastly, the "multiplier" represents the deceased's remaining active working life and is determined solely with reference to age. According to *Sarla Verma*, the multiplier is 18 for ages 15-20 and 21-25; 17 for 26-30; 16 for 31-35; 15 for 36-40; 14 for 41-45; 13 for 46-50; 11 for 51-55; 9 for 56-60; 7 for 61-65; and 5 for 66-70 years.

The remaining three are conventional heads and, unlike "loss of income", do not depend on the deceased's profession or actual earnings. Under *Pranay Sethi* (2017), (i) "loss of estate" was fixed at ₹15,000, representing the loss of savings, investments and accumulated assets that the deceased could reasonably have built up and left for the heirs; (ii) "funeral expenses" at ₹15,000; and (iii) "loss of consortium" at ₹40,000 for each eligible family member, recognising the emotional trauma and loss of companionship, love, care and guidance. Consortium includes spousal consortium for the surviving spouse, parental consortium for surviving children, and filial consortium for parents who lose a child. Each eligible family member is independently entitled to the standard base amount, and therefore the applicable consortium amount is multiplied by the number of eligible dependants.

These three conventional amounts are to be enhanced by 10% every three years, as directed by the Supreme Court in *Pranay Sethi* (para 61).

The third stage is simply to aggregate the four heads to arrive at the compensation payable. Additionally, the court may also grant interest under Section 171, typically ranging between 6% and 9%, depending on the facts of the case.

In a significant judgment recently, in *Shishu Pal* (2026), a case involving the accidental death of a homemaker, recognising that household work, including cooking, cleaning and caregiving, supports the paid workforce, the Supreme Court fixed a minimum notional income of ₹30,000 per month under a new head of "loss of domestic care", with a 10% cumulative enhancement every three years.

(Kartikey Singh and Barkha Dwivedi, lawyers based in New Delhi)

THE GIST

- The Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 provides the legal framework for motor accident claims, with MACTs determining compensation and liability, while insurers generally satisfy awards subject to statutory defences
- For fatal accidents, compensation is calculated using the deceased's age, income and number of dependants, with future prospects, personal-expense deductions and an age-based multiplier applied to determine loss of income
- Courts also award compensation under conventional heads such as loss of estate, funeral expenses and consortium, with interest where applicable; a recent ruling has also recognised loss of domestic care for homemakers

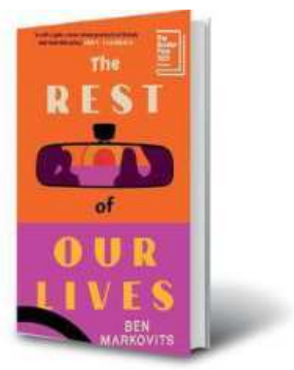
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GETTY IMAGES







When midlife feels like a crisis, it may actually be a chance to begin again

Margie Lachman's new book, alongside two novels, looks at midlife through questions of ageing, identity, relationships and fulfilment; they also point to midlife as a time of possibility, when familiar roles shift and there is room to begin again

Pragya Mittal

Generally, by the time people reach their 40s, they may feel like things are falling apart. They experience what is often termed a 'midlife crisis'. It is not always easy to say what really is falling apart, and there may be no single reason. This period can be accompanied by a strange sense of unhappiness: a feeling of missed opportunities, of a life unlived, and of an uncertain future.

Several things may be true at once. There may be ennui with a familiar role or relationship. Often, a career that felt promising may suddenly begin to feel like a dead-end. Responsibilities tend to add up, as both older and younger people increasingly depend on middle-aged people. Then, there is also the shock of staring into the mirror and seeing more grey hairs, a visible paunch, wrinkles on the face - all reminders of a youth gone by.

But what feels like one big crisis may actually be an accumulation of smaller doubts that have been building over the years and have simply not been acknowledged.

An opportunity

In her recent book, *Primetime: A New Vision for Midlife* (Simon and Schuster), however, lifespan developmental psychologist Margie Lachman tries to change the way we look at midlife. First, she refutes the stigma attached to age. She says there are many types of age - biological, social, and psychological. Biological age refers to our physical health and the ageing process of our bodies. Social age refers to the roles we take on, such as being a parent, caregiver, partner, or professional. Psychological age is arguably the most personal - it's about how old we perceive ourselves to be. As she writes, "Individual markers of midlife can fluctuate over time."



Second, far from a crisis, Lachman, who has said in interviews that she "loved midlife", believes that this time of life can in fact be a blessing in disguise. She writes that it is a period for us to learn from older people's mistakes and help the younger people avoid the same mistakes. She stresses the point that midlife is actually our "primetime" and regards the concept of age as subjective.

Middle age in literature

The phenomenon of the midlife crisis is not just a modern shorthand for the stress of adulthood. Many works of fiction have captured the restlessness associated with this stage of life. Doris Lessing's *The Summer Before the Dark* (1973; Vintage) is one such book. A 40-year-old mother of four, Kate Brown finds herself strangely unmoored when her family goes away for the summer and the roles that had defined her begin to loosen. Her encounter with the much younger Maureen further places two stages of womanhood side by side. Kate's crisis, then, is not simply about how old she is, but about how old she feels and who she is when the familiar roles of wife, mother, and caregiver begin to shift. In many ways, Kate embodies what Lachman calls social and psychological age in *Primetime*: chronological age alone cannot explain the midlife experience. Perhaps midlife becomes a crisis not when life changes, but when the identities that once made sense of it no longer do.

The midlife crisis is often seen as a gendered idea and is mostly associated with women. But men, too, find themselves caught in the same uncertainties: about ageing, relationships, work, identity, and the lives they have built. Benjamin Markovits's *The Rest of Our Lives* (2025; Faber and Faber), which was shortlisted for the Booker Prize in 2025, gives the male midlife crisis both a literal and metaphorical U-turn. At 55, Tom Layward experiences emotional turmoil: a strained marriage haunted by his wife's betrayal 12 years earlier, and a controversy over pronoun use at his university that unsettles his career. His health, too, poses concerns, with unexplained symptoms such as palpitations, fatigue, and facial swelling. For Tom, the crisis involves several problems unfolding at once. And what does he do to deal with all these problems? He takes to the road.

Room for experimentation

Each of the three titles has a common running theme: the lack of fulfilment, but also rays of hope.

The Summer Before the Dark uses summer as a motif for the period before the darkness sets in - it is a space of transition and possibility. The title of Markovits's book - *The Rest of Our Lives* - itself carries the feeling of possibility: there is still a 'rest' of our lives, and perhaps still time to decide what kind of life we want to live.

Primetime, of course, completes the circle. Lachman asks us to embrace midlife not as the beginning of a crisis, but as an opportunity to begin again. She emphasises that there are nonnormative influences - experiences that affect an individual but are not common to everyone - and contextual influences, such as one's environment and culture. Midlife, she says, can be a stage when we are relieved of certain responsibilities and find room for experimentation - in a relationship, a career, a new hobby, and new friendships. It could be the period when our lives take a turn for the better - and hence, midlife can simply be our primetime.

(Pragya Mittal is a Delhi-based editor and writer)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of "feel good factor"? (K. Jitendra, Ranchi)
This is an expression that has been around since the 1970s. At first it was generally used to refer to something that creates a sense of well-being in people – their emotional state, physical state, financial state, etc. Since the 1990s, however, the "feel good factor" has become somewhat restricted in its meaning; it's become an expression, which is mostly employed by economists and financial pundits.

These days it is extensively used to refer to a sense of financial and material well-being – not necessarily physical or emotional.

A well known economist believes that the feel good factor will not return to the country before the end of the decade.

No matter what changes the government makes, the feel good factor will be slow to return.

The opposite of "feel good factor" is "feel bad factor".

Do you congratulate someone "on" getting a job, or do you congratulate him "for" getting a job? (K. Balasubramanian, Chennai)
One usually congratulates someone "on" getting something, and not "for".

Neha and Raju congratulated Atul on his brilliant performance.

Vishnu congratulated Leya on winning the lottery.

What is the word for a child who is born after his father's death? (A. Vijayaraghavan, Bangalore)
I don't know of any specific word that would refer to such a child. Generally we talk about a child being born posthumously. The word "posthumous" means something that happens after an individual's death. The "o" in the first syllable is like the "o" in "pot", "hot", and "cot" and the "h" is like the "y" in "yes", "yet", and "yeast". The following "u" can be pronounced either like the "u" in "put", "pull", and "full", or like the "a" in "China". The final "ous" sounds like the "ous" in "famous", "dangerous", and "generous". The main stress is on the first syllable. This is just one of the ways of pronouncing the word. Here are a few examples of how to use the word.

The soldier was awarded the medal posthumously.

Nandita wanted her memoirs to be published posthumously.

What is the difference between "ornamental" and "ornate"? (M. Damodhar, Vellore)
When you say that something is "ornate," what you are implying is that the object has been decorated excessively or elaborately. There is too much decoration and as a result it is showy or gaudy; the word generally has a negative connotation. The main stress, by the way, is on the second syllable "nate", which rhymes with "eight", "bait", and "hate".

The word "ornamental" also means decorative, but unlike "ornate" it isn't associated with anything negative. When you say that something is "ornamental," what you are implying is that the object has been designed to be decorative without being too vulgar or ostentatious. The stress in this word is on the third syllable, "men".

Published in The Hindu on January 29, 2002

Word of the day

Churlish:
rude and boorish

Synonyms: clownish, classless, discourteous

Usage: *The shopkeeper became churlish when I asked for a refund.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/churlish

International Phonetic Alphabet: /tʃɜːlɪʃ/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Test your knowledge of historic Mars Orbiter Mission, which made India the first Asian nation to reach Mars orbit and the first nation globally to succeed on its maiden attempt

Prathmesh Kher

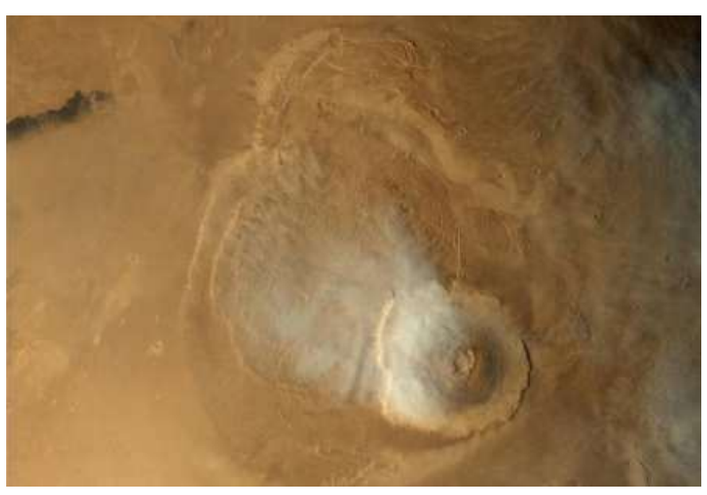
QUESTION 1
On what exact date did the Mars Orbiter Mission (Mangalyaan) successfully enter Mars orbit?

QUESTION 2
What was the name of the launch vehicle used to carry the spacecraft into Earth orbit?

QUESTION 3
Which instrument captured the iconic full-disk images of Mars and its moons, Phobos and Deimos?

QUESTION 4
Who served as the Project Director for the Mars Orbiter Mission?

QUESTION 5
India became the fourth space agency to reach Mars. Which three agencies had achieved this before ISRO?



Visual Question:
Identify this large shield volcano on Mars, as captured by the Mars Orbiter Mission. ISRO

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Which planet's irregular orbital motion led astronomers to hypothesise the existence of another, more distant planet? **Ans: Uranus**
2. On which dates in September 1846 was Neptune first successfully observed? **Ans: September 23-24, 1846**
3. Which astronomer had observed Neptune in 1612–13 without recognising it as a planet? **Ans: Galileo Galilei**
4. What was the name of the star chart that helped Johann Gottfried Galle and Heinrich d'Arrest identify Neptune? **Ans: Hora XXI**
5. Approximately how close was Neptune to Urbain Le Verrier's predicted position when Galle found it? **Ans: Less than one degree**
Visual: This image of Neptune was taken by which NASA space probe, and when? **Ans: NASA's Voyager 2 on August 25, 1989**
Early Birds: Samrat Halder | Gursharan Lal Vadhera | Sitaram Saharay | Sonali Das | Varghese Joseph

From Page One

Opposition seeks CEC's exit over 'illegal conduct'

Opposition parties asked the Supreme Court to take *suo motu* cognizance of the report and Congress leader K.C. Venugopal demanded a Supreme Court-monitored probe to "expose the rot that has destroyed the EC's credibility". The CEC has no right to remain in office after the expose, he said.

Former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee said the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance would meet soon to discuss the next course of action, including a *jono jagaran* (public awareness) campaign against "the BJP and its machinery". She also called for re-elections in West Bengal, Bihar, Haryana, and Madhya Pradesh, saying that the BJP had not won in these States, but rather the mandate had been "stolen".

The EC responded on Wednesday, saying that all its actions have been in accordance with the relevant laws. Highlighting specific internal notes spread over a 10-month period while overlooking the larger body of approvals, instructions, and initiatives gives only "one part of the picture", it said.

In August, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu had recorded that State-level election officials were reporting that they do not have "proper and complete access" to the ERONet portal, the digital system through which the electoral rolls are maintained. He further flagged that the Commission's director general of information technology Seema Khanna "does not have any legal authority to restrict proper and complete access and freedom to operate as given by law to the statutory authorities".

The *Express* report said that when a new officer was put in charge of the EC's administration division in Delhi and issued a work allocation order that threatened to further concentrate these powers, the two ECs separately wrote to the country's top bureaucrat, Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan.

Mr. Sandhu also asked who had authorised the Commission in West Bengal to file appeals against voters whom judicial tribunals had already included in the rolls, with 38 lakh appeals still pending.

'Minister on CEC panel sends wrong signal'

While Justice Datta did not find a reference to a Constitution Bench necessary, Justice Satish Chandra Sharma, the puisne judge on the Division Bench, held in favour of sending the case to a Constitution Bench, reasoning that several questions of substantial importance were at stake.

"There can be no gainsaying that free and fair elections, to a large extent, depend on a truly independent Election Commission of India (EC). It is not enough for the EC to be independent, it must also appear to be independent," Justice Datta observed. The top court judge stressed that it is already a well-settled law that independence in the appointment and functioning of the Election Commissioners was integral to free and fair elections and an essential part of the Basic Structure of the Constitution. The judge said it would be farfetched to expect a Minister to defy the wishes of the Prime Minister, leaving the role of the Leader of Opposition in the three-member selection panel merely "ornamental".

"It would not be a fallacious metaphor if it is said that since the umpire is picked by the captain of one side in a cricket match and his team wins, even if the decisions taken by such umpire are correct, it has the patina of suspicion, for, at the end of the day, the umpire has effectively been chosen by the winning captain," Justice Datta observed. After all, Justice Datta said, the Prime Minister and his Cabinet Minister shared a "collective responsibility" under Article 75(3) of the Constitution, and worked together in the government.

India, EU to sign trade deal on December 16

"The signing is scheduled for December 16, after which it will go to the European Parliament."

Negotiations on the India-EU FTA, dubbed the "mother of all deals" by leaders on both sides, restarted in June 2022 after a long hiatus and were concluded in January this year. The deal would see the EU dropping tariffs on 99.5% of items India exports to the region, with most tariffs going down to 0% immediately once the agreement comes into effect.

India, on the other hand, has given tariff concessions on 97.5% of the traded value between the two economies. A second source confirmed the date, adding that it would take place in Brussels in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

"The deal has majority support in Europe, and so it will not need to be individually ratified in each EU country," the first source added. A reason for this support is that the two sides agreed to leave out contentious issues from the deal and not make "the best the enemy of the good".

Mr. Modi is expected to travel to Canada first, probably around December 12, prior to the G-20 Summit in Miami. Confirming the visit, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney said trade negotiations had made "good progress". "Our commitment to each other, PM Modi and myself last year at the G20 (in Canada) was to look to conclude negotiations by G20 of this year (in the U.S.). That's the middle of December, 14-15 December," Mr. Carney said at a briefing in New York on Tuesday.

Differing views by members a part of decision-making: EC

The poll body was responding to a news report that the two Election Commissioners recorded objections at least 14 times over 10 months; all actions have been 'in accordance of laws', says EC

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

> The Commission operates as a multi-member constitutional body. Written notes and internal checks-and-balances are standard, ongoing practices designed to ensure legal compliance and operational rigour. All actions of EC have been in accordance of laws and instructions of the Commission
>
> **ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA**

Responding to reports of dissent within the Election Commission, the poll body on Wednesday said all its actions have been in accordance with the relevant laws and instructions. Highlighting "certain specific" internal notes or observations spread over a 10-month period while overlooking the much larger body of approvals, decisions, and initiatives give only "one part of the picture".

It was responding to an *Indian Express* report about dissent within the three-member Commission. The two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, said major decisions were being made without their knowledge in the name of the full Commission, which includes Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. The two ECs had recorded formal objections at least 14 times over the last 10 months, the report said.

The EC first issued a source-based clarification to the report. "All decisions of the Election Commission of India, including SIR [the ongoing special intensive revision of electoral rolls], have been unanimous and with the approval of both the Election Commissioners and the Chief Election Commissioner," the clarification said.

'Standard practice'

A formal, written statement followed. "The Commission operates as a multi-member constitutional body. Written notes, observations, technical suggestions and internal checks-and-balances are standard, ongoing practices designed to ensure complete transparency, legal compliance and operational rigour. All actions of ECI have been in accordance of laws and instructions of the Commission," it said.

The statement said that any operational queries or inputs raised by Commission members during draft stages are part of standard administrative practice, aimed at safeguarding voter rights. The suggestions given by the Commissioners were for further improving the electoral processes, it added.

The poll body said that differing views and observations are a normal part of deliberation in any institution and were part of the decision-making process before a final decision is taken. "Not only the three Commissioners, but every officer of the Commission is fully authorised to give his suggestions to the Commission for improving the electoral system," the statement said.

Highlighting certain specific internal notes or observations spread over the period of 10 months while overlooking the much larger body of approvals, decisions, instructions, and initiatives gives only one part of the picture, it argued. In recent months, the Commission has taken numerous decisions, issued instructions, introduced around 40 new initiatives, and undertaken many electoral reforms, including the conduct of electoral roll revisions across the country. All these decisions are an outcome of the unanimous decisions of the full Commission over the past year, it said.

"All official orders, decisions and administrative directions issued by the Commission carry full legal sanctions and follow established statutory procedures under The Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023," the statement said.

According to the *Indian Express* report, both the Election Commissioners had red-flagged several key issues, including the centralisation of the electoral roll database. They warned that "centralised software now overrides ground-level Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) decisions, blocking eligible voters," the report said.

In its response, the EC said that its digital platforms, such as ECINet, operate under strict data security protocols to prevent unauthorised tampering. IT security checks and audit controls are standard cybersecurity measures implemented across national databases.

Disclose details of decisions by EC, say former members

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



> If you feel that something wrong is taking place, you can immediately go public
>
> **O.P. RAWAT**
> Former CEC

Amid a controversy over an "exposé" claiming that decisions were taken without the concurrence of two Election Commissioners, former Election Commissioners have said that the poll body should immediately disclose details of decisions taken and whether they were unanimous or passed by a majority.

Under the law governing the Commission, its business is meant to be conducted unanimously wherever possible, and if the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and the other Commissioners disagree, the majority prevails. This raises the question whether a decision can be treated as valid if Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi together oppose it.

According to former Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) S.Y. Quraishi, all decisions are illegal if they are not unanimous or backed by the majority.

"Multi-member commissions should be unanimous and should have majority views. The list of all decisions should now be made public as to how many were unanimous and how many were by majority," he said.

Former Election Commissioner Ashok Lavasa, who resigned following differences within the Commission in 2020, said the EC should disclose all details, including the dates on which the notes or letters were given and what action was taken on them.

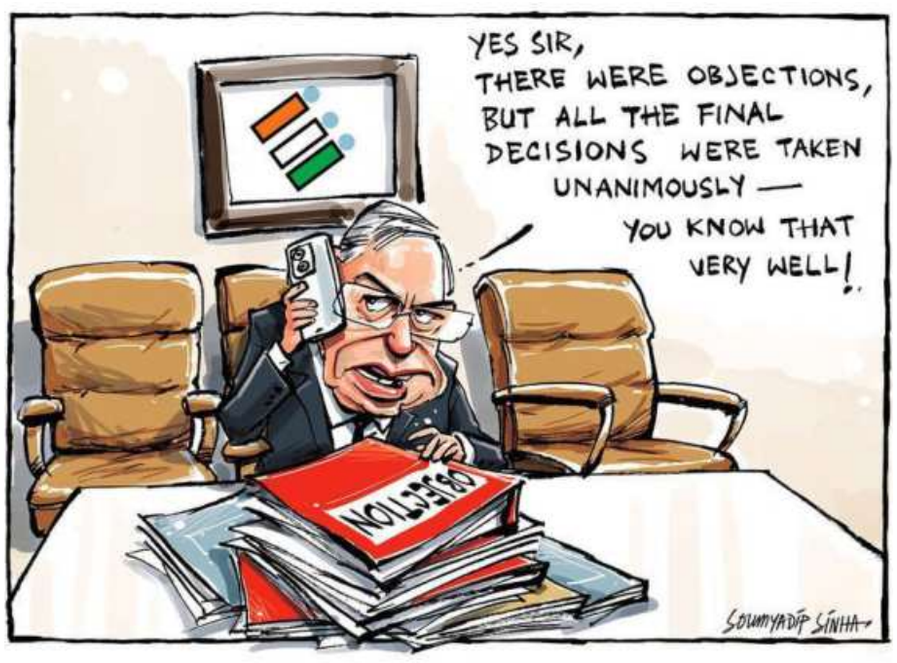
"If two commissioners are saying that they were not involved, then the only way to refute this is to show a record that they were present in the Commission meeting in which these decisions were taken," he said.

10-month delay flagged

Another former CEC, O.P. Rawat, said it would have been better had the two ECs not waited for 10 months.

"The Election Commission provides complete independence, and if you feel that something wrong is taking place, you can immediately go public," he said.

On the draw



Communications between CEC, ECs a sign of democracy: BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Wednesday said communications between the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and two Election Commissioners, which the Opposition parties cited as evidence of internal dissent in the institution, instead demonstrated its democratic functioning.

Accusing the Congress and other Opposition parties of continually attempting to create distrust in constitutional institutions among voters after being "repeatedly rejected by the people in the democratic sphere", BJP MP and spokesperson Sambit Patra alleged that their latest target was the Election Commission (EC) and the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) process.

He accused the Congress of being associated with multiple controversies concerning the independence of the EC during its rule in the past.

At a press conference on Wednesday, Mr. Patra said it showed that the constitutional body ultimately took unanimous decisions following a democratic process of deliberation.

"If the three Election Commissioners do not have communication among themselves, there is no kind of comment, no consultation, and all of them keep saying 'yes, yes', then the Opposition parties would allege 'dictatorship'...," said Mr. Patra. Regarding the Opposition's charge against the SIR process, he said the Supreme Court had upheld its legal validity multiple times.

Germany ready to sign submarine deal with India: envoy

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI


Jasper Wieck

Germany is ready to sign a "forward leaning" deal with India for six submarines worth $8 billion, said its new ambassador to India Jasper Wieck. Speaking to journalists on Wednesday, Mr. Wieck described Russia as the "aggressor" because of its actions in Ukraine amid the war and said that India can play a role in bringing the crisis to an end as New Delhi enjoys positive relations with both Kyiv and Moscow.

Mr. Wieck pointed out that both Germany and India have increased investments in their military capabilities because of the worldwide situation that he described as an "unfriendly geostrategic environment". Germany's Thyssenkrupp Marine Systems and India's Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders are in talks to build six submarines for India. The envoy said that Germany has eased barriers that had posed a challenge in defence cooperation with India.

"From the German side, we should sign tomorrow," said Mr. Wieck describing the deal as one in its final stages. "The government has agreed to all the documents that have been worked on, in particular, the G2G agreement, the inter-governmental agreement which is very ambitious and is very forward-leaning with regard to Indian requests," remarked Mr. Wieck.

The submarine deal will give a "big boost" to the existing India-Germany partnership, Mr. Wieck said.

SC refrains from asking for a timeline for proceedings against Trinamool rebel MPs

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



The Supreme Court on Wednesday stopped short of requiring Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla to give a specific timeline for completing the disqualification proceedings pending against 20 rebel Trinamool Congress party MPs who have aligned themselves with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI).

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant was hearing a plea filed by Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee contending that Mr. Birla was delaying disqualification proceedings under the anti-defection law.

Mr. Banerjee has sought a time-bound decision on the disqualification of the rebel MPs.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Speaker, urged the court to "not fix the Speaker's schedule". This was after Justice Joymalya Bagchi, who is part of the Bench, asked Mr. Mehta to submit a timeline on the disqualification proceedings.

"The Supreme Court monitoring is not necessary," Mr. Mehta stressed.

Senior advocates Neeraj Kishan Kaul and Maninder Singh, for the rebel MPs, said the Supreme Court monitoring and the three-month time limit highlighted in the *Keshab Meghachandra Singh versus Speaker, Manipur Legislative Assembly*, was only applicable in cases of "complete inaction" on the part of the Speaker concerned.

"How soon will you file your replies [to the notices issued in the disqualification petitions]?" the Bench asked.

Senior advocate Kalyan Banerjee, appearing for Mr. Banerjee, said the rebel MPs had already got six weeks, and have now sought four weeks more.

The court recorded in the order the MPs' intention to file their replies in four weeks. It posted the case after four weeks.

Justice Bagchi termed the role of a Speaker as "amphibious", whose responsibilities concern both the House and as a Tribunal under the Tenth Schedule (anti-defection law) of the Constitution.

The dispute within the party follows a rebellion within the Trinamool Congress parliamentary party. The rebel MPs had subsequently been treated as an NCPI group in Parliament.

Court grants default bail to six Ukrainian nationals

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

A special court in New Delhi on Wednesday granted default bail to six Ukrainian nationals arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in March in connection with an alleged cross-border conspiracy involving ethnic armed groups in Myanmar.

Special Judge Prashant Sharma of the Rouse Avenue court granted bail to Hurba Petro, Slyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskyi, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim, and Kaminskyi Viktor on personal cash bonds of ₹1 lakh each.

The court also discharged the accused under Sections 21 (penalty for unauthorised entry) and 23 (penalty for visa overstay and general contraventions) of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, noting the compounding of offences by the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO).



External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar with U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio in New York on Wednesday. @DRSJAISHANKAR/X

Jaishankar takes up U.S. sanctions law in meeting with Rubio

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

In their first meeting since the United States enacted the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act (SRIA), External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar raised concerns about the law with U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio in New York on Wednesday.

The law, which mandates U.S. President Donald Trump to penalise countries that buy Russian oil with up to 100% tariffs and extends sanctions on Iran trade, could affect India if implemented after the stipulated one-month period.

In a social media post, Mr. Jaishankar said he had "reiterated India's interests and concerns with regard to SRIA" and discussed the situations in Ukraine and Iran. In a strongly worded reaction to the U.S. Congress passing the Act last week, the Ministry of External Affairs had said it conveyed to various U.S. interlocutors in recent months that the move would have "implications" for both the India-U.S. bilateral relationship and the international energy market if India is pressured by the U.S. to drop its intake of Russian Ural, which currently makes up 51% of India's total crude imports.

After the meeting, Mr. Rubio sidestepped the issue. In a social media post about the meeting, he said, "Together, we are building on the U.S.-India strategic partnership and coordinating on key regional priorities and upcoming multilateral efforts."

Mr. Jaishankar and Mr. Rubio are also understood to be preparing for meetings between Mr. Trump and Prime Minister Narendra Modi later this year, with a possible meeting at the ASEAN Summit in November and then a bilateral expected in mid-December, when Mr. Trump hosts G20 Summit in Miami.

This is the third year in succession that India has failed to host the Quad Summit, and New Delhi has been keen to set a date later this year or early next year for Mr. Trump and leaders of Australia and Japan to travel to India.

SIR is illegal and needs to be reversed: former CEC Quraishi

Delimitation and SIR are intertwined and tailored to favour BJP, say Opposition leaders at *The Hindu* event; government has not yet prorogued the Monsoon Session of Parliament as it plans to bring the Bills around Oct. 11, says Jairam Ramesh

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



(From left) Sobhana Nair, Senior Deputy Editor, *The Hindu*; Nistula Hebbar, Political Editor, *The Hindu*; Javed Ali Khan, Rajya Sabha MP, SP; John Brittas, Rajya Sabha MP, CPI(M); Jairam Ramesh, Rajya Sabha MP, Congress; S.Y. Quraishi, former Chief Election Commissioner; Sanjeev Chopra, author and historian; Raja Sekhar Vundru, author; Varghese K. George, Resident Editor, *The Hindu*, Delhi; and Suresh Nambath, Editor, *The Hindu* at the launch of *The Delimitation Debate: The Union and its Units* in New Delhi on Wednesday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

The special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls is illegal and needs to be reversed, former Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) S.Y. Quraishi said on Wednesday.

Mr. Quraishi made these remarks at an event to launch the book *The Delimitation Debate: The Union and its Units*, published by The Hindu Group. The book contains essays that examine critical questions of representation, federalism and demographic change.

Speaking at the event, Communist Party of India (Marxist) MP John Brittas said the issues of SIR and delimitation are interlinked as the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) wants these tailored to make the party win.

Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh said the Narendra Modi government has not prorogued the Monsoon Session of Parliament even after 41 days of Parliament being adjourned *sine die*, as it is keen to bring the Delimitation Bill during Navratri.

'Dubious procedure'

Speaking at a panel discussion, moderated by *The Hindu*'s Political Editor Nistula Hebbar, Mr. Quraishi referred to the newsbreak by *The Indian Express* in which it was mentioned that there were major differences between Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the other two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi.

"I have been saying from the beginning, about a year and a half ago, that it is highly undesirable. And today it has come out that it was illegal," Mr. Quraishi said.

Questioning the procedure adopted for the ongoing SIR exercise, Mr. Quraishi described it as "dubious".

"I have been opposing it, and now today's revelations in *The Indian Express* have actually exposed the fact that the Election Commissioners themselves have been questioning the procedures being followed. In fact, it has raised a serious question of the legality of the decision. And all illegal decisions need to be reversed," he said.

His co-panelist Sanjeev Chopra, former director of the Lal Bahadur Shashtri Academy of Administration, argued for smaller States for a more representative democracy.

Raja Sekhar Vundru, former Additional Chief Secretary, Haryana government, argued for a system like France where there can be two rounds of voting so that the ultimate winner of an election should have at least 50% of the votes polled.

A separate panel discussion, moderated by Senior Deputy Editor Sobhana Nair, which included Mr. Ramesh, Mr. Brittas and Samajwadi Party MP Javed Khan, focussed on the political implications of the delimitation process.

"We have a lingering suspicion that the SIR and the delimitation are interlinked. Just as the SIR was the disenfranchisement of crores of people, they want to secure the delimitation in such a way that it favours the BJP," Mr. Brittas alleged.

'Broader implications'

Mr. Khan argued that the BJP was jolted by the 2024 Lok Sabha results in Uttar Pradesh, where his party, SP, won as many as 37 of the 80 Lok Sabha seats, and that prompted the BJP to push for delimitation.

Mr. Ramesh argued that even now the government does not have a two-thirds majority to push through the constitutional amendment that seeks to implement the 33% reservation for women after carrying out the delimitation exercise based on the last (2011) Census. But the government has not yet prorogued the Monsoon Session as it plans to bring the Bills around October 11, during the auspicious period of Navratri.

The Congress MP said the issue should not be framed merely as a North-South divide, as it has much broader implications.

Welcoming the distinguished panelists and guests to the event, Suresh Nambath, Editor of *The Hindu*, said the book does not frame the delimitation debate as a North-South conflict, but as an examination of democratic and federal principles.

"We are here to make sure that democracy and federalism are not seen as undermining each other, but reinforcing each other," Mr. Nambath said.

Varghese K. George, Resident Editor (Delhi) of *The Hindu*, made a brief visual presentation on the book, underlining the consequences of delimitation.

India rejects OIC Group's remarks on Kashmir

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

India on Wednesday categorically rejected the references to Kashmir in the Joint Communique of the Contact Group on Jammu and Kashmir of the Organisation for Islamic Cooperation (OIC).

"The OIC has no locus standi to pronounce on matters that are strictly internal to India. The entire Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh are integral and inalienable part of India, and no amount of repetition of politically motivated propaganda can change this reality. Repeated endorsement of such motivated narratives only raises serious questions on the credibility of OIC," the External Affairs Ministry said.

The Group, consisting of Azerbaijan, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and Turkiye, which met on Tuesday, expressed "deep concern" about the India-Pakistan conflict of May 2025, and termed India's strikes against terror targets inside Pakistan "unlawful".

The conflict had "once again shown that durable peace and stability in South Asia will remain contingent upon the final settlement of the Jammu and Kashmir dispute in accordance with the relevant UN Security Council resolutions and aspirations of the Kashmiri People", it said.

The MEA said the Group will be better advised to counsel Pakistan, which "supported and sponsored terrorism".

UCC is aimed at 'permanent polarisation', says Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Wednesday accused the Narendra Modi government of using the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) as a political instrument rather than a legal reform, alleging that the manner in which it was being pursued could keep society in a state of "permanent polarisation".

The charge came after former Bombay High Court judge Justice R.C. Chavan resigned from the Maharashtra government's seven-member UCC panel, citing differences over its functioning and the manner in which public feedback was being sought.

Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh, in a statement, said Justice Chavan's resignation raised wider questions about the pursuit of separate UCCs by States. He questioned if the Constituent Assembly envisaged every State framing its own version of UCC.

Mr. Ramesh also cited the 21st Law Commission's 2018 Consultation Paper on Reform of Family Law, which concluded that UCC was "neither necessary nor desirable at this stage" and advocated reform within existing family laws while preserving India's legal and cultural diversity.

Later, when asked about the statement, he said, "The UCC 'bulldozer' is to permanently polarise society." Justice Chavan, in his resignation letter, objected to reducing complex social questions to "yes or no" responses, saying he had understood that the exercise was intended to elicit public views and build consensus.

Police file chargesheet naming eight in Ram Temple donation case

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Police on Wednesday filed the chargesheet in the Ram Temple donation embezzlement case in Ayodhya before a local court. Eight accused have been named in the document which details the sequence of events and findings from an investigation into the theft of cash and donations, sources said.

"Today marks roughly 90 days in the temple embezzlement case. The chargesheet was presented before the court by the investigating officer. The chargesheet pertains to Sections 316(5), 372, 375, 162, 131A, 132 of the Prevention of Corruption Act," said Kul Shekhar Singh of the Legal Aid Defense Council, who represents the accused in the case.

The chargesheet, running into thousands of pages, delineates the management of funds collected at the Ram temple, their subsequent transfer to financial institutions, and the documentation and verification of significant charitable contributions.

The court will now examine the chargesheet and fix a date for hearing on its admissibility. Further legal action will be decided based on the facts revealed. The court records will clarify the roles of the individuals named in the report.

BJP rejigs national team, posts new in-charges for States

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) national president Nitin Nabin on Wednesday announced State in-charges and new assignments for his team of national office-bearers with vice-president Ram Madhav accorded the charge of poll-bound Uttarakhand and a promotion for Lok Sabha MP Anil Baluni as overall coordinator for communications, including social media, TV and print media.

BJP general secretaries Vinod Tawde and Satish Poonia had already been given charge of Uttar Pradesh and Punjab, respectively, which are also going to polls early next year. Mr. Baluni's elevation from convenor of media cell, now handed over to Ashish Usha Agrawal, to coordinator of all media is significant and could be a signal ahead of an anticipated Cabinet reshuffle.

National general secretary Smriti Irani has been given charge of Haryana and Chhattisgarh, while Mr. Madhav will additionally take care of Tamil Nadu.

Senior BJP leader Vinay Sahasrabuddhe will be in-charge for Delhi, while Jamyang Tsering Namgyal and Darshana Jardosh will be co-in-charges. Rajya Sabha MP Tarun Chugh retains responsibility for Gujarat, and Baijayant Jay Panda is in-charge of Maharashtra, backed by co-in-charges Amit Malviya, Sadanand Shet Tanawade, and Kamaljeet Sehrawat.

Harish Dwivedi is now in-charge of Bihar and Karnataka, Odisha has been assigned to D. Purandeswari, and Rajasthan to Sanjay Bhatia. Sunil Bansal, who already holds the charge of West Bengal, has additionally been made in-charge of Telangana.

Mangal Pandey has been made in-charge of Assam, while Kanad Purkayastha has taken over Meghalaya and Anil Antony has been given dual charge of Goa and Nagaland. Bhagwat Karad continues to oversee Mizoram. Raju Bista has been named in-charge of Sikkim, George Kurian for Lakshadweep, Rajkumar Bhatia for Ladakh, and K. Surendran for Puducherry.

Rajasthan State Road Development And Construction Corporation Ltd., JAIPUR
No. : NIT/2026-27/7288 - 96 Date : 22/09/2026
अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या 367/2026-27
निम्नलिखित परियोजनाओं पर पथकर वसूली हेतु ई-टेन्डरिंग प्रकिया से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है:-

कार्य का विवरण	कार्य की कुल अनुमानित लागत(रु.)
Selection of Bidder for Collection of User Fee on the basis of competitive bidding through e-procurement basis for the following:–	
On Sikar-Jhunjhunu-Luharu BOT Road SH–08" for a period of 01 Year. UBN: RRC2627SLOB00598	3864.66 Lakh

निविदा से सम्बन्धित प्रपत्र में निविदा शुल्क, धरोहर राशि, डाउनलोड करने व खोलने की तारीख सहित सम्पूर्ण विवरण एवं संशोधन वेबसाईट: http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.rajasthan.nic.in तथा http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in/rsrdc पर देखा जा सकता है। इच्छुक संवेदकों को अपने डिजिटल हस्ताक्षर के माध्यम से वेबसाईट http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in पर रजिस्टर्ड करवाना आवश्यक है।
महाप्रबंधक

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA – DEPARTMENT OF SPACE
CONSTRUCTION & MAINTENANCE GROUP, SDSC – SHAR
SRIHARIKOTA – 524124
Brief E-TENDER NOTICE
e-Tender Notice No.CMG/C/CON/268721 Date: 21/09/2026
On behalf of President of India, Item Rate tenders are invited through e-tendering for the following works:

Brief Name of work	Est. Value (Rs)
Miscellaneous balance works (Sewer pipeline, 2 Nos. of sewage collection wells) at Visitors Complex, SDSC SHAR.	44 Lakhs

Last date for sale (Tender documents can be downloaded) up to **30/09/2026**, **14:30 hrs**. For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi-English) Notice Inviting Tenders (NIT) on the website **https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html** and tender free view at **https://www.tenderwizard.com/isro**
Sd/- GROUP HEAD, CMG/ SDSC SHAR

JAIPUR CITY TRANSPORT SERVICES LIMITED
No. :- MD/JCTSL/2026-27/D - 1593 Date :- 22/09/2026
Corrigendum - 02
This is with reference to JCTSL Bid No. 02/2026-27 published on **http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in JCT2627SLOB00002** and **http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in** Tender ID 2026_JCTS_589839_1, some amendments are made. Detail of amendments can be seen and may be downloaded from above mentioned websites and JCTSL Website **(http://transport.rajasthan.gov.in/jctsl).**
Raj.Samwad/C/26/10650 Officer on Special Duty

अखिल भारतीय आयुर्विज्ञान संस्थान, देवघर
ALL INDIA INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES DEOGHAR
(स्वास्थ्य एवं परिवार कल्याण मंत्रालय, भारत सरकार के अधीन राष्ट्रीय महत्व का संस्थान)
(An Institution of National Importance under Ministry of Health & Family Welfare)
भारत सरकार/Government of India
Website-www.aiimsdeoghar.edu.in
No.-AIIMS/DEO/RECT.CELL/2026-27/384 Date- 14.09.2026
9th Rolling Phase 2 Medical & Nursing Faculty Recruitment Advertisement
Advt. No.:- AIIMS/DEO/RECT.CELL/2026-27/377/Phase 2, Dated: 14.09.2026
Online applications are invited for the medical & Nursing faculty posts on **direct recruitment/deputation** basis in various departments at All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Deoghar, Jharkhand.
Cut-off date for receiving soft copy of application is **15.10.2026**.
For further information candidates are requested to visit the website of institute- **www.aiimsdeoghar.edu.in** on regular basis.
Recruitment Cell
AIIMS Deoghar

BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED
Office of the Deputy General Manager-1,BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru – 560 052
No: DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/23/2026-27 Date: 23.09.2026
INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER
(Only through GOK KPP Portal Only) Call-04
The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Amount Put to Tender per annum (Rs. in Lakhs)	EMD (in Rs.)	Contract period
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Mahadevapura-2 division (Package-25) Call-04	1,865.37	Rs.1,00,000/- through e payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/ NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.17,65,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized /scheduled Bank	84 Months

1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal: **23.09.2026.** 2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: **27.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** 3) Tender Pre Bid meeting : **28.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs.** at above mentioned office. 4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender: **05.10.2026 before 17.00 hrs.** 5) Opening of Technical Bid: **06.10.2026 after 17.30 hrs.**
More details can be downloaded from website - https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in
Sd/-
DIPR/CP/2911/AKAR/2026-27 Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML

Soban Singh Jeena Government Institute of Medical Science & Research Almora
Near Vikas Bhawan, Pandeykhola, Almora, Distt-Almora-263601 (Uttarakhand)
E-mail- principal.gmcalmora@gmail.com http://www.ssjgimsralmora.org
मोबाइल सं. :- 9412410759 फ़ोन नम्बर -05962-230557
Letter No. :4128/GMCA/G-1/Advertisement/2025-26 Date:- 23rd September, 2026
Walk-In-Interview
A Walk In interview for various post of **"Professor, Associate Professor, Assistant Professor, Casualty Medical Officer, Lady Medical Officer & Medical Officer"** at **Soban Singh Jeena Government Institute of Medical Science & Research Almora** will be held on **07th October, 2026 at 10:00am** on wards in **"Office of the Principal, Soban Singh Jeena Government Institute of Medical Science & Research Almora"**. Registration will be done on the day of interview till 1:00 PM only. The post will be filled on yearly renewal contract basis for a maximum period of **03 (three) years** or till regular appointment are made. For further details please visit our **website**:- **http://www.ssjgimsralmora.org, www.medicaleducation.uk.gov.in & www.hnbumu.ac.in**
Principal
SSJ Govt. IMSR Almora
Almora.

MAHATRANSCO Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.
INVITATION FOR BID (IFB) (LOCAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING)
SRM e-Tender No. T-2687/MSETCL/CO/Projects/Pre-Tender (RFx No. 6000001600) (1st Call)
MSETCL invites offers by SRM e-tendering in TWO bid system (Techno-Commercial Bid and Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for the following work as detailed below.
"Establishment of 2X315 MVA 400/220 kV ICTs with GIS HV bays & AIS LV bays at 400/220 kV STPL Sinnar (MSPGCL) S/S alongwith construction of 220 kV DC line from 400/220 kV STPL Sinnar (MSPGCL) S/S to 220 kV Nashik Eklahare (OCR & GCR) S/S using HPC and reorientation of lines at 220 kV Nashik Eklahare (OCR & GCR) S/S under Nashik zone, MSETCL, Maharashtra."
Interested bidders may obtain further information available on the website **https://srmetender.mahatransco.in**
The date of downloading of Bid documents available on the website is from **22.09.2026**.
Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Projects), MSETCL

INBRIEF



FSSAI proposes front-of-pack labelling rollout in single step

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) , the country's food regulator, on Wednesday conveyed to the Supreme Court its proposal to adopt a single-phase approach for the implementation of front-of-pack nutrition labelling (FoPL) on packaged food products indicating sugar, salt and saturated fat levels. The regulator sought a four-month period for issuing and finalising the draft regulations under the Food Safety and Standards Act (FSS Act), 2006. The affidavit said that there would be a voluntary implementation period of 365 days by food business operators (FBOs).

ED says former Chhattisgarh PSC chief took ₹45 lakh bribe

The ED has claimed that arrested former Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission (CGPSC) chairperson Taman Singh Sonwani received ₹45 lakh through an institution controlled by him in return for favouring a businessman's son and daughter-in-law in the 2021 State service examination. The money he received was shown as corporate social responsibility (CSR) funding, it said, adding that the total proceeds of crime in this case is quantified so far to the tune of ₹3.28 crore. The probe agency on Tuesday filed its first prosecution complaint before a special court in Raipur in connection with the alleged irregularities in the CGPSC examination scam during the previous Congress government. PTI

Super El Niño to add 15,800 heat deaths in India: report

Climate Impact Lab says this year's El Niño is a 'postcard from our future', bringing temperatures climate change is projected to deliver 20 years later; national rainfall deficit is at 15% below normal

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

India could see an estimated 15,800 additional heat-related deaths, give or take 1,600, between September 2026 and February 2027, as the current Super El Niño drives unusually high temperatures, according to a report made public on Wednesday by the Climate Impact Lab. The estimate is relative to average conditions during the corresponding months from 1996-2025.

Globally, the report projects 451,000 additional heat-related deaths during the first six months of the El Niño event, including 239,000 during the September 2026-February 2027 period. It projects 19,300 deaths in Indonesia; 19,400 across the Philippines, Vietnam, Thailand, and Cambodia; 13,300 in Brazil; and 66,800 across the Sahel, a 5,000-kilometre swathe of about 10 countries across Africa, including Senegal, the Gambia, and northern Nigeria.

"This report allows decision-makers to see exactly where emergency actions can be taken now to save tens of thousands of lives in the coming months," Michael Greenstone, co-founder, Climate Impact Lab, University of Chicago, said.



Dry spell: Heat is increasing electricity demand with nearly 40% of coal-fired power plants clocking critically low fuel stocks. FILE PHOTO

The report describes the current event as a Super El Niño, an informal term generally used for exceptionally strong El Niño conditions. El Niño occurs when waters in the central and eastern tropical Pacific become unusually warm, altering atmospheric circulation and shifting rainfall and temperature patterns worldwide. Forecasts earlier this month projected a greater than 90% chance of a very strong El Niño during the northern hemisphere autumn and winter, with eastern equatorial Pacific sea surface temperatures already more than 3°C above normal.

Its effects are already being observed in different regions. Indonesia has experienced conditions conducive to wildfires, while parts of Central America have faced drought-related agricultural impacts. "This year's El Niño is also a 'postcard from our future', bringing temperatures climate change is projected to deliver 20 years in the future. In this way, it offers a glimpse at what lies ahead without new investments in adaptation," an accompanying press statement noted.

Rainfall deficit

In India, the southwest monsoon is entering its withdrawal phase after a season marked by deficient rainfall. The national rainfall deficit stood at about 15% below normal up to September 22, 2026 with larger shortfalls in southern and eastern parts of the country.

The heat is also increasing the demand for electricity, with nearly 40% of India's coal-fired power plants reporting critically low fuel stocks amid increased power demand associated with hotter than usual weather linked to the El Niño.

The Climate Impact Lab says it applies previously estimated temperature-mortality relationships across 24,378 regions to seasonal temperature forecasts, accounting for local climate, vulnerability, and adaptive capacity. The report does not spell out the underlying numerical relationship or coefficients connecting a particular temperature increase to a number of deaths.

SC judge defends Collegium system, hits back at Centre

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court Justice Dipankar Datta on Wednesday lashed out at critics in the Union government who claim that the Collegium system of judicial appointment is an insular mechanism of "judges appointing judges", saying the judiciary cannot always be at the receiving end of the Executive.

"The oft-repeated phrase that 'Judges appoint Judges' is a myth which people have been fed by vested interests through motivated narratives, often drawing sustenance from certain controversial decisions taken in this century in relation to appointment of judges," Justice Datta observed.

The observations were part of his separate opinion in a split verdict on the legality of a 2023 law on appointments of the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners.

Justice Datta said sweeping generalisations that the Collegium acted as a law unto itself overlooked the detailed consultative process and the intrinsic role of the Executive, both at the Central and State levels, as well as intelligence and other agencies in the judicial appointment process. The judge said every judicial appointment bore the imprimatur of the President.

'Piecemeal approvals'

Justice Datta turned the spotlight on the Union government's "piecemeal approvals" of recommendations made by the Supreme Court Collegium for judicial appointments.

The judge said the government has calibrated the judicial appointment system to override recommendations of the Supreme Court Collegium. Names proposed by the Collegium gather dust for years. Even recommendations for transfer of judges are not acted upon by the government in many cases.

"This court is left to wonder why, even after the judiciary has been relegated to playing second fiddle to the Executive in the matter of appointment of Judges, is there still a clamour to induct an outsider at the stage of selection? Coming as it does from the side of the Executive, the argument ill-behoves its stature and is a feeble attempt to deflect attention from its own dereliction and failure," Justice Datta said.

SC grants time to Centre over third language for Class 6

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta on Wednesday sought more time from the Supreme Court for the Union government to reach a decision on a suggestion to spare the current batch of Class 6 students from the three-language policy.

"Take your time, but see that the Class 6 students get some relief. We did not make this suggestion on a point of legality, but after considering the comfort and convenience of Class 6 students," said Justice Joymalya Bagchi, part of a three-Judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India, addressing the law officer.

In the previous hearing, the SC had proposed the scheme should be mandatory for Class 6 only from January 1, 2027.

SC to examine BCI's power to regulate legal education

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday decided to examine the authority of the Bar Council of India (BCI) to control and regulate legal education imparted in law colleges and national universities.

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, heading a three-judge Bench, questioned how the BCI, a regulator of the legal profession, could be considered an expert on legal education when there were domain experts and legal academicians.

The Bench said the BCI could formulate general guidelines like the duration of a law course, but had no authority to dictate the nuances of legal education.

The oral observations came while issuing notice in a writ petition filed by



Girish Mittal, represented by advocates Prashant Bhushan, Cheryl D'Souza and Pranav Sachdeva, against the constitution of the Bar Council of India Trust for Promotion of Education (Legal & Professional) and Reforms in Law and For Improvement of Research and Social Training (PEARL FIRST) and the establishment of law institutions by the Trust.

Conflict of interest

Mr. Bhushan submitted the existence of a conflict of interest arising from the continuing institutional association of BCI and the State Bar Councils, with institutions operating in the field of legal education.

He questioned the BCI's simultaneous exercise of regulatory and inspecting functions along with the establishment of the India International University of Legal Education and Research, Goa (IIULER) through the BCI-PEARL Trust.

Mr. Bhushan said 77% of the General Council of the university, which is the supreme supervisory body, were members nominated by the BCI or the BCI-PEARL Trust.

Subsequent to setting up IIULER in Goa, the same model is proposed to be set up IIULER in Andhra Pradesh, Mr. Bhushan submitted.

MoD signs ₹811 cr. deal to buy 160 glide bombs for IAF

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of Defence (MoD) signed a ₹810.79-crore contract with Bharat Dynamics Limited (BDL) on Wednesday to procure 160 Satellite Smart Anti-Airfield Weapons (SAT-SAAW) and associated equipment for the IAF. The weapon is expected to enhance stand-off precision strike capability.

According to the Ministry of Defence, Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh was present when the contract was signed in New Delhi under the Buy (Indian-Indigenously Designed, Developed and Manufactured) category.

The SAT-SAAW is an air-to-ground precision-guided glide bomb designed to neutralise enemy airfields from stand-off range.

IIT Bombay forms panel to investigate student's death

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

IIT Bombay on Wednesday set up a committee with 10 members to probe the circumstances around the death by suicide of Sahil Ravindra Wakode, age 20, a student at the institute, on September 18, 2026. The institute's Board constituted the panel.

The panel may question Professor Suryanarayana Doolla, who has been named in the case, an official said.

Prof. Doolla has been sent on leave. This was to facilitate a probe without bias, sources said.

The Mumbai Police have transferred the probe into Wakode's death to the Crime Branch. An officer of the rank of Assistant Commissioner of Police will lead the probe. Deputy Commissioner of Police (Detection-I) will supervise the investigation. The case has been registered at the Powai police station.



Public outcry: Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi activists stage a protest seeking a fair investigation into the death of Sahil Wakode. PTI

On Monday, Mr. Doolla was removed as Dean, Administrative Affairs, following protests over Wakode's death by suicide.

Wakode was a second year B.Tech. student in the Department of Energy Science and Engineering. The police found his body in his hostel room on the evening of September 18, 2026, hours after the institute's authorities caught him using a phone to access ChatGPT during a examination pertaining to the semester.

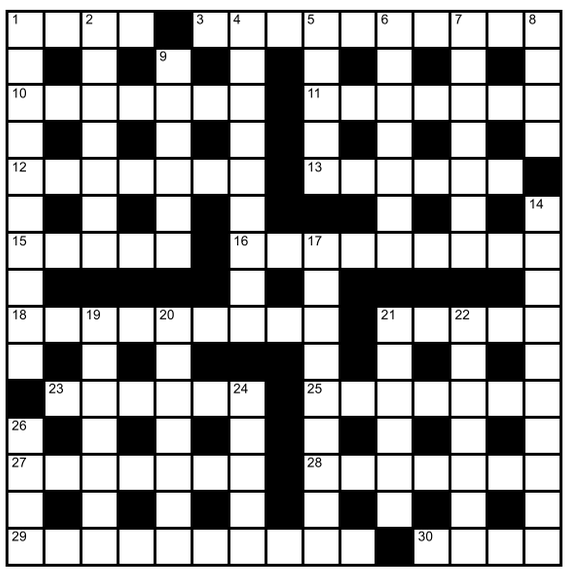
Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the Tele-MANAS 14416, and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050.

TH CROSSWORD + 14906

(set by Afterdark)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

1 Empty bay filled with electric vehicles by company (4)
3 Part of mouse (more than one) used by learner in black arts insanely (10)
10 Spending Euros, lavishly decorate in style (3,4)
11 Where US Congress meets is Washington D.C., say, is not advanced but ordinary (7)
12 Retain port (7)
13 Without resistance, say, sister could be excited (6)
15 Show opener in the second half is a landlord, maybe (5)
16 Agreement with criminal by faculties reportedly (9)
18 Extract sugar mass from seaweed (9)
21 Concluding words by messenger (5)
23 Clay and soil sent back to a town near Kolkata (6)
25 Infrared used in vessel, to regularly heat fish (7)
27 Opposed to Turkish general in emptying Siirt (7)
28 As deduced, gold ingot initially was spotted on April 1 (1,6)
29 Say, massager's at large, decapitated following rule by someone from Spurge family (6,4)
30 Avoid the quiet one (4)

Down

1 Say, holiday home is at Belgium, one in East Central near two hotels by a river (5,5)
2 Check electronically administered by one that is experienced (7)
4 Luggage holders for cars ok to fit (4,5)
5 In hurricane, it's not on to go round (5)
6 One having blood pressure on passage in transport (7)
7 Messages to check brief lacking finish (7)
8 Betrayed, hence boy is disheartened (4)
9 Departed, route jammed so a diversion (6)
14 Assessment at New York time by 1, Matthew is overwrought, negativing in the front (10)
17 Say, masthead is made of metal pane (9)
19 Right hand cut in the centre by thorn of a plant (7)
20 Way to cook? Criminal at hideout primarily tortures examiner (2,5)
21 Mistakes by precursor; in knots after losing CPU (6)
22 Painter of vehicle set out to get herbal primers (3,4)
24 McDermot eternalizing hidden composition (5)
26 Locks husband and innkeeper's relative at the gate (4)

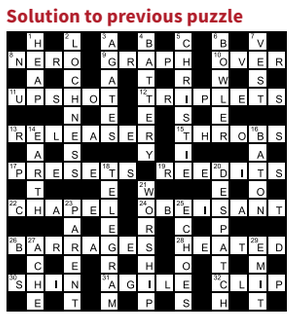
SUDOKU

		2	5				6	1
4				6			8	
	7	8						
5	4			7				
	2	3		4		5	9	
				5			7	6
						3	2	
	3			9				4
9	5				2	6		

No.SS7012 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

4	8	5	1	2	6	7	9	3
3	6	1	7	9	8	2	4	5
9	7	2	3	4	5	8	6	1
7	4	9	6	8	3	5	1	2
1	3	6	2	5	4	9	8	7
2	5	8	9	1	7	4	3	6
5	9	3	8	7	1	6	2	4
8	1	7	4	6	2	3	5	9
6	2	4	5	3	9	1	7	8

FAITH

Gem of a benefactor

None can predict when it will rain, except to be sure that it will happen to alleviate distress. Perumal is also like that, none can fix a date but He will appear at the right time and make a better person of even asuras. Like rain not discriminating against anyone, He too will grant moksha to the truly repentant, said Tirukkudanthai Dr. Venkatesh.

After asura Thanjagan received Perumal's infinite grace, his two brothers, Thandakan and Gajamugan, had escaped, hiding from Neelamega Perumal and His Chakra. However, as the three brothers had harassed a number of saints, there was apprehension about what havoc the two remaining brothers would wreak on all. Sage Markandeya prayed to Perumal seeking His intervention with regard to Thandakan. Ever ready to please His devotees, Perumal, aware that Thandakan had sought refuge in the bottoms of the earth, assumed the form of Varaha, a boar. He chased Thandakan, who ran about everywhere, but soon realised that he had nowhere to hide. He fell at the feet of Perumal, who pardoned Him and offered him mukti. He then emerged in full glory, appearing like a mountain of gems, accompanied by Bhu Devi who is also known as Ambujavalli. They are worshipped as Manikundra Perumal (*mani* in Tamil refers to gem) and Ambujavalli Thayar in Thanjavur. To purchase a rare gem, one has to find a knowledgeable middleman so that one can be sure of its purity. Similarly, one should go through an acharya to find Perumal. Once that is done, one can be sure that He will always be there for the devotee. Like how a gem obeys its owner, Manikundra Perumal also heeds His devotee's shout for help whenever needed, unfailingly.

INBRIEF



Banks to operate on Sunday ahead of proposed strike

In view of the proposed nationwide bank strike by the United Forum of Bank Unions (UFBU) from September 28 to 30, 2026, the government has announced that all public sector banks and regional rural banks will operate normally on Sunday. The UFBU, which claims to represent 90% of the banking workforce, is set to go on a three-day strike beginning September 28, primarily seeking a five-day banking week, among other demands.

India to study potential of new markets for tea exports

India is encouraging tea exports to explore new markets, as shipments to Iran are hit by the war. Amit Kumar, Joint Secretary, Union Ministry of Commerce and Industry, said on the sidelines of the UPASI annual conference in Coonoor that the Centre was focusing on markets such as Oman, which are increasing purchases of Indian tea. On increase in import of tea and concerns raised by planters, he said the focus is on increasing exports to diverse markets.

Samvriddhi can operate as online payment aggregator

Samvriddhi Inclusive Growth Network Pvt. Ltd. (SIGN), a Corporate Business Correspondent focused on last-mile financial inclusion, said that it had received in-principle authorisation from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to operate as an Online Payment Aggregator (PA-Online). Subject to final authorisation from the banking regulator, Samvriddhi Inclusive Growth Network will build and offer online payment aggregation services for merchants, it said.

Banks cautioned against 'aggressive lending' practices

Improving manufacturing performance and skilling the workforce would remain critical to sustaining economic growth, says Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, P.K. Mishra

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI



Poor credit assessment had forced the system to divert significant resources for cleaning up stressed assets, says Mishra. FILE PHOTO

Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister P.K. Mishra on Wednesday cautioned banks against reviving aggressive lending practices driven by short-term optimism, warning that poor credit assessment in the past had forced the banking system to divert significant resources towards cleaning up stressed assets.

"The clean-up of the banking system required considerable resources and time. Those resources could otherwise have supported productive investment. We should therefore preserve the institutional memory of that episode," Mr. Mishra said while addressing the SBI Banking and Economics Conclave in Mumbai.

"Credit must be appraised against the economics of the project rather than the enthusiasm of the moment. That is the surest protection against a repetition of the cycle of excessive lending, stressed assets and subsequent cleanup," he added.

The remarks come at a time when India's banking sector has emerged from one of its worst asset quality crises, with gross non-performing assets (GNPA) at a multi-decadal low. The GNPA ratio of the banking system fell below 1% in the first quarter of fiscal 2027, compared with nearly double-digit levels about a decade ago during the peak of the bad loan crisis.

The earlier deterioration in asset quality had contributed to the "twin balance sheet problem", where stressed corporate borrowers and weakened bank balance sheets constrained fresh investment. The government responded through bank recapitalisation, consolidation of weaker lenders and regulatory measures aimed at strengthening risk management practices.

Mr. Mishra's comments assume significance as banks are currently witnessing strong liquidity conditions and improved balance sheets, raising concerns that renewed credit growth could lead to excessive risk-taking if lending decisions are influenced by market optimism rather than fundamentals.

Highlighting the need to improve India's macroeconomic resilience, Mr. Mishra stressed the importance of reducing dependence on imports and strengthening domestic manufacturing capabilities.

"We have a significant merchandise trade deficit. We must make things at home and competitively," he said.

LG, Samsung face tariff evasion probe over OLED TV parts

Reuters
NEW DELHI



The DRI believes Samsung and LG should have paid a 15% duty for OLED parts.

India is investigating LG Electronics and Samsung for allegedly paying lower tariffs on imported display parts of high-end TVs, five sources told *Reuters,* putting under scrutiny the premium entertainment devices both South Korean giants have bet big on.

Lengthy import tariff and tax investigations have been a sore point for foreign investors in India and embroiled companies like Samsung and Volkswagen, though Indian officials say they are simply enforcing the law of the land.

The latest investigation concerns imports of display parts that go into making panels for OLEDs, or organic light emitting diode technology, which offer superior picture quality and are made by LG Electronics and Samsung in India, a key growth market for them.

The market for pricey OLEDs is still niche globally, however, with just 6.5 million units sold last year, research firm Omdia says. Counterpoint Research data shows India's TV market was worth $4.7 billion last year, with OLEDs having a near 4% share.

Indian officials have alleged the companies wrongly claimed a concessional 5% tariff on imported OLED glass screens called open cells, arguing the rate has for years been reserved for the older LCD and LEDs which dominate mass-market sales, said the sources, who declined to be identified as the matter is confidential.

For OLED parts, India's Directorate of Revenue Intelligence believes Samsung and LG should have paid a 15% duty, said two of the sources aware of the investigation.

The companies are privately opposing the position of Indian authorities as they believe OLED is nothing but an advanced form of LED technology and the same Indian tariffs should apply, the sources added.

The sources did not comment on the financial details of the amount of duty allegedly underpaid. Typically, following an investigation, authorities can issue tax demand notices and impose penalties of up to 100% of the duty evaded. Companies can legally challenge such demands in courts. Samsung said in a statement to Reuters that it is "reviewing the matter and cooperating fully with the relevant authorities, adding it is firmly committed to complying with all laws." LG and the revenue directorate did not respond to queries.

OECD forecasts India growth at 7.1% in '26-27

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) has become the latest global body to raise its growth forecast for India in the last week, predicting that India's economy will grow by 7.1% in 2026-27, up from 6.3% forecast in June.

This comes soon after the three most-recognised global ratings agencies – Moody's, S&P Global, and Fitch Ratings – raised their respective growth outlooks for India over the last week. The OECD, in its Economic Outlook Interim Report September 2026 released on Wednesday, said that several countries have been able to mitigate the damage from the West Asia crisis by rapid growth in artificial intelligence-related investment and production in many economies.

For India, however, it said domestic demand and government policy cushioned the impact.

"This was also the case in China, whilst growth in several other G20 emerging market economies, such as India, Indonesia and Brazil, was underpinned by resilient domestic demand and government policies that cushioned households and firms from the impact of higher energy prices," the report said.

'Indian OMCs incur ₹530-cr. daily losses'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Indian oil market companies (OMCs) are estimated to be incurring under-recoveries of ₹8 per litre on petrol, ₹9 per litre on diesel sales and almost ₹300 per domestic LPG (liquefied petroleum gas) cylinders, according to credit rating agency ICRA.

The combined impact translates into an estimated daily loss of about ₹530 crore from the sale of petrol, diesel and cooking gas for the OMCs, ICRA analysts said.

"The escalation of the conflict in West Asia and the [resulting] disruption to key oil supply routes has led to a sharp increase in crude oil prices, which has also resulted in sizeable marketing and LPG under-recoveries for oil marketing companies," said Prashant Vashisht, senior vice-president and co-group head of corporate sector ratings at ICRA.

BRICS must work in sync on transfer-pricing disputes: FM

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman urged BRICS nations to share experiences on treaty interpretation and multilateral negotiations in international taxation, saying global transfer pricing disputes "disproportionately" burden developing countries.

India proposed to set up two new working groups, International Taxation and Transfer Pricing and Revenue Statistics at a time when global tax rules are being renegotiated, she said at BRICS heads of tax authorities meeting here.

Multilateral tax issues

"There are several multilateral tax issues, including the UN Framework Convention on International Tax Cooperation, under active talks.The decisions made at these processes over the next few years will shape cross-border taxation for a generation.

Transfer pricing refers to pricing of goods and services exchanged between related firms. International transfer pricing disputes arise mainly as countries seek to ensure MNCs are subject to tax on profits attributable to their respective jurisdictions. Accordingly, differences in allocation of taxable income among countries can give rise to disputes among taxpayers and tax authorities as well as those in different jurisdictions.

HC rejects CBI plea on ex-NSE chief bail

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday, dismissed the CBI's challenge to the bail granted to former NSE MD and CEO Chitra Ramkrishna in the NSE employees' illegal phone tapping case.

Justice Madhu Jain rejected the agency's plea against the trial court's December 22, 2022 order granting the bail.

The CBI, in its FIR, said senior NSE officials, including Ms. Ramkrishna, conspired with iSec Private Ltd. to cheat NSE and its employees.

The CBI claimed, as part of the conspiracy, iSec was engaged to illegally intercept the phone calls of NSE employees.

Ms. Ramkrishna joined the NSE as Joint MD in 2009 and held the post until March 31, 2013.

She was appointed MD and CEO on April 1, 2013, and continued in the position until December 2016.

'Vigil vital for tied markets'

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Capital flows are increasingly blurring the lines between financial markets, raising the risk of shocks spreading from one segment to another, thus calling for closer coordination among regulators, Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Chairperson Tuhin Kanta Pandey said.

He said traditional boundaries separating banks, capital markets, insurers etc. were turning less distinct.

NANAJI DESHMUKH VETERINARY SCIENCE UNIVERSITY JABALPUR (MADHYA PRADESH)

No. 3531/ /NDVSU/2026 Date: 22/09/2026

NOTICE FOR SPOT COUNSELING (OFFLINE) FOR ADMISSION IN B.V.Sc. & A.H. / B.F.Sc.: 2026-27

Spot Counseling (Offline) for admission in remaining vacant seats (free and payment) of B.V.Sc. & A.H. and B.F.Sc. degree programmes 2026-27 will be held as under:

Degree programme	Date	Qualifying examinations	Venue	Time
B.V.Sc. & A.H. (5.5 years)	30.09.2026	NEET (UG) 2026	Auditorium, Veterinary College, South Civil Lines, Jabalpur (M.P.)	09.30 a.m.
B.F.Sc. (4 years)	30.09.2026	NEET (UG) 2026/ CUET 2026		

For details, rules and vacant seats visit University website: **www.ndvsu.org / https://ndvsu.mponline.gov.in**

Registrar

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES
OFFICE OF THE ADDITIONAL CHIEF ENGINEER, EASTERN CIRCLE-I, CANTONMENT ROAD, KATAKA.
Email id :- seeccuttack@gmail.com

"e" Procurement Notice No.ACE, EC-I/09 of 2026-27

1.	Nature of work	: Stone work, Road work & Canal Lining Work
2.	Total no. of works	: 3 Nos.
3.	Tender Amount	: Varies from Rs.335.62 Lakh to Rs.590.90 lakh (Approx.)
4.	Tender paper cost	: Rs.10,000/- per each tender (Non refundable)
5.	EMD required	: As mentioned in Section No.1 of DTCN (Clause No.6)
6.	Class of contractor	: As mentioned in Section No.1 of DTCN (Clause No.1)
7.	Period of completion	: As mentioned in Section No.1 of DTCN (Clause No.8)
8.	Online for bidding	: 30.09.2026 at 10.00 hrs. to 14.10.2026 up to 17.30 hrs.
9.	Date & time of opening of Tender (Technical bid)	: 15.10.2026 at 11.30 hrs.

Other terms and conditions can be seen from the Govt. website "**www.tendersodisha.gov.in**".
All corrigendum / cancellation of tender if any, will only be uploaded in the above web site.

32001/915/2627 **Additional Chief Engineer, Eastern Circle-I, Kataka.**
OIPR-32001/32370/1/26-27/0008

NANAJI DESHMUKH VETERINARY SCIENCE UNIVERSITY, JABALPUR (M.P.)

2nd Counselling and Admission Notice for 2026-27

Applications are invited for admission in Bachelor of Veterinary Science & Animal Husbandry (B.V.Sc. & A.H.) and Bachelor of Fishery Science (B.F.Sc.) degree courses for the session 2026-27 under following quota seats:

1. **Non Resident Indian (NRI) seats**
2. **Foreign national category seats**
3. **For wards of Kashmiri Migrants and Kashmiri Pandits/Kashmiri Hindu Families (Non-migrants) living in Kashmir valley**
4. **For students from Union Territories of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh**

For details visit University website **www.ndvsu.org** The date for submission of application and physical presence is **29th September, 2026**

No. 3532/2026 Date: 22/09/2026 **Registrar**

KERALA MEDICAL SERVICES CORPORATION LTD
(DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH & FAMILY WELFARE, GOVT. OF KERALA)
Head Office : Thycaud, Thiruvananthapuram-14,
(Telephone No. 0471-2945600, 2945646)
E-mail : edrugs.kmscl@kerala.gov.in,
website : www.kmscl.kerala.gov.in, CIN No. U24233KL2007SGC021616

No.KMSCL/ED/25/2026 Date : 22.09.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Online bids are invited from manufacturers/loan licensees on behalf of Department of Health, Govt of Kerala for the Procurement of Risdiplam Oral Solution for the year 2026-27.

Sl. No.	Tender No. and Date	No. of Item
1.	KMSCL/ED/RISDIPLAM/RC/2026/023 dtd: 22.09.2026	1

Schedule of dates

Particulars	Date	Time
Last date of online uploading of tenders	29.09.2026	05.00 pm.
Date of technical bid opening	01.10.2026	11.00 am. onwards

Tenders shall be downloaded and submitted online through the e-tender portal **www.etenders.kerala.gov.in**.

(Sd/-) MANAGING DIRECTOR (Tender Inviting Authority)

OFFICE OF THE MUNICIPAL COUNCIL, BHADRAK
Tel.No. 06784-251519(O), Fax No. 06784-251221
Email:- bhadrakm.hud@od.gov.in & eobdkmunicipality@gmail.com

Letter No:- 5193 Date:- 21.09.2026

NOTICE INVITING REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)

On behalf of the Bhadrak Municipal Council, Executive Officer of Municipality invites Request for Proposal (RFP) from interested agencies who fulfil the eligibility criteria requirement set forth in the RFP document for ***"Establishment Request For Proposal (RFP) For Development Of 60 TPD Capacity Municipal Waste To Charcoal Plant With Operation & Maintenance For 25 Years (Extendable Up To 5 Years) On PPP Basis (DBFO) At- Bhadrak Municipality."*** The detail RFP document can be seen and downloaded from website **https://www.bhadrakmunicipality.nic.in** & **https://bhadrak.odisha.gov.in** from **25.09.2026 (11.00 AM)** onwards.

1. **Schedule of Events:**

Period of availability of Tender Document in website	From Dt.. 25/09/2026 to Dt.22/10/2026 (till 5:00 PM)
Pre-bid meeting (Physical)	On Dt. 06/10/2026 (Time 12.30 PM) (Office of Executive Officer, Bhadrak Municipality, Bhadrak
Last date and time of receiving queries to be sent to email id: eobdkmunicipality@gmail.com (Format as Per RFP)	Dt. 09/10/2026 (by 5:00 PM)
Last date and time for submission of bids	22/10/2026 (till 5:00 PM)
Date and time for technical bid opening	23/10/2026 (11:00 AM)
Financial bid Opening	Will be Communicated by Bhadrak Municipality
Address for submission of Bid	The Executive Officer, Bhadrak Municipality, Bhadrak - 756001. Email: eobdkmunicipality@gmail.com

2. All amendments, Clarifications, time extension etc. will be uploaded in the website only interested parties should regularly visit the above website to keep themselves updated.

13001/1931/2627 **Executive Officer, Bhadrak Municipality**
OIPR-13001/13152/1/26-27/0007

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA - e-Procurement Notice
OFFICE OF THE ADDITIONAL CHIEF ENGINEER, CENTRAL MINOR IRRIGATION CIRCLE, BHUBANESWAR
Phone-0674-2540559; Mail ID:cmic.bbsr@gmail.com; No.1714 /CMIC Date : 21.09.2026

The Additional Chief Engineer, Central Minor Irrigation Circle, Bhubaneswar on behalf of Governor of Odisha invites **percentage rate bids in Double cover only in ONLINE mode** for the works detailed in the table from **"B" & "A" class** Contractors registered with the State Government and contractors of equivalent Grade/ Class registered with Central Government/M.E.S./Railways for execution of civil works on production of definite proof from the appropriate authority. The bidders may submit bids for any or all of the works.

e-Procurement Notice-BID IDENTIFICATION NO- ACE - CMIC-2/2026-27

1	Name of the works	: "Improvement to Head Works of Gayapathara M.I.P (Res) in Bhapur Block of Nayagada District under DPIW scheme for the year 2026-27
2	Total No. of works	: 1 (One) no
3	Estimated Cost	: Rs 190.11 lakh Approximately (Detail list of work Annexed)
4	Class of Contractor	: Class "B" &"A"
5	Period of completion	: As Mentioned against Work.
6	Date & time of Availability of Bid Document in the portal for online bidding.	: 28.09.2026 at 10.00 AM to 13.10.2026 up to 5.30 P.M.
7	Last date/Time for receipt of Bid only in ONLINE	: 13.10.2026 up to 5.30 P.M.
8	Date/Time of Opening of Technical Bid.	: 14.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M. at Office of the Addl. C.E Central M.I Circle, Bhubaneswar through Web site
9	Date/Time of Opening of Financial Bid	: To be intimated online after offline evaluation of Technical Bids.
10	Date of Transparent Lottery (If cases arises)	: To be intimated through mail after offline evaluation of Financial Bids.
11	Name & Address of the Officer Inviting the Bid.	: Additional Chief Engineer, Central M.I. Circle, Bhubaneswar, Plot No- A-8/2, Po: Bhoinagar, Bhubaneswar PIN: 751022. Dist: Khurda. Ph:0674-2540559
12	Mode of Payment of Bid Cost	: Online

Further details can be seen from the "e"-procurement portal : https://tendersodisha.gov.in

32001/913/2627 **Additional Chief Engineer, Central M.I.Circle, Bhubaneswar.**
OIPR-32001/32047/1/26-27/0003

SUSTAINABILITY SUMMIT 2026



Memorable moment: H. Shankar, MD of CPCL, felicitating a school student at the summit on Wednesday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM



Immersive discussion: A member of the audience interacting with a panellist during a session on Wednesday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM



Special event: H. Shankar, MD of CPCL, handing over a certificate to a student on Wednesday.



Making a point: One of the participants speaking at the session on 'Refinery to Energy Hub'. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

CPCL looking to be a part of renewable energy growth journey: MD



Interesting insights: N. Ravikumar, Senior Deputy Editor, *The Hindu* in conversation with H. Shankar, MD, CPCL, during a session at the summit. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

H. Shankar, Managing Director, Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited (CPCL) on Wednesday said the company was looking at how it could be a part of the growth journey in renewable energy.

"CBG (compressed bio-gas) is fuel that can be a good form of energy we can invest in. With SAF (sustainable aviation fuel), we can be a part of sustainability in aviation fuel," Mr. Shankar said at a fireside chat during *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026 with N. Ravikumar, senior Deputy Editor, *The Hindu*.

This past August has been a very important milestone in the auto mobile sector, with more renewable, hybrid EV (electric vehicles) and CNG (compressed natural gas) vehicles registered than vehicles using hydrocarbon derivatives as fuel, Mr. Shankar said.

"We are watching the transition that is happening now. Although the impact is more on on two- and three-wheelers, it's only a matter of time before it (renewable energy) really changes the larger means of transportation also. Refineries will continue to thrive despite the shift in auto mobiles from fossil-based fuels to renewable energy. We will change our refining from a fuel-based one to a petrochemical-based one, according to the needs of our customers," Mr. Shankar said.

Speaking of CPCL's refinery at Manali, Mr. Shankar said the company was building its own infrastructure requirements for importing green power directly, and had started using green energy in its day-to-day operations. "So, this is how we are preparing ourselves also for the transition from fossil fuel to renewable energy as a means of energy supply for processing requirements," he said.

At Nagapattinam, where CPCL is in a joint venture with Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL) and had originally proposed a nine-million tonnes per annum refinery, and a small component of polypropylene with petrochemical feedstock, the company is taking an alternative route. "Looking at the the internal rate of return that is accruing from the project, we are looking at the opportunity to move into the petrochemical sector directly," Mr. Shankar said.

On the company being accorded '*Navratna*' status, Mr. Shankar said it was a recognition from the Government of India, which came with a lot of benefits, and also a lot of responsibility and accountability.

"Our board has now the authority to sanction the approval of projects without any limit on a standalone basis. We also have lot of flexibility with respect to the formation of joint ventures to move forward," he said.

Sponsors

- The summit is supported by Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited (CPCL) as the Presenting Partner, with NLC India Limited, Larsen & Toubro (L&T), Navin's, WABAG, Tamil Nadu Newsprint and Papers Limited, Indian Bank, Urbando and State Bank of India as Associate Partners
- The summit's sustainability-focused partnerships include Thermax as the Sustainable Cooling Partner, Treeni as the Sustainability Intelligence Partner, Chennai Port Authority as the Blue Economy Partner and Tamil Nadu Green Climate Company as the Climate Action Partner
- Mangaldeep is the Fragrance Partner, Puthiya Thalaimurai the TV Partner, The Federal the Digital TV Partner and Communitree the NGO Partner

Sustainability must be demonstrated through measurable outcomes: Minister

Speaking at the inauguration of the summit, V.K. Rajeev says T.N. will extend policy support to accelerate green transition; Kumar Jayant, Chairman and Managing Director, T.N. Newsprint and Papers Ltd and H. Shankar, Managing Director, Chennai Petroleum Corporation Ltd spoke at the event

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Sustainability must move beyond discussion and translate into practical action; the Tamil Nadu government's vision for green transition is to ensure that sustainability leads to tangible improvement in people's daily lives, V.K. Rajeev, Minister for Environment and Climate Change, said at the inauguration of *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026 in Chennai on Wednesday.



V.K. Rajeev, Tamil Nadu Minister for Environment and Climate Change at the inauguration of *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026, in Chennai on Wednesday. Kumar Jayant, Chairman and Managing Director, TNPL; H. Shankar, Managing Director, Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited; and S. Sundaresan, senior Vice President (Advertisement), *The Hindu* are also present. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Pointing out that such summits would serve as a platform to arrive at practical solutions, Mr. Rajeev underlined the Tamil Nadu government's vision for a sustainable environment. Sustainability cannot remain a subject of discussion among government departments or environmental organisations alone. It must become a larger part of the way we plan, invest, build and grow. For the Tamil Nadu government, climate change and environmental protection are not separate from development. Highlighting the State's vision, he said that given Tamil Nadu's long coastline, coastal resilience is a priority, not an afterthought.

Sustainability must be demonstrated through measurable outcomes, including ecosystem restoration. Industries must move towards commitments, be it through energy efficiency or decarbonisation, Mr. Rajeev added.

The State government would extend its policy support to accelerate green transition and would encourage young entrepreneurs to drive innovation and clean development, he said.

Highlighting the various sustainable solutions adopted, Kumar Jayant, Chairman and Managing Director, Tamil Nadu Newsprint and Papers Limited, said that the TNPL was a bagasse-based paper mill and aimed at minimising waste through innovative approaches. It would soon expand its renewable energy production.

Noting that paper recycling is not a structured setup as yet, he said source segregation must be made a public movement to ensure that waste does not go to the landfill. There has been a renewed focus on source segregation in cities like Chennai. It must be turned into a public project for better accountability, said Mr. Jayant.

Speakers also emphasised the need for collective responsibility to build a sustainable future for the next generation.

H. Shankar, Managing Director, Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited, elaborated on the CPCL's pioneering efforts that focuses on resource efficiency, cleaner energy, and reducing its environmental footprint. He highlighted various initiatives, including desalination and sewage reclamation systems and investments in renewable energy sources.

Sustainability continues to be major driver for the CPCL's growth. While ensuring that the CPCL is ahead of the curve in meeting the demand for fuel, environmental concerns are firmly in focus, said Mr. Shankar.

The CPCL is also working towards engaging people in sustainability initiatives, including through its urban forest trail project and creating awareness through art. These efforts would help move awareness towards action and impactful activity. S. Sundaresan, senior Vice President (Advertisement), *The Hindu*, also participated.



P. Kannan, Director (operations), CPCL; Mukesh Mohan, Executive Director, Indian Oil Corporation Limited; Rajiv Mittal, Chairman and Managing Director, VA Tech WABAG Limited; and Rajesh Nair, Professor, Department of Ocean Engineering, IIT Madras speaking to K. Lakshmi, Deputy Editor, *The Hindu* on Wednesday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Experts share insights on conserving, reusing water

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

It was Chennai's acute water shortage of 1980 that proved to be a turning point for Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited (CPCL)'s attitude towards used water, pivoting from dependence on Metro Water towards the principles of reduce, reuse and recycle, according to P. Kannan, Director (Operations), CPCL.

He was one of the senior corporates and experts pitching for wastewater to be treated as a valuable economic resources at *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026 on Wednesday. The discussion on 'Reimagining Water Management for a Circular Future' was moderated by K. Lakshmi, Deputy Editor, *The Hindu*.

"We have optimised our water requirements and taken several measures to reduce consumption. For reuse, the water is diverted to our processing units, and wherever possible, we have maximised our reuse capability. As part of our recycling efforts, we are also producing 480 tonnes of steam," Mr. Kannan said.

Change in operation

Indian Oil Corporation Limited is another oil major that is changing the way it operates. "We operate nine refineries. Geographically, there are certain things that you cannot avoid. Refineries that are located inland face challenges in reducing their water footprint. We have been recycling almost 90% to 91% of our wastewater, but we are not stopping there," said Mukesh Mohan, Executive Director, IOCL.

Rajiv Mittal, Chairman and Managing Director, VA TECH WABAG Limited, said that fresh water is not an answer to everything. "We have a huge coastline in Chennai. Why are we not using seawater? You don't want to drink recycled wastewater, but why not use seawater?" he asked. "There is a myth that desalinating seawater is expensive. I believe the management of water is more important. And we should have the responsibility to conserve water," he added.

Mr. Mittal said untreated water should not be allowed to flow out.

Rajesh Nair, Professor, Department of Ocean Engineering, Indian Institute of Technology, Madras, highlighted how they are deriving geothermal energy from the sub-surface of the earth. "We are into India's first project to derive geothermal energy from unused oil and gas wells... the ones that have been depleted," he said.

Mr. Nair added that groundwater quality needs to be assessed and different grades should be established. He stressed the need to monitor how groundwater conditions are changing over time, adding that greater attention needs to be given to conserving wetlands.

Shift in mindset needed for CSR to move beyond compliance, say speakers

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A change in mindset is needed for corporate social responsibility (CSR) to create a meaningful impact, rather than merely meet compliance requirements, speakers said at a session at *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026 here on Wednesday.



Rohit Kumar Agrawala, Director (Finance), CPCL; Geetha Ramamoorthi, founder and principal adviser, Herizon Advisory; and Akshay Kurian, head of consulting and supply chain sustainability at Treeni Sustainability Solutions in conversation with Geetha Srimathi, senior reporter, *The Hindu*. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Addressing the session, titled Responsibility to Impact: Driving sustainable CSR through ESG, Data and Digital Innovation, Rohit Kumar Agrawala, Director (Finance), CPCL, said the environmental, social and governance (ESG) framework has become integral to the ecosystem driving industrial growth and is no longer merely a compliance requirement.

Critical resources cannot be ignored in business management and decision-making, said Mr. Agrawala, who sought to highlight how refinery operations can no longer be viewed in isolation, as the cost of production, competitiveness and CSR are interconnected.

Pointing out that sustainability targets in CPCL are more focused on implementation than intent, he said peer collaboration is also important to scale sustainable solutions and create changes in society.

"We need to move beyond incremental changes and shift from linear to exponential growth in our sustainability efforts," Mr. Agrawala said and added CSR metrics should focus not on money spent but on measurable outcomes and impact.

Speakers observed that CSR has evolved from merely counting beneficiaries to understanding their needs and measuring the impact of interventions, driven in part by regulatory requirements.

'Significant share'

Geetha Ramamoorthi, founder and principal advisor, Herizon Advisory, said health and education account for a significant share of CSR interventions among the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

A green innovation fund should be created to help startups develop innovative solutions, while cross-skilling programmes can help MSMEs build the capabilities needed for the green transition, said Ms. Ramamoorthi.

She also called for greater awareness of sustainability among the future workforce through the introduction of project-based learning in educational institutions. Creating a wider impact in society requires a shift in mindset along with sustained commitment and collective action, she said.

Noting that ESG data largely remains in the reporting phase, Akshay Kurian, head of consulting and supply chain sustainability at Treeni Sustainability Solutions, said it plays an important role in setting a baseline and tracking progress.

With many companies focusing on renewable energy and reducing emissions, Mr. Kurian said ESG data plays a crucial role in decision-making by helping organisations assess progress made and identify areas for improvement. The session was moderated by Geetha Srimathi, senior reporter, *The Hindu*.

SUSTAINABILITY SUMMIT 2026

Refinery sector must balance energy security with net-zero push: experts

Panellists speak about renewable energy, geopolitical disruptions affecting crude supplies, and Carbon Credit Trading Scheme; fossil fuels are not going to go away, the experts say and add that the transition should be viewed as a shift from a high-carbon energy system to low-carbon one

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



S.G. Venkatesh, Director (Technical), CPCL; Nandakumar Velayudhan Pillai, Director (Refinery), Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Limited; Santosh K. Singh, Chief Sustainability Officer, L&T; and D. Senthi Kumar, MD, Tamil Nadu Petroproducts Limited at a session moderated by Srinivasan Ramani, Deputy National Editor, *The Hindu*, at the summit in Chennai on Wednesday. M. SRINATH

India's refining and energy sector will have to balance growing energy demand and energy security with the transition towards net-zero emissions, industry leaders said at a panel discussion at the *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026.

At a discussion on the topic of 'Fossils to Net Zero: Transforming India's Refinery and Energy Landscape', S.G. Venkatesh, Director (Technical), Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited (CPCL); Nandakumar Velayudhan Pillai, Director (Refinery), Mangalore Refinery & Petrochemicals Limited (MRPL); Santosh K. Singh, Chief Sustainability Officer, Larsen & Toubro; and D. Senthil Kumar, Managing Director, Tamil Nadu Petroproducts Limited, spoke about the challenges facing the sector.

The session was moderated by Srinivasan Ramani, Deputy National Editor, *The Hindu*.

Mr. Venkatesh said achieving net zero for a refinery involved reducing the energy required to produce the same quantity of finished products and progressively shifting to cleaner energy sources and technologies.

He said the CPCL had reduced its energy consumption even as it achieved its highest-ever crude throughput through energy conservation measures, use of cleaner fuels, operational optimisation, and digitalisation. The company had also improved its energy efficiency benchmark and was targeting net-zero Scope 1 and Scope 2 emissions by 2046.

Different Scopes

While Scope 1 covers direct emissions from refinery operations and Scope 2 covers emissions associated with purchased electricity, reducing Scope 3 emissions would depend on the wider transition in sectors that consume refinery products, particularly transport, he said.

"Fossil fuels are not going to go away, at least for the next two decades," Mr. Singh said, adding that the transition should be viewed as a shift from a high-carbon energy system to a low-carbon one rather than an immediate replacement of fossil fuels.

Mr. Singh said green hydrogen had already moved from the policy stage to implementation, but cost remained a major barrier. Scaling up electrolyser manufacturing, reducing renewable energy costs and creating demand would be crucial to making the fuel commercially viable.

The transition to a green hydrogen economy would also require an ecosystem covering renewable power generation, energy storage, electrolysers, hydrogen storage, transportation and end-use, he said.

Mr. Pillai said the intermittent nature of renewable energy posed a particular challenge for refineries, which require a continuous and stable energy supply. "The refinery process cannot have a variation in its feed flow," he said, pointing to the need for energy storage and technological improvements in electrolysers.

The panellists also discussed how geopolitical conflicts and disruptions to key shipping routes could affect crude supplies and refining operations, particularly for an import-dependent country such as India. They said such shocks underscored the need for refineries to diversify crude sources and strengthen supply resilience while ensuring uninterrupted energy availability.

On sustainable aviation fuel (SAF), Mr. Pillai said refineries had begun developing projects using used cooking oil as a feedstock. The major challenge was collecting adequate quantities of used cooking oil and meeting sustainability certification requirements. A SAF plant using indigenous technology was expected to be commissioned next year, he said.

Trading scheme

Mr. Kumar said the Carbon Credit Trading Scheme would shift energy efficiency from a largely voluntary exercise towards a compliance-driven mechanism for refineries and petrochemical industries. Under the scheme, industries would have prescribed emissions-intensity targets for a specified period, against a baseline determined using identified operating parameters. Companies that improve beyond their targets could trade the additional efficiency achieved through certificates, while those unable to meet their targets would have to procure certificates to bridge the shortfall.

He said similar mechanisms were already in place in other industries under the Bureau of Energy Efficiency, including through the Perform, Achieve and Trade scheme. However, the earlier mechanism had not gained sufficient traction. With the carbon market now being expanded to more industries, including refineries and petrochemicals, trading activity could increase significantly, he said. "The trading activities are expected to be very challenging in the future," he said, adding that the incentives available to industries that perform better than their targets could create greater scope for investment in energy efficiency.

The panellists stressed that energy efficiency should precede more expensive decarbonisation technologies. They highlighted the need for a gradual transition that safeguards energy security while accelerating investments in efficiency, renewable energy, green hydrogen and sustainable fuels.

'Meaningful partnerships bring tangible outcomes'


V. Sriram, Chief General Manager, HSE CPCL, speaking at *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026 in Chennai on Wednesday. M. SRINATH

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Sustainability must move from awareness to action, and from action to measurable impact. "Let us continue to work together, share knowledge, build meaningful partnerships, and translate our commitments into tangible environmental outcomes," V. Sriram, Chief General Manager, HSE, Chennai Petroleum Corporation Limited (CPCL) said while delivering the vote of thanks at *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026.

Mr. Sriram thanked all the panellists and government officials for their insights during the panel discussion and fireside chats. He thanked V. K. Rajeev, Minister for Environment and Climate Change, Government of Tamil Nadu for being a part of the summit.

He thanked Indian Oil Corporation Limited, BPCL, HPCL, MRPL, and other energy-sector organisations for being part of this summit. He thanked *The Hindu* for putting the event together.

"A special word of appreciation to CommuniTree - our NGO partner - and all the sustainability organisations and volunteers who supported the various initiatives such as the Urban Forest Trail, Art for Awareness, and the Installation Art Event at Mathur during the last 30 days," he said.

Green push



Objective approach: Harish Iyer, Global Sales Head, Cooling and Heating Solutions, Thermax Limited, speaking on 'engineering the future of sustainable cooling and process heating' at the *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026 in Chennai on Wednesday. M. SRINATH

Industry leaders urge Tamil Nadu govt. to incentivise green buildings

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI


Bharath Kumar Venkatesan, Managing Partner, Urbando; Faiza Solanki, Regional Technical and Business Development Specialist, IFC, World Bank Group Member; Navin Kumar, MD, Navin's along with N. Ravikumar, Senior Deputy Editor, *The Hindu*. M. SRINATH

Faiza Solanki, Regional Technical and Business Development Specialist, International Finance Corporation, World Bank Group Member on Wednesday said several banks offered rebate on interest rates for those building green homes. This applied for those constructing individual houses and building homes commercially.

She was speaking at a panel discussion moderated by N. Ravikumar of Senior Deputy Editor, *The Hindu* on 'Real Estate and Sustainability: Building growth without building environmental debt', at *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026.

Ms. Solanki said more and more commercial buildings and residential buildings were going in for green certification.

"From 2013, mainstream green certification has been growing. It is still growing. Even affordable buildings such as the Tamil Nadu government's Thozhi Hostels are green verified," she added. She said the major barrier in people going in for green certification was the lack of understanding about the benefits.

Navin Kumar, Managing Director, Navin's, said many commercial buildings were going net zero carbon and tenants too were willing to pay for the facilities created in terms of renewables. "Though it does not cost significantly more than a regular building, unlike commercial sector, residential buyers do not ask for it."

Bharath Kumar Venkatesan, Managing Partner, Urbando, said that from their perception, many customers view sustainable building as a tag of luxury. Customers look for comfort and convenience rather than go for aspects that could give a good life and increase their life span. People were spoilt they want to splurge.

The also panellists stressed the need for the State government to incentivise green buildings.

"An additional free FSI would be great. If such a programme is run for say a decade, it would easily become the standard," they added.

'Start-ups require support from ideation stage to drive energy transition'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Start-ups working on sustainability solutions need to be supported from the ideation stage to help innovative ideas translate into viable technologies, panellists said at *The Hindu* Sustainability Summit 2026 held in Chennai on Wednesday.

At a session on 'Ideas to Impact: Start-ups accelerating the energy transition', speakers spoke about the current status of start-ups, challenges they face and the support needed to scale their innovations.

Elaborating on the importance of incubation and entrepreneurial activities, Indumathi M. Nambi, Environment and Water Resources Division, Department of Civil Engineering, IIT Madras, said not many incubators supported students at ideation stage and many students too did not register with incubators. This indicated a gap in the existing incubation ecosystem. There was a need to create pre-incubators that could help students develop and test their ideas.

At IIT-Madras, gaps had been identified after the piloting stage and corporates and industries must step in to bridge them. Highlighting that funding was not an issue for deep tech start-ups, she said a major roadblock was the trust about new ideas.

Doctoral programme

She also suggested introducing a doctoral programme in entrepreneurship to help students demonstrate scaled-up products and receive mentorship support for commercialisation.

Speakers called for greater collaboration between industries, academic institutions and start-ups. They also stressed the need to introduce entrepreneurship as a subject at the school level to help students pursue careers aligning with their interests.


Pravin Dongre, Executive Director, Indian Oil Corporation; Prof. Indumathi M. Nambi, Environment and Water Resources Division, IIT-Madras; Karthika Gopi, founder and CEO Carbelim, along with Sangeetha Kandavel, Senior Assistant Editor, *The Hindu*. M. SRINATH

Pravin Dongre, Executive Director, Indian Oil Corporation Limited spoke about the IOCL's journey in encouraging the start-up ecosystem. Various start-ups across the value chain, including those working on clean and green energy and water, had received funding with support extended for 18 to 36 months. Some had reached proof of concept stage and some of them, including projects such as eco toilets and nano fillers for oil pipelines had been commercialised, Mr. Dongre said.

He stressed the need for start-ups to have clarity on long-term development. Incubation mechanisms could benefit both start-ups and industries. More support mechanisms were needed to take innovations from modular solutions to commercial scale, he said.

Speakers also emphasised on the need for collaborations to address critical environmental challenges such as air pollution and water issues.

Many challenges

Pointing out various challenges faced by start-ups, Karthika Gopi, Founder and Chief Executive Officer, Carbelim, said achieving net-zero goals did not have a one-stop solution but required an umbrella of solutions. Testing technologies in real world conditions was often challenging, while protecting intellectual property and achieving commercial scale-up were other hurdles.

Start-ups needed consortium-based support as investors had to be patient during gestation period. Start-ups must also explore international support and generate early evidence to validate their technologies, she said.

Such consortium-based support from industries and the government would pull out ideas from the lab and facilitate the emergence of new technologies, she added.

MUSCAT

Indian sailor killed in attack on vessel in Hormuz, say authorities



AP

An attack on a cargo ship in the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday killed an Indian sailor, Omani and Indian authorities said, with the latter condemning the ongoing attacks in the vital shipping lane. Suraj Yadav from Uttar Pradesh was killed when *MV Cape Dao* was attacked 2.5 nautical miles off coast of Oman. AFP

MOSCOW

Russia voices interest in 'limited ceasefire', says Rubio after talks



AP

Ukraine and Russia have both voiced an interest in a limited ceasefire involving energy-related targets, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Wednesday after meeting Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov in New York. However, Russia has given no public indication it is ready to agree to such arrangements. REUTERS

NEW YORK

Harvey Weinstein sentenced to 15 years for New York sexual assault



AP

A New York judge sentenced former Hollywood producer Harvey Weinstein to 15 years in prison on Wednesday for sexually assaulting a former production assistant in 2006. Weinstein, 74, was convicted in June 2025 of first-degree criminal sexual act for assaulting Miriam Haley at his Manhattan apartment. REUTERS

SANAA

Houthis to target U.S. interests if it supports Saudi-led strikes: adviser



AFP

Houthi military adviser Abed Mohammed al-Thawr said that the group would attack U.S. interests in the West Asia if Washington intervenes in Yemen's conflict in support of Saudi Arabia or tries to unblock the Bab el-Mandeb strait. Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman had requested help from U.S. President Trump. AFP

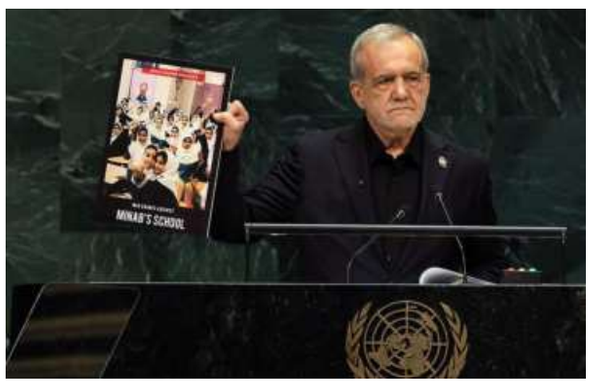
'We are not terrorists, but victims of terror': Iran's Pezeshkian at UN

'Our innocent people have been the targets of cowardly attacks and aggressions imposed upon our country; we defended ourselves with utmost strength; we're hit, but we did not bend the knee,' says the Iranian President at the General Assembly

Associated Press
UNITED NATIONS

Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Wednesday that his people have been "victims of terrorism" by the United States, delivering a rare wartime speech at UN General Assembly a day after President Donald Trump said he could "annihilate" the Islamic republic.

In a defiant speech, President Pezeshkian held up large photos of the late Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and the more than 150 Iranian school children killed by U.S. strikes on the first days of the war.



Masoud Pezeshkian holds up a picture of an Iranian school that was bombed, while speaking at the UN headquarters on Wednesday. AFP

"We have only defended ourselves. We are not terrorists," Pezeshkian said at the General Assembly. "Our innocent people have been the targets of cowardly attacks and aggressions imposed upon our country. And we defended ourselves with utmost strength. America and Israel attacked us."

He added of the United States: "Yes they did hit us, but we did not bend the knee." Toward the end of his speech, Mr. Pezeshkian called out Mr. Trump by name. "It must be understood by Mr. Trump and those who seek to bully us that we are ready for dialogue and diplomacy and negotiations without accepting the language of force."

He also said one thing that was measurably false: "We did not hit civilian populations."

Arriving in New York under heavy security and scrutiny, Mr. Pezeshkian – who, within Iran's political landscape, is considered a moderate politician – addressed world leaders a day after Mr. Trump used the same stage to suggest he may "annihilate" the Islamic Republic if a deal isn't reached soon to end the nearly seven-month war.

Mr. Pezeshkian's address elaborated on where Tehran stands as more than a year of start-stop negotiations between the two longtime adversaries have failed to produce a sustainable solution.

His address last year came months after the 12-day Israel-Iran war.

"Ladies and gentlemen, you all bore witness that this past June, my country was subjected to a savage aggression and flagrant contravention of the most elementary principles of international law," Mr. Pezeshkian said at the time.

With Trump-Xi truce, China looks to reshape Asian order

NEWS ANALYSIS

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING



Donald Trump speaks with Xi Jinping while leaving after a visit to the Zhongnanhai Garden in Beijing, China, in May. REUTERS

As U.S. President Donald Trump hosts Chinese President Xi Jinping at the White House on Thursday, the world's two biggest powers appear to be looking to extend their truce.

In May, when Mr. Trump visited Beijing, both sides declared their commitment to build a "constructive relationship of strategic stability", a Chinese coinage that the U.S. President, to the surprise of many observers, readily accepted.

This week, Mr. Trump is laying the red carpet for Mr. Xi, including by personally welcoming him at Joint Base Andrews, a courtesy he has not extended to any other leader.

Optics aside, the expectations for the visit are, however, largely modest on both sides, seen an effort to put a floor on a contentious relationship rather than a grand bargain. This is regardless of Mr. Trump's stated fondness for the idea of a "G2" which has concerned countries in the region, including India.

In the weeks after Mr. Trump's visit to Beijing, both sides have traded blows, including the listing of Chinese companies such as Alibaba and BYD by the Pentagon for "civil military fusion", and mutual accusations over how the other side is conducting the AI race. Other sticking points remain unresolved, such as tariffs, restrictions on semiconductors and Chinese export controls, especially on rare earths. China is also pressing the U.S. to stop arms sales to Taiwan.

If this has led some observers to suggest this truce is merely a tactical pause while each side works towards reducing their vulnerabilities and building leverage, others argue there are compelling reasons for both powers to pursue a future relationship of stability.

Writing in *Foreign Affairs* before the visit, Da Wei, a leading voice in Beijing on the China-U.S. relationship and Director of the Center for International Security and Strategy at Tsinghua University, made the case for why despite structural challenges, there were reasons for both to pursue a detente.

"The rapid development of technologies such as AI will make it particularly difficult for either the U.S. or China to eliminate the other's sources of leverage," he said. In the lead up to the visit, the two sides held talks in New York between Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng, including to set up a dialogue mechanism for AI cooperation.

The broader reason for a continued truce, in the view of Da Wei, was the narrowing power differential between the two countries. "China is looking at bilateral relations from a position of greater equality and with more confidence," he said. "It is less anxious that competition will undermine its national development prospects. Instead, Beijing believes that competition can be effectively managed without presenting an existential threat." For other Chinese strategists, the longer term goal is a grand bargain that will gradually see declining U.S. interest in Asia and a reshaped Asian security order. The view in Beijing is that Mr. Trump has already initiated that trend.

Li Kai, the Vice President of the influential China Institutes for Contemporary International Relations (CICIR) in Beijing, argued in the lead up to Mr. Xi's visit that "regional affairs should be led and managed by Asian countries themselves".

"This is consistent with the principle of 'Asian solutions to Asian problems'," he said. "Confronted with an increasingly complex regional security landscape, we must fend off external interference, seek common ground while reserving differences, proactively manage divergences and facilitate peaceful settlement of disputes."

First U.S.-Iran shuttle talks in months raise hopes for progress

Reuters
UNITED NATIONS/DUBAI

The first shuttle talks between the United States and Iran for months raised hopes on Wednesday that the adversaries could make progress towards ending the West Asia war, although neither side spelled out any change in its position.



Abbas Araghchi

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and U.S. envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner communicated through mediators on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York, the first such contacts since an interim ceasefire agreement collapsed in July.

"Steve and Jared had a very productive meeting today with mediators of Iran," U.S. President Donald Trump said. "I think there's a lot of momentum for them to make a deal. It's what we're hearing from everybody."

Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmaeil Baqaei said Tehran had engaged with the U.S. through a Qatari mediator in New York and conveyed conditions, including an end to the war on all fronts and a halt to U.S. "acts of aggression".

The diplomatic contact in New York caused backlash in Iranian media associated with hardliners.

Pak. shoots down 8 drones 'launched from Afghanistan'

Press Trust of India
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan's security forces on Wednesday shot down eight drones allegedly launched from Afghanistan after they entered Pakistani airspace, security sources said, as new clashes along the border added to tensions between the two neighbouring countries.

Four drones were brought down near the Torkham border and another four in mountainous areas near Kohat in northwest Pakistan's Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa province, the sources said.

The claims could not be independently verified.

Some of the drones were described as rudimentary models, with those detected near Kohat neutralised through a "soft-kill" operation.

Afghanistan denied Pakistan's claim, with the Taliban regime rejecting allegations that Afghan Taliban forces had attacked Pakistani positions.

Sport

Kushagra gets his century before Mulani runs through Australia-A

AUSTRALIA-A IN INDIA

Abhishek Saini
PUDUCHERRY

Shams Mulani picked up four wickets as Australia-A slumped on either side of a Jason Sangha counterattack and folded for 171, a massive 163 short of India-A's 334, on the second day of the first 'Test' at the Siechem Cricket Stadium here on Wednesday.

Sangha produced a 64-ball 46 (5x4, 1x6) after walking in at 37 for three, and a late recovery appeared to be the theme for the second day in a row. He began with consecutive sweep shots off Mulani (four for 67) after tea before riding the bounce against Tushar Deshpande and punching the pacer through point twice.



Mulani. CAP

Liam Scott took a leaf out of this playbook and ransacked 14 runs off Tanush Kotian in three deliveries. However, Scott was no match for Mulani, who floated a delivery full, got it to turn and had Scott caught behind. Two overs later, Sangha threw his wicket away in an attempt to clear the point fielder with a reverse sweep.

The spinners took the honours in the final session, but it was because of the quicks that Australia-A was behind the eight ball. Its top and middle orders, which boasted of five capped players, unravelled against lateral movement.

Sam Konstas was far from the hot-headed opening renegade, who had caught India by surprise during the last Border-Gavaskar Trophy. He put a price on his wicket and negotiated the early period. But Deshpande's delivery nipped in sharply and pinned him in front on 25.

Earlier, Kumar Kushagra (113, 240b, 12x4) checked his instinct and took up almost an hour to complete his seventh First Class ton off 202 balls.

Kushagra showed no intent of changing gears after his century, but would be ruing the approach. On a rapidly deteriorating pitch, his end was inevitable and it came when a Corey Rocchiccioli (four for 95) delivery pitched outside the off-stump line, spun and crashed into his leg stump.

The scores: India-A 334 in 117.3 overs (Sai Sudharsan 57, Kumar Kushagra 113, Tanush Kotian 69, Corey Rocchiccioli 4/95) vs. Australia-A 171 in 55.3 overs (Jason Sangha 46, Shams Mulani 4/67).

Lakshya stars as India u-19 complete sweep

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

After a couple of disappointing outings, Lakshya Raichandani stepped up when it mattered most. His unbeaten 110 (106b, 9x4, 3x6) helped India under-19 beat Australia under-19 by six wickets and complete a clean sweep in the three-match youth ODI series.



Clinical: The India under-19 team celebrates the youth ODI series win against Australia under-19. SHAYAN ACHARYA

Composed hundred

The India captain had failed to convert his starts in the first two games, but on Wednesday, Lakshya responded with a composed hundred at the Niranjan Shah Stadium.

He first added 58 with Aaryavir Sehwag, then 85 with Kushagra Ojha for the third wicket, keeping India firmly on course.

Chasing 255, India started briskly, with Aaryavir and Lakshya taking on an Australian attack. While Lakshya anchored the chase, Aaryavir struck five fours before mistiming a Jacob Pietz delivery to give Matthew Lough a catch at long-on.

V.K. Vineeth failed to get going, but Lakshya kept the chase moving. Even after Kushagra's dismissal, he held firm as Rajat Baghel provided a cameo of 34-ball-44 (5x4, 2x6).

Flat deck

Opting to bat on a flat deck, Australia made a strong start as Zed Hollick (87, 88b, 12x4) and Neel Patel (51, 71b, 1x4) added 62 for the second wicket. India came under pressure before local boy Aryan Savsani broke it by removing Hollick.

That opened the door for Indian bowlers. Mohit Ulva and Manal Chauhan claimed three wickets apiece as Australia lost wickets in clusters and failed to rebuild.

With the series already sealed, India rested a few regulars. However, with Lakshya leading from the front, it romped home with more than eight overs to spare.

The scores: Australia u-19 254 in 49.3 overs (Zed Hollick 87, Neel Patel 51, Blake Cattle 38, Mohit Ulva 3/43, Manal Chauhan 3/42) *lost to* India u-19 255/4 in 41.2 overs (Lakshya Raichandani n.o. 110, Aaryavir Sehwag 34, Kushagra Ojha 45, Rajat Baghel n.o., 44).

Toss: Australia; **PoM:** Lakshya; **PoS:** Yashbardhan.

SURREAL

This time I have fulfilled my Asian Games dream: Mirabai



PTI

I have dreamt of winning an Asian Games medal ever since I stepped into weightlifting. Something or the other happened before or during the Games, but this time I have fulfilled my dream. I am yet to decide on how to go about LA 2028. I will enjoy this medal for a while and then decide — Mirabai Chanu after winning silver.

BREAKING THROUGH

Jay Meena wins India's first-ever medal in soft tennis at Asiad



X@SAI

Jay Meena won India's first-ever soft tennis medal at the Asian Games, fetching a bronze after losing to Takuya Kurosaka in the men's singles semifinals. Taking part in his third Asiad, the 26-year-old produced a spirited fightback before losing 2-4 (3-5, 1-4, 1-4, 4-1, 6-4, 1-4) to the Japanese in a 45-minute clash.

NO SWEAT

Deepika scores nine as India women thrash Thailand



AHF

In-form drag-flicker Deepika Sehrawat extended her impressive run, scoring a record nine goals, as India thrashed Thailand 20-1 to register its third consecutive victory in Pool B of the Asian Games women's hockey competition in Kakamigahara on Wednesday. India, which is leading the group, will next play Japan on Friday.

GOLD IN SIGHT

Roshibina prevails over Thania, enters wushu summit clash



PTI

Indian wushu player Roshibina Devi, *in red*, will fight for gold at the Asian Games after defeating Indonesia's Thania Kusumaningtyas in the women's 60kg category in Nagoya on Wednesday. Roshibina, who prevailed 2-0 in the last-four contest at the Aichi Prefectural Martial Arts Hall, will face China's Xiaoyu Zhang in the summit clash.

Mirabai lifts silver, ends long wait for Asian Games medal

A total of 198kg helps the icon finish behind North Korea's Gum, who completes a hat-trick of titles with a World record 215kg effort; dream finally turns into reality for the 32-year-old Indian

ASIAN GAMES

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

Mirabai Chanu's place in the pantheon of Indian sporting greats was already secure. Olympic silver, World championship gold and multiple Commonwealth Games golds had ensured that.

So, just how much could an Asian Games medal matter? It turns out that it mattered to her for close to a decade and a half.

"I was thinking that I've won medals at the Olympics, World championships and Asian championships. Why can't I just win a medal at the Asian Games? I've been trying since 2014 but wasn't able to," said Mirabai after the final of the 49kg category.

North Korea's Ri Song Gum was in a class of her own. She won her third consecutive Asian Games gold and broke her own World record with a total of 215kg. The precocious Wijayana Diana, just 21, edged ahead of Mirabai after snatch, lifting 88kg to the Indian's 87kg. But in clean and jerk, Mirabai's strength made the difference. She had 107kg and 111kg while the Indonesian's best was 103kg. Mirabai's total of 198kg was enough for silver; she didn't even need a final attempt. It was the medal she had chased for eternity. The obsession finally become reality.



Weight off her shoulders: Mirabai beams with joy and pride after winning a medal at the Asian Games for the first time in her illustrious career. AP

Mixed bag for India at shooting range

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The Aichi General Shooting Range continued to reward Indian shooters with medals at the Asian Games here on Wednesday, just not the colour they desperately want; or the events that they expected to win in. The men's and women's skeet teams both finished third for a bronze while two of the three shooters in the final – Anantjeet Singh Naruka and Raiza Dhillon – fell agonisingly short, finishing fourth. Parinaaz Dhaliwal finished eighth in the individual event as India's wait for a shooting gold continues.

The shotgun arena made up for the disaster inside the firing range where Esha Singh and Suruchi Phogat had forgettable outings in the qualifying and failed to make the cut for the final while Manu Bhaker bowed out fifth in the 10m air pistol, an event the three of them have been dominating.

Naruka, the silver medallist from Hangzhou, missed two of his first four shots and despite trying his best, was unable to overturn the deficit.

In a field where the smallest of margins meant survival or elimination, it was not so much Naruka misfiring as his competitors not faltering. He scored 25 out of 28 shots, one behind bronze medallist Lee Meng-Yuan of Taiwan. Among the women, Raiza ended with 23 out of 28 while Parinaaz was the first to be eliminated.



Fruitful outing: The men's team of Mairaj, Naruka and Bhavtegh and the women's trio of Raiza, Maheshwari and Parinaaz made it to the podium. R.V. MOORTHY

Earlier, the men – Mairaj Ahmed Khan and Bhavtegh Gill along with Naruka – totalled 346 over three days of qualifying rounds to finish behind Qatar (353) and Kuwait (348).

The women's trio of Raiza, Parinaaz and Maheshwari Chauhan totalled 331 in the qualifying to finish third behind China (357) and Kazakhstan (336) for the first-ever Asian Games medal in women's skeet.

"It's a great feeling knowing that [we are the first] but I think the girls were in great form and I am hoping we will go with a few more medals, a little disappointed it not being a better colour," Maheshwari said. "The reason [for shotgun taking a backseat] is because we just didn't have high performing athletes and enough female athletes to begin with."

In pistol, Manu finished her qualifying round with 579 in third position. Esha began with series of 94 and 93 before picking up pace but a 95 and 96 in the last four series was never going to be enough, as she finished with 572 points with 12x. Suruchi, meanwhile, had three series of 94 each and one of 93 for a total of 568 with 12x to finish 26th.

In the final, Manu never really got going, starting with a 9.9 and ending with a 9.6 and just two 10.8s throughout her series of 18 shots. The biggest setback was an 8.9 on her eighth shot, which pushed her down into elimination zone and although she kept surviving, it was a matter of evading the inevitable.

'Feels like life is complete'

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

Asian athletes have dominated the women's 48kg and 49kg weight divisions for 25 years, winning 27 of 30 Olympic medals and holding all World records. And so, the desperation for an Asian Games medal is understandable for India's Mirabai Chanu.

"I'm feeling so happy... so light. *Bilkul weight hat gaya hai* (the weight has lifted completely)," she said after the win.

In the Hangzhou Asiad of 2023, Mirabai knew she had tweaked her hip during warm-up, but she gritted her teeth and loaded 117kg on the bar – the second-most she had ever attempted – as she bid for bronze.

However, she collapsed and had to be carried off stage. Previously, she'd fallen short in Incheon 2014 and missed the 2018 Jakarta edition with injury.

When the lightest Olympic weight division moved to 53kg, Mirabai – rather than bulking up for the LA Games after missing out at Paris – kept her weight down to focus on the podium in Nagoya.

"I had to work so hard to preserve myself to maintain my weight but this was so important for me."

With a silver medal in hand now, she exclaimed, "It feels *ki life complete ho gaya* (It feels like life is complete)," she said.



Winning smile: Mirabai added another silver to her collection. AP

INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY

A look at some Indian players/teams who will compete on Thursday (all times IST):

Athletics: Women's heptathlon (Anamika, Pooja), 6.30 a.m. onwards; 4x400m mixed relay (heats), 7 a.m.; final, 6.45 p.m.; Women's triple jump final (Niharika, Asha), 4.10 p.m.; Men's 100m heats (Gurindervir, Animesh), 4.30 p.m. onwards; Women's 10,000m final (Seema), 5.55 p.m.

Boxing: 1/8 finals: Men: 70kg: Sumit vs. Al-Sarray (Irq), 10.30 a.m.; Women: 51kg: Sakshi vs. Balkibekova (Kaz), 2.15 p.m.; 65kg: Parveen vs. Nozimova (Tjk), 2.45 p.m.

Fencing: Women's sabre individual (Bhavani Devi, Shreya), 8.15 a.m. onwards.

Gymnastics: Women's vault final (Pranati), 2.25 p.m.

Hockey: Men (Pool A): vs. South Korea, 11.30 a.m.

Kabaddi: Men (Group A): vs. Taiwan, 9.45 a.m. Women (Group A): vs. Japan, 4.15 p.m.

Shooting: 10m air pistol men individual qualification and team final (Aakash, Kamaljeet, Kedarling), 6.15 a.m.; individual final, 12.15 p.m.; Skeet mixed team qualification (Anantjeet, Parinaaz), 6.30 a.m.; final, 11.15 a.m.

Squash: Round-of-16: Mixed doubles: Suraj & Shameena vs. Velavan & Joshna, 8 a.m.; Women: Tanvi vs. Yhann (Sgp) and Anahat vs. Iynn (Sgp), both 10.30 a.m.; Men: Abhay vs. Laksiri (SL) and Veer vs. Sanjay (Mas), both 11.15 a.m.

Swimming: Heats (from 6.30 a.m.): Men: 50m butterfly (Benedicton); 4x100m freestyle relay; 800m freestyle final B (Aryan), 7.20 a.m.

Table tennis: Round 2: Women's doubles: Yashaswini & Diya vs. Setayesh & Mahshid (Iri), 6.30 a.m.; Sreeja & Syndrela vs. Bolor-Erdene & Burenjargal (Mgl), 7.10 a.m.; Round 1: Men: Manush vs. Wong (Mas), 8.35 a.m.

Wushu: Women's sanda 60kg final: Roshibina vs. Zhang (Chn), 6.10 a.m.



Tough going: Manu felt really sorry for not being able to win a medal in the 10m air pistol event. R.V. MOORTHY

Manu shooting through tears and challenges

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Manu Bhaker has had a rough two years since the Paris Olympics high, both on and off the range. The 24-year-old has had a couple of podium finishes in both 10m and 25m pistol each, a far cry from her own high standards, but it's the sudden death of coach, mentor and father-figure Jaspal Rana earlier this year that really broke her.

The Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games is her first competitive outing since Rana's passing and, expectedly, it wasn't easy for the youngster. Talking to the media after her fifth-place finish in the 10m air pistol, Manu began bravely, talking about the match before a mention of Rana finally broke open the shell.

"Of course I miss him, he was the best of the best, the Asian champion. When it came to Asian Games, I think he was the undisputed champion and we were really looking forward to Japan," she started before getting overwhelmed. Eyes welling up, unable to speak, she walked away, the floodgates finally making way for a torrent of tears gushing down her face.

It took a few minutes but she returned and her composure and decision to complete the interaction was perhaps the biggest hat-tip to Rana, ever the professional.

Talk about shooting and Wednesday's performance brought back a semblance of normality. "I genuinely tried my best and I really feel the performance was significantly better than the challenges I have been facing in my training in Japan. I feel really sorry I was not able to make it to the podium, I hope I will be able to do better," she said.

The training challenges she mentioned included sunlight affecting her focus during the pre-event training and inability to see the sides but she insisted that she was focused on the process.

THE INDIA SHOW

A look at some Indian performances on Wednesday:

Badminton: Men's team (semifinal): lost to China 1-3, bagged bronze.

Boxing: Men's 80kg (round-of-16): Ankush bt Hamsa (Brn).

Fencing: Table-of-16: Men's sabre individual: Gisho lost to Sarkissyan (Kaz) 11-15; Table-of-32: Men's sabre individual: Karan lost to Luo (Chn) 14-15; Women's foil individual: Ashitha lost to Gnoyeva (Kaz) 14-15; Mina lost to Jihee (Kor) 3-15.

Hockey: Women (Pool B): bt Thailand 20-1.

Kabaddi: Women (Group A): bt Iran 37-23; Men (Group A): bt Bangladesh 48-25.

Shooting: Finals: Women: 10m air pistol individual: Manu (fifth); Team: Fourth (Manu, Esha, Suruchi); Skeet individual: Raiza (fourth), Parinaaz (eighth); Team: Bronze (Raiza, Parinaaz, Maheshwari); Men: Skeet individual: Anantjeet (fourth); Team: Bronze (Anantjeet, Mairaj, Bhavtegh).

Soft tennis: Men (semifinal): Jay lost to Kurosaka (Jpn) 2-4, clinched bronze.

Squash: Round-of-32: Men: Abhay bt Arkarahirunya (Tha) 3-0; Veer bt Wakeel (SL) 3-0; Women: Tanvi bt Dami (Kor) 3-0.

Swimming: Men: 100m butterfly: Benedicton (13th overall), DNQ for final; 200m freestyle: Aneesh (17th overall) and Vedaant (19th overall), DNQ for final.

Table tennis: Mixed doubles (round-of-16): Harmeet & Yashaswini bt To & Lam (Hkg) 3-1; Manush & Diya bt Moosa & Aishath (Mdv) 3-0.

Weightlifting: Women: Final: 49kg: Mirabai (silver); 53kg: Gyaneshwari (eighth).

Wushu: Women's 60kg sanda semifinal: Roshibina bt Thania (Ina).



Falling short: While Satwik and Chirag did their job in doubles, the others faltered. REUTERS

Indian men shuttlers finish with a bronze after loss to China

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty won their doubles match but Lakshya Sen and Ayush Shetty faltered against higher-ranked opponents as the Indian men's team signed off with a bronze medal after losing 1-3 to China in the Asian Games semifinals here on Wednesday.

India had won silver at the last edition in Hangzhou, where it had lost to China in the final.

World No. 14 Lakshya, who had produced a stirring performance to take India to the semifinals, could not quite bring his A game, going down 16-21, 18-21 to world No. 6 Shi Yu Qi in the first singles.

Satwiksairaj and Chirag then produced a sensational performance to outwit reigning world champions Liang Wei Keng and Wang Chang 21-11, 22-20 to bring India back into the five-match tie.

A lot rode on young Ayush, but the world No. 20 could not maintain the required discipline and lost 19-21, 13-21 to world No. 12 Li Shi Feng in the second singles.

The responsibility to keep India afloat then fell on Hariharan Amsakarunan and M.R. Arjun, who took on the scratch pair of He Ji Ting and Liu Yi in the second doubles but they lost 16-21, 21-17, 9-21.

The results (semifinals): China 3 bt India 1 (Shi Yu Qi bt Lakshya Sen 21-16, 21-18; Liang Wei Keng & Wang Chang lost to Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty 11-21, 20-22; Li Shi Feng bt Ayush Shetty 21-19, 21-13; He Ji Ting & Liu Yi bt Hariharan Amsakarunan & M.R. Arjun 21-16, 17-21, 21-9).

INBRIEF



Bumrah and Hardik will be important in SA: Gambhir

With the upcoming West Indies ODIs at home, India will start its preparations for next year's 2027 World Cup in South Africa without Jasprit Bumrah (on Asian Games duty) and Hardik Pandya (still not fit to bowl 10 overs in ODIs). Head coach Gambhir said both seniors are very important in India's ODI scheme of things. "Both of them are going to be extremely important for us in South Africa. Very few teams have a player like Hardik who can bowl 10 overs for you, plus bat at No. 6 or 7 with that impact. There are no ifs and buts going to World Cup," Gambhir said.

Brook and Jacks power England past SL in first ODI

England extended its white-ball dominance over Sri Lanka by winning the first ODI at Chester-Le-Street on Tuesday by 89 runs on the back of a 67 by captain Harry Brook and a five-wicket haul by part-time spinner Will Jacks. It comes after England won the T20I series between the countries 3-0 last week. Jacks had also contributed with the bat by providing crucial late-innings runs for England with 46 not out before the hosts were restricted to 265. Contributions also came from opener Ben Duckett (32), Joe Root (44) and Jos Buttler (31).

The scores: England 265 in 48.1 overs (Brook 67, Jacks 46 n.o., Root 44, Colombage 3/44) bt Sri Lanka 176 in 37 overs (Wellalage 45, Kusal 42, Jacks 5/22).
Toss: England. **PoM**: Jacks.

Mohali to host India-A vs. Australia-A women's game

The only red-ball fixture between India-A women and Australia-A women beginning September 29 was, on Wednesday, moved to Mohali from Dharamshala after the rainy season damaged the outfield. "The Multi-Day fixture between India-A Women and Australia-A Women, scheduled to be played from September 29 to October 2, 2026, has been shifted from Dharamshala to Mohali. The venue change has been necessitated due to the impact of prolonged rainfall in Dharamshala on the outfield and the prevailing ground conditions," said the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) in a release.



Sports media professional Naveen Peter passes away

Naveen Peter, a sports media professional, passed away in Mumbai in the wee hours of Wednesday. He was 34. For almost a decade, Naveen was the digital head of a sports content company, which was in charge of the Olympics.com's India content. Prior to that, Naveen, an alumnus of the Asian College of Journalism in Chennai, had stints as a sports journalist with *Deccan Herald* and *Deccan Chronicle*.

Indian tennis player Somani gets four-year ban for doping

Indian tennis player Parikshit Somani was banned for four years (till September 2029) in a doping case on Wednesday after judges dismissed an explanation he gave that was similar to the case of Russian figure skater Kamila Valieva. The 26-year-old Somani tested positive for trimetazidine at a lower-tier event last year in Astana, Kazakhstan.

Aronian, Abhimanyu join field for Total Chess pilot event

A total of 24 elite players, including three Indians, will compete in the official pilot event of the Total Chess World Championship Tour in Budapest from November 10 to 20. Organisers said Levon Aronian, Jorden van Foreest, Abhimanyu Mishra and three others had been added to the line-up. The field, led by World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen, includes R. Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi and R. Vaishali, apart from Fabiano Caruana, Vincent Keymer and Anish Giri.

Total Chess is a FIDE-approved global event conceptualised by Norway Chess.

Tajinderpal eyes history as athletics contingent targets 20-plus medals

The shot putter is a favourite to complete a hat-trick of golds; Rohit and Yashvir lead the country's javelin charge in the absence of Neeraj

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Tajinderpal Singh Toor might have missed a chance to carry the Indian flag at the opening ceremony but the star shot-putter remains a favourite to raise it for the third consecutive time at the Asian Games as the track and field events kick off at the Paloma Mizuho Stadium here on Thursday.

While athletics icon Neeraj Chopra had a premature end to his season due to injury, Tajinderpal will be a certainty to finish on top. A two-time defending champion, the 31-year-old would be hoping to complete his hat-trick of gold medals and enter the history books as the first-ever Indian track and field athlete to stand on top of podium thrice in a row in a single event.



Strong contender: Tajinderpal will dig deep into his reservoir of experience to finish top of the podium. PTI

In the absence of Neeraj, Rohit Yadav and Yashvir will look to ensure an Indian among javelin medallists. Both have crossed 85m this season although the gold is likely to go to Sri Lankan Rumesh Pathirage, who has been the man to beat this year with three throws beyond 90m and tops the season's World list.

Among those looking to better the colour of their medal from the previous edition is long jumper Murali Sreeshankar and Gulveer Singh (10,000m), who won silver and bronze in their respective events. Sreeshankar has consistently crossed 8m this year while Gulveer has also been entered in 1,500m and 5,000m although it remains to be seen if he will participate in all three.

Defending champion steeplechaser Avinash Sable, returning from a long injury layoff, proved he was ready to compete again with an impressive outing at the Indian Athletics Final Series earlier this month.

National record holder decathlete Tejaswin Shankar will be eager to better his silver but will have to contend with local favourite Yuma Maruyama, who leads the Asian rankings with 8,321 points this season and won bronze last time around.

Quarter-miler Vishal T.K. and 3000m steeplechaser Parul Chaudhary can surprise the field on their day while triple jumper Praveen Chithravel and 100m hurdler Jyothi Yarraji have been struggling with niggles. Long jumper Ancy Sojan, the Asian leader at the moment, will also be hoping to carry her momentum to clinch gold.

The 75-member strong contingent is expected to shoulder the responsibility of propelling India's medal tally and is targeting at least 25 podium finishes. India won 29 in the last edition, but injuries and inconsistent form have tempered expectations.

India's hunt will begin with Asha Ilango and Niharika Vashisht in triple jump on Thursday although a medal looks tough. Also in action on Thursday would be Seema in 10,000m and the 4x400m mixed relay team, the latter expected to bring home the first medal from athletics.

Indian open team back to winning ways; women outclass Germany

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

The rest day seemed to have helped both the Indian teams at the Chess Olympiad in Samarkand. The defending champion India scored badly-needed wins in the open and women's sections in the seventh round on Wednesday.

After the loss to host Uzbekistan in the previous round -- their first in the tournament -- the Indian men should be relieved that they could defeat England 2.5-1.5.

Nihal loses again

It was the wins by R. Praggnanandhaa and D. Gukesh over Nikita Vitiugov and Daniel Howard Fernandez respectively that nullified Nihal Sarin's second straight defeat, this time to Luke McShane.

Arjun Erigaisi drew with Michael Adams.

Uzbekistan has maintained its sole lead after scoring a crucial 3-1 win over China.

The home team has 12 match points, two more than India and four others - the Netherlands, Germany, Azerbaijan and Armenia.



Third eye: Gukesh follows the women's match after his win.



Dominant show: Divya played her part in India's facile victory over Germany. FIDE

In the women's event too, India is in joint second place, but just one point less than the leaders China and Kazakhstan who have 13 each. India is tied for the second position with Bulgaria, Georgia, Armenia and Mongolia.

Four rounds remain. The Indian women should take a lot of confidence into their remaining matches after their crushing 3.5-0.5 win against Germany. Koneru Humpy,

Divya Deshmukh and B. Savitha Shri all won their games, while R. Vaishali drew.

The results (seventh round):
Open: India bt England 2.5-1.5 (R. Praggnanandhaa bt Nikita Vitiugov; Arjun Erigaisi drew with Michael Adams; Nihal Sarin lost to Luke McShane; D. Gukesh bt Daniel Howard Fernandez).
Uzbekistan bt China 3-1; Armenia drew with USA 2-2; Germany bt Turkiye 3-1; Netherlands bt Bulgaria 3.5-0.5; Azerbaijan bt Greece 3.5-0.5; France drew with Uzbekistan (2) 2-2; Hungary bt Australia 2.5-1.5; Serbia bt Kazakhstan 3.5-0.5; Poland bt Sweden 2.5-1.5; Slovakia bt Iran 2.5-1.5; Czech Republic bt Lithuania 2.5-1.5.
Women: India bt Germany 3.5-0.5 (Koneru Humpy bt Dinara Wagner; R. Vaishali drew with Elisabeth Paehtz; Divya Deshmukh bt Hanna Marie Klek; B. Savitha Shri bt Lara Schulze).
Uzbekistan bt Slovenia 3.5-0.5; China drew with Kazakhstan 2-2; Georgia bt Poland 2.5-1.5; Bulgaria bt Ukraine 3-1; Armenia bt Azerbaijan 2.5-1.5; Mongolia bt France 2.5.1.5; USA bt Switzerland 3-1; Netherlands bt Turkiye 3.5-0.5; Cuba drew with Serbia 2-2; Canada bt Hungary 2-2.



Magnetic presence: Indian All Stars players try to take the ball off Ronaldinho. THULASI KAKKAT

Brazil Legends thrill the crowd during win

FOOTBALL

P.K. Ajith Kumar
KOCHI

Long before kick-off, the fans thronged the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium. Many of them wore the blue shirt of India, and there were several in yellow, too.

Hawkers were there as well, selling jerseys and plastic horns. And if you wanted, you could get the flags of India or Brazil painted on your face. There was indeed excitement in the air on Wednesday night. You would be pardoned if you thought the build-up was for a competitive match, and not the one featuring former football stars. The legends from Brazil didn't disappoint their fans.

And there were quite a few goals, too. In the match dubbed the Return of the Titans, Brazil Legends beat Indian All Stars 4-3.

The highlight was an old-fashioned hat-trick by Fernandinho, who was superb right through. Brazil's other goal was scored by the man most people came to watch – Ronaldinho. The winner of the Ballon d'Or in 2005 scored from the penalty spot. And it was a nice, firm kick.

He wasn't the only player on the field to have won the Ballon d'Or and World Cup. There was Rivaldo, too. C.K. Vineeth netted two goals, including the one that gave the home team a 1-0 lead. The other was scored in the dying minutes by Ashim Biswas.

Moliya to lead Rest of India u-23 against TN

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Priyanshu Moliya will lead the 15-member Rest of India u-23 squad against Col. C.K. Nayudu Trophy champion Tamil Nadu in a four-day match, to be held at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium, here from October 1 to 4.

The squad, picked by the BCCI junior cricket committee, has Angkrish Raghuvanshi as vice-captain, while Aravelly Avanish Rao and Mayank Verma are the two wicketkeepers.

Ganesh Suthar, Chandraraj Rathod, Nikhil Giri and Chetan Sharma form the pace-bowling group, while Emanjot Singh Chahal, Varun Singh Bhuie and G. Sumith provide the spin options.

The squad: Priyanshu Moliya (Capt.), Angkrish Raghuvanshi (Vice-capt.), Ayush Jethwa, Manan Bhat, Digvijay Patil, Raxit Mehta, Aravelly Avanish Rao (wk), Mayank Verma (wk), Emanjot Singh Chahal, Chandraraj Rathod, Varun Singh Bhuie, Ganesh Suthar, Nikhil Giri, Chetan Sharma, and G. Sumith.

LIVE TELECAST

Asian Games: Cricket (Men): Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10.30 a.m. & 5.30 a.m. (Friday)
South Africa vs Australia: First ODI, Star Sports 2 & JioHotstar, 1.30 p.m.
England vs Sri Lanka: Second ODI, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 5 p.m.
Football: Nations League, Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 5 & LIV, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Friday)
Asian Games: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Friday)

Anupama aims for glory in billiards at Commonwealth championship

Tarun Shastry
CHENNAI

After a semifinal finish in the UK Women's Snooker Championship earlier this month, Anupama Ramachandran is turning her attention to billiards.

The reigning IBSF World Snooker champion will lead India's challenge in English billiards at the Commonwealth Cue Sports Championships, to be held in Ahmedabad from October 7 to 10.

"I've been playing a couple of snooker tournaments and did well in the event in the UK. I've been feeling more confident and feel that I'm in good touch," Anupama told *The Hindu* in a virtual interaction. "Obviously, I'm playing billiards, which is a little different. Although the games are similar, they require different skills and a different thought process. So, I'll have to put in the hours on the billiards table."



Anupama. FILE PHOTO

> I was struggling a little with my timing and cueing, and Yasin sir helped me make a few changes

The 23-year-old has also been testing herself in Heyball over the last year and a half, competing at the Asian and World championships.

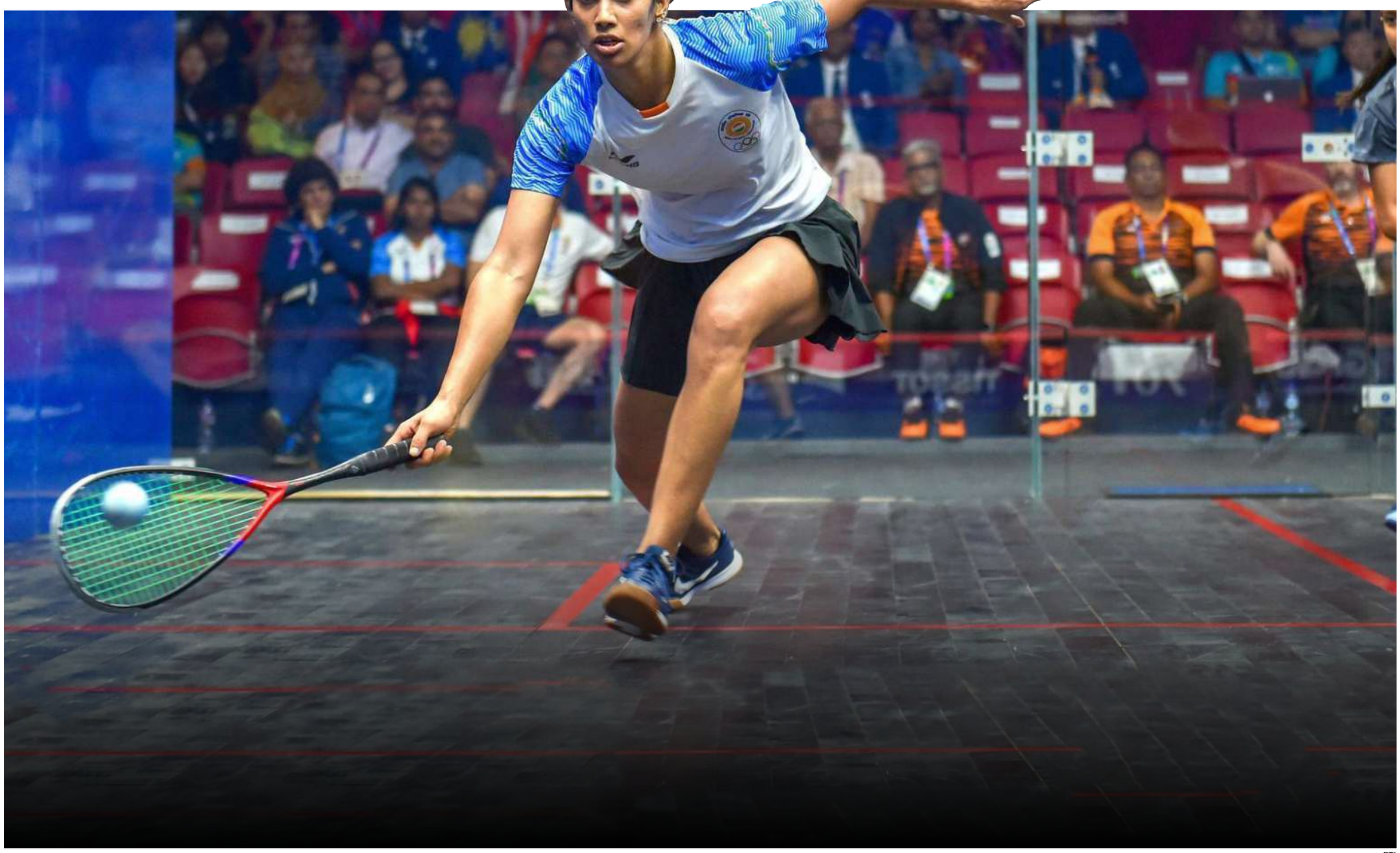
"Because I've played snooker, the potting aspect does help me. But there's a lot of tactical play and the way you think about the game is a little different. It's about playing more and gaining experience," she said.

For Anupama, the Ahmedabad event also represents a significant step for cue sports in the country, particularly with billiards being included in the Commonwealth.

"India has a great legacy in billiards with the likes of Wilson Jones, Michael Ferreira, Geet Sethi and Pankaj Advani. We won five medals at the previous edition in Mauritius, and hopefully we can improve on that this time."

Anupama has also been fine-tuning her technique under former Asian champion Yasin Merchant, with particular emphasis on her timing and cueing.

"I was struggling a little with my timing and cueing, and Yasin sir helped me make a few changes. It's a slow process, but I can already see the difference in my game. I feel more comfortable with my timing and my shots now, and that has been the major change," she said.



PTI

Forty-year-old Joshna is competing at the Asian Games for an Indian record seventh time; the veteran, still chasing an elusive gold, is keen to add to her tally of five medals at the quadrennial showpiece

INTERVIEW

Joshna Chinappa

K. Keerthivasan

For nearly a quarter of a century, Joshna Chinappa has stood like a colossus on the squash court. At 40, Joshna doesn't seem to have lost her fighting spirit and tenacity.

She knows she is ageing, has tweaked her training module accordingly and has remained one of the finest players in the country a good 24 years after she made her Asian Games debut in Busan in 2002.

Taking part only in the women's team and mixed doubles (with Velavan Senthilkumar) events at the ongoing Aichi-Nagoya Games, the veteran from Chennai is more than eager to bag another medal.

Seeded third in mixed doubles, the Velavan-Joshna duo will take on the fellow Indian pair of Suraj Chand and Shameena Riaz in the round of 16 after having received a bye in the first. In the women's team event (Anahat Singh, Tanvi Khanna and Shameena are her teammates), the No. 3-seeded India has been drawn in Pool C alongside Japan, China and Iran.

On the PSA World Tour, Joshna's career has overlapped with three generations of elite squash players. Most of her contemporaries – Nicol David (43), Laura Massaro (42), Jenny Duncalf (43), Alison Waters (42) and Annie Au (37) – have long retired, underlining her remarkable longevity.

Placed 73rd in the chart, Joshna is India's third-highest ranked woman behind the 18-year-old Anahat Singh (World No. 17) and Tanvi Khanna (World No. 71). A winner of 11 PSA titles, she continues to perform at a high level and is determined to make another significant contribution at the Asian Games. Everyone who has followed Joshna's career knows how meticulous and disciplined she is in her preparation.

Saurav Ghosal, a former men's top-10 player, perhaps perfectly summed up her longevity. "First and foremost, she really, really loves the game. She's immensely talented, but she has also worked tirelessly on every aspect of her game to remain at the top for as long as she has.

"I hope that she comes back from the Asian Games with quite a few gold medals."

In this interview with *The Hindu*, the five-time Asian Games medallist reflects on her longevity, debut at the 2002 Asiad, most cherished memories from the continental showpiece, and the motivation that continues to drive her at the highest level. Excerpts:



You are competing at the Asian Games for the seventh time, becoming the first Indian sportsperson to achieve the feat...

I honestly didn't think I would make a seventh Asian Games appearance. I just focused on my training and tournaments. It definitely feels great to be a part of the Indian team again.

You have won five medals at the Asiad, but a gold remains elusive. What are the chances of clinching the yellow metal?

We have a strong team and yes, it would be great to win another medal. I have always taken my matches one at a time, so I am as prepared as I can be.

Looking back, which was your best Asian Games?

Performance-wise, 2018 would probably be the best I played (singles bronze and silver in women's team).

How special was it to be on the Asiad stage as a teenager?

As a 15-year-old, it was amazing to see so many superstars of Indian sport in one Village. There is one memory that stands out from my first Games in Busan in 2002.

We are usually given our official India clothing and I would obviously wear that to play and train. But in my down time at the Village, I wore a personal T-shirt at the food hall a couple of times, and legendary hockey player Dhanraj Pillay told me that I had to be in my India clothing. It's something we should always be proud of. It was inspiring for me because it made me aware that I am always representing my country at the Games on and off court... that has stayed with me till now.

You were part of the top 10 in the PSA rankings thrice. When you got there for the first time as a 29-year-old in July 2016, how did you feel?

The top 10 is a special place. It took a lot of effort, especially coming back from my ACL surgery, and years of work with my team.

There were top players like Nour El Sherbini, Raneem El Welily, Nouran Gohar, Camille Serme and Massaro. So how difficult was it to get or stay there?

I definitely played with a bunch of incredibly talented and hardworking women who were greats of the game. Playing with them, beating some of them and making it to the top 10 was one of the best moments of my career.

What did the win over Nicol – an eight-time World champion – in the 2018 Asian Games women's team semifinals mean to you?

It meant a lot because I have always looked up to her and admired how humble she is as a champion. I really wanted to do it for the team. She is one of the greatest of all-time. Coming in from the disappointment of losing singles and making the team final after beating a strong team like Malaysia was amazing!

You had a on-court rivalry with Dipika Pallikal but shared a bond and went on to bag medals at the Asian Games and Commonwealth Games...

We have had some amazing wins together for India and I will always think of my time competing with her and playing alongside her as inspiring and motivating.

You have won 11 Tour titles. You had to wait 10 years to earn your latest crown, at the Japan Open in 2025. Why did it take so long to end the drought?

I didn't expect to win in Japan. It felt great to win after ages, especially since I beat girls who were in their early 20s and were ranked way higher than me. The difference now is that I am a lot more relaxed towards competing and I am more performance-oriented than result-focused. Maybe it just helps me enjoy and appreciate these moments more and play better squash.

Every title I have won has come at different times of my life: they all have come after years of training and preparation. Each one has been rewarding.

How have you been able to sustain at this level for nearly quarter of a century? Is it down to mental sharpness, your focus on fitness, outlook towards life or all three?

The main reason I am able to still compete today is my parents. My team, including my coach, strength and conditioning trainer, physios, nutritionist and sports psychologist, has been amazing. The support from my sponsors, the State government, Central government and Squash Rackets Federation of India has been great. It takes a lot to compete at the highest level and it's only possible because of the amazing people I work with. I do work a lot on the mental and physical side of the game besides recovery. I really appreciate and worship my body, which has been so incredibly supportive.

How much has the sport evolved since you began playing?

So much! At the international level, the game has become so much more physically demanding, faster and skilful. Domestically, we have many players playing, and the level has improved a lot. Seeing so many PSA (World Tour) events happening in India is wonderful because many of our players benefit tremendously by playing in them and watching the top players competing here in India.

Squash will make its debut at the 2028 LA Olympics...

Such exciting times ahead for squash. India has a great chance to do well.

You had knee injuries/surgeries in 2011 and 2023? How challenging was it physically and mentally to come back from those?

I tore my ACL on the right knee in 2011 and was out of the game for a year. I was encouraged to quit playing and get into coaching. I had no financial support but I moved to Bombay (Mumbai) and worked with a really good Egyptian physio and trainer – Ahmed Youssef. When I got back to playing, coach Ritwik Bhattacharya helped me. Some of my best victories came after that surgery because I believed I had a lot more to offer to the game and I really wanted to play for India again.

And in 2023, during the last Asian Games, I found that there was no cartilage in my right knee and it also needed a surgery. But I did the surgery more for quality of life as it was painful to do basic things like driving, getting out of bed comfortably and jogging. My surgeon, Dr. Jagdeesh, who did my ACL surgery, also did my cartilage surgery and told me that I would be able to compete again.

So I moved to Bengaluru and worked with Yash Pandey at Peak Performance. I got back on court after five months of rehab. I decided to train and play for a couple more years to see if I could play the Asian Games.

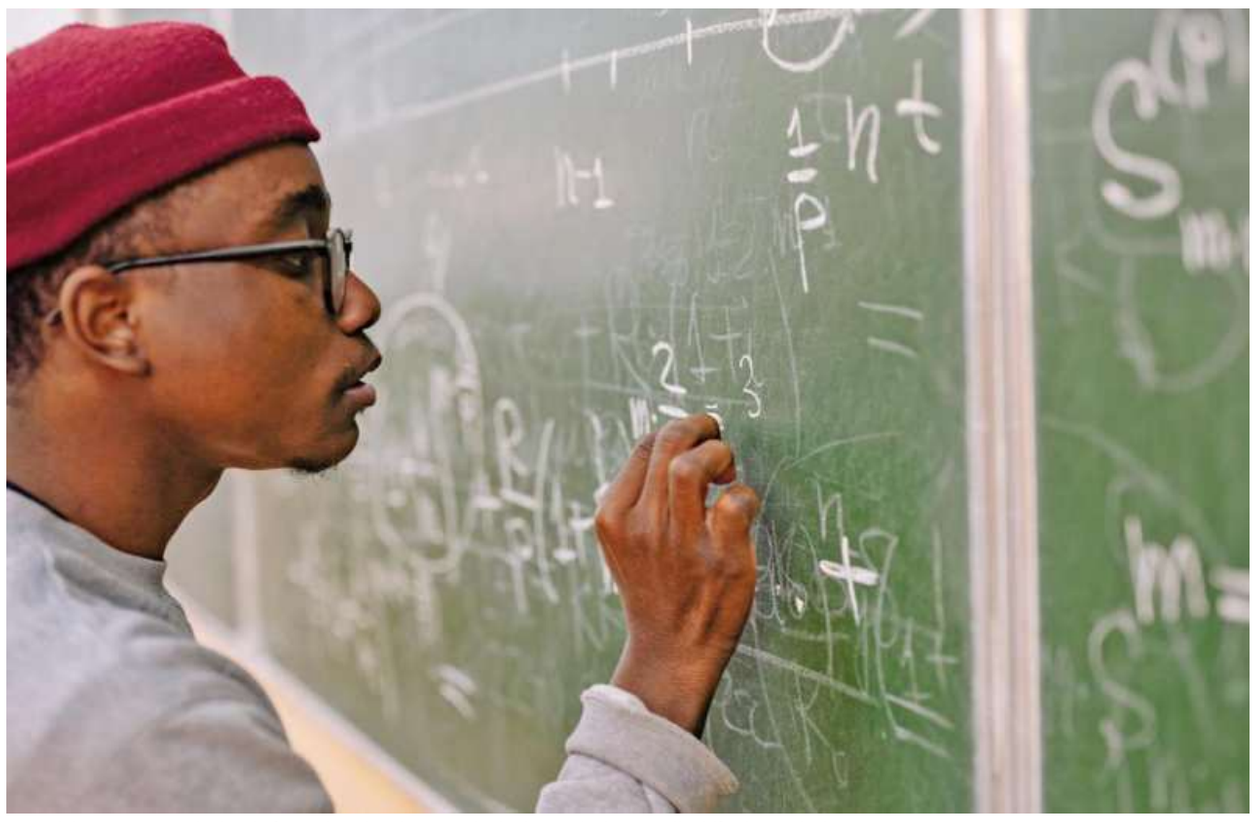
How big a support has your father been and what are your memories of playing with him at Madras Cricket Club?

My dad is the main reason I am here today. He introduced me to the game as he was a squash player himself. I have the best memories of tagging along with him to the MCC and playing squash with him, other MCC members and my friends. He was my coach and motivator for a very long time, especially when I was a junior.

As AI marches on math research, scholars ponder the future

A flurry of AI-generated proofs has left mathematicians in various emotional states; some are cautiously excited, some are critical of the AI companies' commercial motives behind their relentless mining of open maths problems and are insisting on more careful regulation, and some are left asking existential questions

Rohini Subrahmanyam
BENGALURU



AI models operating at the level of a grad student have made thinking, which is usually difficult, much cheaper. Representative image. YAN KRUKAU/UNSPLASH

On July 20, mathematician Levent Alpöge, who works at the artificial intelligence company Anthropic, dropped a casual post on X. He claimed the company's advanced large language model Claude Fable 5 had produced a counterexample to an 87-year-old open problem in algebraic geometry called the Jacobian conjecture. By working on it during the FIFA World Cup final, AI had helped disprove a conjecture that many mathematicians had been working on for decades – and the world got the news about it in a short social media post.

This was not AI's first major mathematical conquest. On May 20, OpenAI released a series of posts on X claiming that its internal, general reasoning model had found a solution to the planar unit distance problem, an open problem proposed by Hungarian mathematician Paul Erdős in 1946. Many expert mathematicians who verified the solution realised that if humans had solved this on their own, the result would be out in a top journal.

The floodgates were opened. On August 1, OpenAI announced that its newest model 'Astra' had solved ten more open maths problems, three of which were from the legendary list of Erdős problems that included the unit distance conjecture. AI had been solving other less exciting Erdős problems and International Math Olympiad questions even before tackling the unit distance problem – but this latest set had many people sit up and take notice. As Columbia University theoretical computer scientist Henry Yuen posted, "I did not just hear about these problems from my friends or from seminars. I feel their importance in my bones; I deeply care about the answers to these questions."

In the most significant advance yet, on September 8, OpenAI announced that an unreleased internal model had solved a Millenium Prize Problem called the Navier-Stokes existence and smoothness problem – one of six heavily researched maths problems with a million-dollar bounty.

Spurred by rumours that their rival Anthropic might be closing in on a solution, OpenAI went all guns blazing, deploying 10,000 autonomous AI agents and millions of dollars' worth of computing power and found a solution in 88 hours.

But even as it rattles the maths world, the achievement is already shrouded in controversy. On September 7, New York University mathematician Tristan Buckmaster revealed he and Mr. Alpöge had been personally building on previous work by other mathematicians and working on a solution for a simplified version of the problem using similar methods for about a year, and they were assisted by both Anthropic and OpenAI models in their efforts.

While OpenAI has denied specifically accessing the duo's data, the company noted "they cannot rule out that de-identified data from [the duo's] usage of their products helped improve their models."

This flurry of AI-generated proofs has left mathematicians in various emotional states. Some are cautiously excited about how the fast-improving models can help them in their research. Some are critical of the AI companies' commercial motives behind their relentless mining of open maths problems and are insisting on more careful regulation. And some are left asking existential questions: if AI can solve important problems at this alarming rate, what role will mathematicians play in the future?

The rise of AI has generated an unprecedented level of discourse and introspection among mathematicians about what they really value and enjoy about doing maths, with one sentiment prevailing among them. As MIT mathematician Andrew Sutherland put it: "I think it is going to change the way mathematicians do research going forward."

Andrew Booker, a number theorist in the University of Bristol, had been stuck solving a central problem in number theory with a collaborator for about ten years. Called the converse problem for L-functions, they would work on it for a few weeks, give up out of frustration, and periodically return to it. "And suddenly, that all changed in April," he said.

Dr. Sutherland had gifted Dr. Booker a gift subscription to Claude Max, finally pushing him to use Claude Code, which is Claude's AI coding agent, on the problem. He was not expecting much – but the AI model wrote 30,000 lines of code and about 200 pages of maths in the first week, "an amount I would write in a year," he said. Although they have not completely solved the problem yet, "within two weeks we had made more progress than in the previous five years."

The frontier AI models released in the last year have become a lot better at reasoning compared to the older, more sycophantic versions. "It works almost eerily like a human," said Dr. Booker. "It reasons things out in the same way. It makes the same mistakes as a human." It needs expert guidance in the hard problems, but it can, on occasion, find something very obvious that humans completely missed.

"They are not perfect, but they are operating at the level of a grad student, with the difference that they are a hundred times faster than grad students," Dr. Booker said. "It is like having a grad student army, if you like."

That feels powerful because it has made thinking, which is usually difficult, much cheaper. Humans might have several ideas but cannot work on all of it to the same extent the way AI can. "And if it continues improving [at this] pace, it will not be long before it matches the skill set of the best mathematicians in the world," Dr. Booker said.

Dr. Sutherland got interested in using machine learning and AI in mathematics research in early 2022, before the large language models era. As a computational number theorist, he realised that AI/ML tools could help find interesting patterns in large amounts of data. Researchers slowly realised that the models were like a "more intelligent search engine", he said, being able to sift through literature and find useful connections between vastly different fields of maths.

But a major turning point for him was when Claude's Opus 4.5 came out late last year, which is an AI agent that can code, produce proofs, and formalise them – i.e. convert them to a computer science-based language (like Lean), which can be verified by a machine. In the last six months or so, the newest AI tools are "both good at writing code and very good at math, and that combination has been very, very valuable," Dr. Sutherland said. "I am still the one driving the process, but having these tools lets me go faster and see further than I could before. It is an exciting time from that perspective."

'It writes like an alien'

Nevertheless, he understands why these powerful AI tools can be disconcerting, especially for theoretically inclined mathematicians who enjoy solving very hard, complicated problems. Instead of thinking deeply about a problem for many years, one can now get an answer from a model immediately with a few well-placed prompts, he said.

Some maths students are worried about whether they will have jobs in the future, and whether mathematicians will become obsolete if AI models become better than them at

Recent frontier AI models have become a lot better at reasoning compared to older versions; while they need expert guidance in hard problems, they can, on occasion, find something very obvious that humans completely missed

solving problems. One of the winners of the 2026 Fields Medal, Jacob Tsimerman, has stopped taking graduate students on because he is uncertain about whether the traditional mathematical career he trains them for now will even exist in a few years. (He has since moved to OpenAI to work on AI safety).

AI's proofs are not perfect, however. The models tend to gloss over the hard parts of the proof, Dr. Sutherland said – which is usually the key, intuitive step that humans may struggle with and ultimately gain insight from if they tackled it on their own. Also, models' proofs are incredibly hard for humans to understand: as it rapidly borrows concepts and vocabulary from vastly different mathematical fields and learns on the go, it tends to make up weird terminology as it's working. It also does not cite all the previous research it is building on.

"It writes like an alien sometimes," Dr. Booker said. "If left unchecked for too long, you may be left with text that is completely incomprehensible. It is [not] meaningless gibberish – the AI understands it – but it is so far removed from standard terminology that I can no longer parse it."

Dr. Booker eventually learnt that he must supervise the AI assistant to keep it grounded, prune its long arguments, and rewrite some of its proofs to add more intuition, to keep it less dry and more appealing to human readers. Researchers have called OpenAI's proof write-ups "horrendous"on X, implying that the companies are not communicating their results in a way that others can gain insights from them.

There is, however, an unsettling way to circumvent mathematicians entirely: AI can rapidly generate and formalise its own long, incomprehensible proofs, which can then be machine-verified.

In an essay titled 'Mathematics in the Age of AI', the Australian-American mathematician and 2006 Fields Medal winner Terence Tao discussed how the field could shift from "proof scarcity to proof abundance", and with more proofs than humans can deal with, this may also end up in "proof indigestion". "Something that is happening with these large language models releasing these proofs one after another is we have not had time to chew and understand these proofs," Tata Institute of Fundamental Research, Mumbai, computer scientist Prahladh Harsha said. A nightmare situation, Columbia University mathematician Michael Harris said, is that AI will generate a long, incomprehensible proof of the Reimann hypothesis – one of the most famous open problems in mathematics – and humans will just have to accept it without understanding it.



OpenAI CEO SAM ALTMAN

"It is a very confusing time right at this moment, because nobody knows what the rules are," said Dr. Booker. Many mathematicians are worried that the AI tools are developing at a rate faster than human institutions can adapt.

Dr. Sutherland, however, does not think mathematicians will become obsolete. There is still value in humans being able to understand the proof on their own, to learn not just "what is true but why it is true," he said. With infinitely many mathematical problems and only a finite number of computers, he does not think that mathematics will be "solved" by AI. But with AI trivialising the easier problems, "the bar to make a significant contribution is going to rise," Dr. Booker said.

Students may need to be trained differently, as "maybe pure, problem-solving ability is not going to be as highly valued in the future as it was in the past," Dr. Sutherland added. Improving the exposition of AI-generated proofs or using AI assistance to tackle and understand hard problems may become more important. But people passionate and excited about maths should still pursue it, he said, willing to work with students who engage with AI tools in their research. Current students' careers may look very different from their own advisers', he noted, but that does not mean they will not have one.

'Generous with ideas'

After a 2025 conference titled 'Mechanization and Mathematical Research' at Leiden University, a small group of the participants stayed in touch and drafted a set of much-needed guidelines for responsible AI use. They came to be called the 'Leiden Declaration on Artificial Intelligence and Mathematics'. With many distinguished endorsers, including Dr. Tao, the June 2026 declaration has emerged as an important step in understanding how AI tools affect mathematics, with recommendations on how to engage ethically with them.

Dr. Harris and University of California San Diego mathematician Karthik Ganapathy, two members of the working group involved in drafting the declaration, are both critical of how AI companies do not release a detailed account of how exactly their internal models have solved a problem – in most cases, the result is declared as a press release or as an unceremonious social media post.

"The best mathematicians are very generous with their ideas," Dr. Ganapathy said, unlike giant AI corporations that are incentivised to not be open about their methods. This lack of transparency also makes it hard to ascertain how much the advanced mathematicians working at AI companies played a role in the proof.

Harvard University mathematician Nina Zubrilina agreed that the companies should ideally be releasing the prompts they used in the discovery process to get more insight into the model's reasoning. "There is a certain amount of intentional mysticism around how they arrive at certain results, which I find counterproductive for understanding something deeper," she said.

Ideally, these solutions should lead to a deeper theory or "set the groundwork for something bigger." Simply resolving a decades-old conjecture "is not really the right metric for success," she added. "It makes for good headlines, but it is not necessarily what is valued kind of the most for people who do mathematics for a living," she said, while also noting that AI might improve at theory-building in the future.

Maths as cultural capital

Although he may use AI for routine work, Dr. Ganapathy wants to think on his own to preserve the pleasure of doing pure maths. "It is not like we want to completely offload all aspects of [doing mathematics] to a machine," he said, saying how no mathematician is "asking OpenAI to build a model which can reason this way." Pure maths problems might eventually lead to applications only if humans are able to think together and apply the insights they learn in innovative ways, and AI using opaque methods to produce impenetrable proofs will hinder this process.

"Corporations have no material interest in abstract mathematical research," said Dr. Harris, who thinks there are two reasons driving the AI companies: they think rigorous mathematical reasoning may bring the models closer to artificial general intelligence – a vague, hypothetical intelligence that will match and/or beat humans in all cognitive tasks; and demonstrable mathematical prowess may make investors happy. Academics' "goals are trying to understand the math [and] science behind these [proofs], but [the companies'] goals are to show that they have built very smart models and monetise that," Dr. Harsha said.

Also, not everyone can access the frontier AI models: students in India do not have access to them the way U.S. students do, Dr. Harsha said. On July 29, OpenAI announced that it will allow 1,00,000 scientists, mathematicians, and engineers to access its frontier models for free – but Indian, Russian, and Chinese institutes were excluded from this list, most likely because of geopolitical tensions.

India, with no frontier model of its own, unlike the U.S. or China, might struggle to keep pace with theoretical scientific advances at this rate, even though the large country had previously enjoyed an edge over others in the theoretical sciences. "Mathematics is certainly one way that [AI companies are] trying to gain cultural capital, which will inevitably help them change policy," said Dr. Ganapathy.

Dr. Harris thinks that instead of treating AI as an inevitable natural phenomenon, mathematicians must recognise it as a product of giant, commercially driven corporations. Are they then comfortable with these corporations dictating the direction of mathematical research?

"The interests of mathematics are protected by mathematicians and not by the corporations," Dr. Harris said. "As long as the mathematicians are free from external interference or attempts to shift the funding strategies in the direction more beneficial to the investors, I think they can be trusted to use the AI technology in a way that is in general interest."

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THE GIST

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